

# Family and the Community

## Book 12

### Unit 2

#### An Expanding Conversation on the Education of Children

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**PRE-PUBLICATION EDITION  
MATERIAL IN DEVELOPMENT**

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**VERSION 1.1.1.PP**

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Ruhi Institute

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The Ruhi Institute is an educational institution functioning under the aegis of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of Colombia. Its purpose is to develop human resources dedicated to the spiritual, social and cultural progress of the Colombian people. Over the decades its materials have increasingly been used by national Bahá'í communities in all parts of the world.

The approach to curriculum development followed by the Ruhi Institute differs significantly from the traditional one of design, field-testing and evaluation, carried out in a linear fashion. The first step in writing any set of materials is taken, rather, when an experience is created at the grassroots in performing some act of service in response to the exigencies of the development of a community. Materials emerge out of this experience and become an expression of it. They are, on the one hand, a record of the learning that occurs in applying the teachings of the Bahá'í Faith in a particular area of service and, on the other, an instrument for the systematization of that learning. The approach has been described in the following terms in the small volume *Learning About Growth: The story of the Ruhi Institute and large-scale expansion of the Bahá'í Faith in Colombia*:

Once an educational need is identified, a small group of people, working at the grassroots, consult among themselves, develop a set of ideas for educational activities, and put them into practice. The results of this practice are reviewed, evaluated and consulted upon; in light of this consultation, a modified set of educational activities is put into practice, and subjected to reflection that leads to further modification and revision. At no time in this process of curriculum development does action await the final preparation and evaluation of educational materials. At every stage, educational activities proceed with the best materials at hand, in the conviction that it is only through practice and reflection, both pursued in light of the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh, that more appropriate curricula can gradually evolve. Yet, this is not a setting in which a few individuals are developing materials for their own use, and it does become necessary at some point to finalize the structure and content of each unit so that it may be used with confidence by others. The decision to release a final version of the materials for a given course is made simply when it is noticed that modifications are becoming negligible. It is important to note that the various aspects of this process of consultation, action and reflection are carried out parallel with one another, and not performed in a linear sequence which would be inherently artificial.

As the use of the materials of the Ruhi Institute has become more widespread, the development process has drawn increasingly on experience worldwide in applying the teachings to the life of humanity. Though in practice the process today can take divers forms, depending on the nature of the material in development, there are generally three stages that give rise to what is considered the final published edition.

### *1. Initial Outline (IO)*

At this stage a course or text contains the basic concepts and a set of passages from the Bahá'í writings that, taken together, are believed to achieve the educational objective in question. For some time, this initial outline of ideas is used by small groups of individuals in the field, as part of the efforts to elaborate effective course content.

### *2. Alpha Version (AV)*

As action progresses, the material is refined and begins to reflect new experience gained, incorporating ideas that arise out of it. Not infrequently, certain concepts are amended, new passages from the Bahá'í writings added, or a series of simple exercises introduced to facilitate

comprehension of a topic or to help develop an important skill or attitude. Through this process, a consolidated course or text emerges which is generally regarded as the “alpha version”.

### 3. *Pre-Publication Edition (PP)*

In time it is determined, generally on the basis of the integrity of the content, to make the course or text more widely available as a pre-publication edition. Through its continued use, it becomes apparent when a section needs to be moved or an exercise or two revised. Several successive versions may appear. Gradually, however, fewer and fewer modifications are required to achieve the intended purpose of the course or text, and the material, at this stage, goes for publication.

We are happy to make available to selected organizations and institutions one of the units that has reached the pre-publication stage. It is the second of three units of a book currently in development entitled *Family and the Community*. You are encouraged to send us any comments you have on the basis of your experience in using the course content.

Ruhi Institute  
Colombia

## NOTES FOR THE TUTOR

This is the second of three units currently in development by the Ruhi Institute that will make up the twelfth book in its main series. It seeks to enable participants to propagate a conversation on the education and upbringing of children among families in villages and neighborhoods where the processes of the expansion and consolidation of the Faith are gathering momentum and where a sense of community life has emerged. The premise underlying the unit is that, while parents are primarily concerned with the sound development of their own children, they share a common responsibility with every member of the community for the well-being of all the youngsters in a village or neighborhood.

It is envisioned that the study of the unit and the act of service to which it gives rise will further advance in participants the capabilities they have been developing ever since they entered the institute process—that is, the capabilities which enable them to engage in meaningful and uplifting conversation. What should be acknowledged is that, by the time individuals reach this point in the sequence of institute courses, they will have already gained a good deal of experience in paying visits to homes and in conversing with members of households on a variety of topics and themes, including but not limited to those addressed in the second and third units of Book 2, as well as concepts embedded in the programs for the spiritual education of children and for the spiritual empowerment of junior youth. Such visits have become as integral to the life of each participant, then, as they have to the pattern of community life that distinguishes every center of intense activity. The tutor should appreciate that this affects both the way the content is presented in the unit and how participants are expected to make use of it.

The unit picks up the story of Alejandra from Book 2 and proposes that three years have passed, during which the community-building efforts in her neighborhood have intensified greatly. Now a young mother, Alejandra decides with a small group of friends, including her husband, to try to gain insights into what the Bahá'í teachings say about the education and upbringing of children, insights the group plans to share in conversation with others in the neighborhood, especially with parents of the children and junior youth who are participating in the educational programs of the institute. The unit asks participants first to deepen, as do Alejandra and her friends, their own understanding of each of the themes thus addressed. To this end, they are encouraged to reflect on certain relevant concepts in light of guidance enshrined in the writings and to consider their implications for the education of children, aided by a set of corresponding exercises.

As should become apparent to the tutor, participants will have already encountered many of the ideas and quotations presented in the unit in previous courses. Yet, their organization into themes related to raising children will enable participants to draw fresh insight into the meaning of the quotations and will further enhance their understanding of the implications of the teachings for their own lives. It can well be imagined that those who study the unit will be predominantly young people, either single or newly married, actively engaged in the processes of expansion and consolidation and committed to the material and spiritual progress of their villages and neighborhoods. The reflections they undertake in this and the preceding unit, concerned with Bahá'í marriage, will serve as a means of preparation for them as they enter the stage of life where they are ready to start forming families—an indispensable element of the future civilization conceived by Bahá'u'lláh. It would not be unreasonable to assume that in the strivings of more and more such young adults we will catch the first glimpses of a family life that conforms to His teachings as depicted in these pages.

That said, though the content of the unit will serve to increase the understanding of participants, this is by no means the primary objective. To share the gems of wisdom we discover in the ocean of Bahá'u'lláh's Revelation is a most profound source of joy. "With the hands of renunciation draw forth from its life-giving waters," are the words of Bahá'u'lláh studied in Book 2, "and sprinkle therewith all created things, that they may be cleansed from all man-made limitations and may approach the mighty seat of God, this hallowed and resplendent Spot." Like Alejandra and her companions, participants are encouraged to initiate, concurrent with their study, a series of visits to homes for the purpose of exploring passages from the writings with families and interested individuals in their village or neighborhood. It is envisaged that the kind of conversation promoted by this act of service, in deepening understanding of concepts and principles fundamental to the programs for the spiritual education of children and for the spiritual empowerment of junior youth, will go far in reinforcing the aims of those programs. It is quite possible that, in some instances, several families may decide to gather together regularly for the purpose of discussing the themes addressed in the unit. Devotional meetings, community gatherings and festivals, as well as certain other activities held at the local level, might also prove to be suitable spaces for this purpose. In this unit, then, study and action run parallel to each other, and the tutor will be challenged to bring to bear on the former the insights and experience being gained by participants in the latter.

It may be helpful to mention here that the unit is essentially organized into three parts. In the first few sections, participants become familiar with the purpose of the unit, identify families and individuals they might visit, either individually or in teams, and consider how they will go about inviting them to take part in a series of conversations. They then explore, in the next several sections, the broad subject of education, examining its various dimensions and its importance to the proper development of the human being. The unit continues with an exploration of the role of the family in the emergence of a just and harmonious civilization, including how the family must conduct itself and what should distinguish the relationships that bind its members.

As to the nature of the conversation being promoted, it is at once more structured and more exploratory than those in which participants have engaged up to now. That the themes addressed from visit to visit build on one another, to an extent, lends a degree of structure to the overall conversation and to the direction in which it moves. Yet, in the main, every discussion should be viewed as an opportunity for all involved to examine the reality faced by families and to analyze issues and concerns in light of the writings. To undertake the kind of exploration envisioned, participants are asked to consider the circumstances of families visited and determine how they will draw on the content studied in each section to build a conversation and which quotations from the selection provided they will share. It is hoped that the participants' engagement with the themes, including their deliberations on the exercises, will enable them to make sure the conversation they facilitate flows between the abstract and the concrete—sometimes helping family members to explore the practical application of an educational concept and at other times the spiritual principle underlying a concrete course of action. What is required of participants reflects the degree to which those who have reached Book 12 will have advanced in the requisite capabilities—not only in the amount of knowledge they have acquired but also in the qualities, attitudes, and skills they are developing.

Finally, it should be recognized that most of those who take part in discussions around the themes treated in the unit will already have some knowledge of the Bahá'í teachings; yet it is quite likely that many of them will not have had any previous opportunity to study systematically and reflect on a set of quotations from the writings as described above. Thus the conversation should be seen, above all, as a means of extending the edifying influence of the Word of God to a wider

circle of the population—to individuals who will, in turn, through their daily interactions, begin to propagate even further afield ideas and concepts gleaned from the writings and who will contribute, in this way, to the creation of an environment conducive to the spiritual and intellectual development of children.





## SECTION 1

In the first unit of this book, we undertook an exploration of the writings of the Faith that shed light on the nature of Bahá'í marriage. There is no doubt that a sound understanding of the principles involved lays a strong foundation upon which a harmonious and healthy family life can be built. Naturally, then, the next topic to which we will turn our attention is the raising of children.

Our deliberations will focus on the spiritual development of children within the home. It is hoped, however, that the study of this unit and the actions to which it gives rise will contribute to a wider goal—that of a community assuming more and more responsibility for the education of all its youngsters. To this end, it is possible to envision a conversation unfolding among many families and residents of a given neighborhood or village on this matter of great importance. How such a conversation is initiated, promoted, and sustained is the central concern of this unit. In your study of the second and third units of Book 2 and your subsequent participation in systematic programs of visits to homes in your community, you have no doubt advanced in those capabilities needed to enter into meaningful and uplifting conversation. This unit will assist you in further enhancing these capabilities by familiarizing you with relevant teachings on a number of interconnected themes related to raising children, to be explored in a series of conversations with parents and others.

## SECTION 2

In the third unit of Book 2, we were introduced to Alejandra, a young person in her third year of university, who was living with her parents in the home where she was raised. When we left our story, a growing nucleus of friends—Alejandra, her brother and parents, and a young couple new to the neighborhood—were meeting regularly to reflect on the progress of their efforts to advance the process of community building. Alejandra was serving as the animator of a junior youth group, and Beatrice, the granddaughter of an older couple, Mr. and Mrs. Sanchez, who had recently joined the Bahá'í community, had begun to assist her. The Sanchezes were deepening their knowledge of the Faith by exploring various themes with Alejandra during her visits to their home.

Let us imagine that three years have passed. In this relatively short span of time, the community-building process has, through perseverance and consistency on the part of the friends, gained considerable momentum. A steadily increasing number of people are embracing the Faith. Regular devotional gatherings are being held in eight homes. Two junior youth groups have completed their study of the texts central to the spiritual empowerment program, and the participants are now proceeding through the main sequence of institute courses. Several new junior youth groups have been established, as have a few children's classes. The animators and teachers, assisted by the cluster coordinators, have strengthened bonds of friendship with the parents of the youngsters and with other members of their households. As a result of all these efforts, there are now some fifty families which, in one way or another, are taking part in an ongoing conversation around the various stages of the educational process being promoted by the institute in the neighborhood.

Alejandra has earned her undergraduate degree and married a young man named Martin. They have recently become parents and are learning how to care for and nurture their daughter. The young couple that had moved to the neighborhood some years back, Daniela and Francisco, have twin boys aged three, and the two couples are good friends. They often talk about issues related to raising children, and, on one occasion, they decide to get together regularly to study the teachings

of the Faith on education. They become very excited about the prospects of their study. They are certain that, as they find relevant passages in the writings and reflect on the gems of wisdom enshrined in them, they will gain many insights, insights they can then share with others in the neighborhood interested in the education and upbringing of children. Alejandra immediately thinks of Martin’s brother and his wife, who are newly married and hoping to begin a family soon. Daniela and Francisco have befriended the couple that lives next door to them, and this subject has already started to come up in their conversations. Alejandra mentions that she will speak to her friend Maribel about their idea. Maribel is teaching Bahá’í classes for children in the fourth grade, and she has told Alejandra that some of the youngsters’ parents are eager to engage in more in-depth conversation on the general subject of raising children. “Perhaps Maribel and I could visit one or two households together with this in mind,” she suggests.

In the account that follows you will see how, from such a modest effort to share with a few others insights gleaned from the writings, a conversation on the importance of the education and upbringing of children can be set in motion and expand. For now, you may wish to take a moment to identify those you know in your own village or neighborhood who might be interested in participating in such an ongoing conversation with you.

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### SECTION 3

When the two couples next meet, Maribel joins them. She has enthusiastically accepted Alejandra’s invitation to participate in their small effort and to accompany her friend on visits to the homes of a few parents that, Maribel is sure, will welcome an opportunity to engage in the conversation envisioned. Thinking about her interactions with parents as a children’s class teacher, Maribel suggests that one of the first topics they might explore is the weighty responsibility parents and the community shoulder with respect to the education and training of children. She has brought along a selection of relevant passages, which the small group studies and eventually organizes into a sequence of ideas:

Educating children is one of the most critical tasks before us. The future of our community, of our society, and ultimately of the world depends on the type of adults they will grow up to be. The Universal House of Justice provides the following guidance:

**“Children are the most precious treasure a community can possess, for in them are the promise and guarantee of the future. They bear the seeds of the character of future society which is largely shaped by what the adults constituting the community do or fail to do with respect to children. They are a trust no community can neglect with impunity.”<sup>1</sup>**

So sacred is our obligation to care for this trust that Bahá'u'lláh states in the Kitáb-i-Aqdas:

**“He that bringeth up his son or the son of another, it is as though he hath brought up a son of Mine; upon him rest My glory, My loving-kindness, My mercy, that have compassed the world.”<sup>2</sup>**

To appreciate the significance of this obligation, we should ponder on the following words of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá in which He describes the fruits of proper education:

**“I pray in behalf of these children and beg confirmation and assistance for them from the Kingdom of Abhá so that each one may be trained under the shadow of the protection of God, each may become like a lighted candle in the world of humanity, a tender and growing plant in the rose garden of Abhá; that these children may be so trained and educated that they shall give life to the world of humanity; that they may receive insight; that they may bestow hearing upon the people of the world; that they may sow the seeds of eternal life and be accepted in the threshold of God; that they may become characterized with such virtues, perfections and qualities that their mothers, fathers and relatives will be thankful to God, well pleased and hopeful. This is my wish and prayer.”<sup>3</sup>**

Should a child not receive the necessary care and training, the consequences, both for the individual and for society, are grave:

**“Every child is potentially the light of the world—and at the same time its darkness; wherefore must the question of education be accounted as of primary importance.”<sup>4</sup>**

**“Man is even as steel, the essence of which is hidden: through admonition and explanation, good counsel and education, that essence will be brought to light. If, however, he be allowed to remain in his original condition, the corrosion of lusts and appetites will effectively destroy him.”<sup>5</sup>**

**“A child is as a young plant: it will grow in whatever way you train it. If you rear it to be truthful, and kind, and righteous, it will grow straight, it will be fresh and tender, and will flourish. But if not, then from faulty training it will grow bent, and stand awry, and there will be no hope of changing it.”<sup>6</sup>**

Thus does ‘Abdu’l-Bahá call upon us:

**“... the beloved of the Lord and the handmaidens of the Merciful should, with all their heart and soul, educate children and instruct them in the school of virtue and perfection. Nor should they tolerate in this regard the least neglect or shortcoming.”<sup>7</sup>**

In answer to this call, communities in villages and neighborhoods are striving to shoulder the collective responsibility for the education of children, in part, by holding classes that seek to develop spiritual susceptibilities in them from a tender age. Yet, no matter how essential are such classes for children, there is more that goes into “developing their characters and shaping their personalities”. The necessity exists as well, the Universal House of Justice explains, for a community as a whole “to show a proper attitude towards

children and to take a general interest in their welfare.” In this vein, the House of Justice tells us:

**“The friends should candidly accept that the spiritual and social environment they create in their communities and their homes has a profound influence on shaping the thought and character of young people . . .”<sup>8</sup>**

Naturally, then, the inhabitants of a village or neighborhood would be eager to discuss with one another concepts and ideas found in the Bahá’í teachings related to the education and upbringing of children. It is not unreasonable to imagine that, as more and more families and individuals are drawn into such an ongoing conversation, the spiritual and social environment created in the community and in the home will be increasingly conducive to the healthy progress and development of the next generation.

As you can see, in their first visit to each of the families and neighbors they have identified, the small group of friends will make explicit the importance of opening up a conversation in the neighborhood about the education of children. With the other participants in this course, reflect on the above paragraphs and discuss the main ideas presented, in order to become thoroughly familiar with them. You can then carry out the exercises below. They will help you consider how you might go about introducing the ideas in these paragraphs to a few individuals and families, in such a way as to elicit their participation in the envisioned conversation.

1. Read the following three statements drawn from the first passage above. What do they tell us about the responsibility a community has for its young members? Write down some of your conclusions in the space provided.
  - Children are the most precious treasure a community can possess, for in them are the promise and guarantee of the future.
  - Children bear the seeds of the character of future society which is largely shaped by what the adults constituting the community do or fail to do with respect to children.
  - Children are a trust no community can neglect with impunity.

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2. In educating the younger generation, whose children are we bringing up? \_\_\_\_\_  
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3. According to the third quotation above, when children are properly trained and educated, they will be able to
- give \_\_\_\_\_ ,
  - receive \_\_\_\_\_ ,
  - bestow \_\_\_\_\_ ,
  - sow the seeds of \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ ,
  - become characterized with such \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ .
4. To help you reflect on the consequences of neglecting our responsibility to educate and train the young, complete the following statements based on the above quotations:
- a. The question of education must be accounted as of primary importance because \_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ .
  - b. Through admonition and explanation, good counsel and education, the essence of the child will be brought to light; otherwise \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ .
  - c. If a child is reared to be truthful, kind, and righteous he or she will grow straight, just as a young plant, and will be fresh and tender and will flourish. Without suitable training, \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ .
5. A significant way in which the community is fulfilling its responsibility towards children is through the provision of regular classes for their spiritual education. We envision a day when the majority of the children in every village and neighborhood of the cluster in which we reside will benefit from such classes. Describe how bonds of unity and fellowship in a community are strengthened through concern for its children and through collective action for their proper training.
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## SECTION 4

The next time the two couples and Maribel come together, they are excited to talk about what took place during their initial meetings with the friends visited, all of whom expressed an eagerness to participate in a series of conversations on the education of children. Most of the discussions lasted much longer than expected, in one case, more than two hours. Gina seemed to be particularly keen. She is one of the parents with a child in fourth grade visited by Alejandra and Maribel. Gina knows many mothers in the neighborhood who, she indicated, might be interested in participating as well. What became clear from some of the questions she raised is that it would be helpful to elaborate in the next visit on the family and its relationship to the community. Alejandra and Maribel have come prepared with several relevant quotations from the writings, which the group happily discusses. Here is the sequence of ideas they eventually decide to share with the friends they will soon visit again:

Each of us is a member of a family, and at the same time we are all members of a community. We are convinced that, at a fundamental level, the progress of one is inseparable from the progress of the other. The following passage written by the Universal House of Justice seems to apply as much to the family unit as it does to other groups:

**“The welfare of any segment of humanity is inextricably bound up with the welfare of the whole. Humanity’s collective life suffers when any one group thinks of its own well-being in isolation from that of its neighbors . . .”<sup>9</sup>**

The family is not an isolated unit; it derives benefits from, and contributes to, the development of the community. The House of Justice explains:

**“And just as the viability of every cell and every organ is contingent upon the health of the body as a whole, so should the prosperity of every individual, every family, every people be sought in the well-being of the entire human race.”<sup>10</sup>**

Naturally, we each need to tend to the well-being of our family. Moreover, every parent is eager to create a loving, stable, and united environment for the upbringing of children. Yet, in thinking about this responsibility, we must heed the warning of the Universal House of Justice that “excessive attention to family interests can lead, however unwittingly, to a narrow social outlook, one that is ultimately detrimental to the broader community.” The education children receive at home should help them gain a vision that is world-embracing. The House of Justice states:

**“ . . . through education children gradually learn to look beyond their own interests to those of their family. With yet further training, they recognize the importance of respecting the interests of others and see as a sacred obligation service to their**

**neighbors. At a higher level still, proper education can help children to broaden their horizons and set their sights on the advancement and glory of their nation. And when their breadth of vision expands even wider, they will undoubtedly come to see the progress of the entire human race and the furtherance of the true interests of all the peoples of the world as a guiding purpose of their lives. The family unit provides an environment within which such lofty and world-embracing principles can be taught and nurtured. It is the matrix in which generation after generation can be reared in the conviction that the well-being of the individual is inextricably bound to the progress and well-being of others.”<sup>11</sup>**

To acquire a world-embracing vision, an individual should be nurtured from childhood within a household whose members are concerned not only with their own well-being but also with the progress of their community and their nation—nay, the entire human race. A question we may ask ourselves, then, is “What can a family do to promote the progress of the community to which it belongs?” At the outset, we should recognize that, in many parts of the world, certain social and cultural values have led to the disintegration of community life, while in others the customs of collective life linger but have lost their once unifying influence. Under such circumstances, to raise capacity within a local population to take charge of its own spiritual, social, and intellectual development is no small task. But we are dedicated to this task, and in village after village, in neighborhood after neighborhood, there are so many of us now working together to build vibrant communities, communities that are, the House of Justice tells us, to be

**“characterized by tolerance and love and guided by a strong sense of purpose and collective will, environments in which the capacities of all components—men, women, youth and children—are developed and their powers multiplied in unified action.”<sup>12</sup>**

Every family, then, is welcome to participate in the activities that drive this process of community building. Families, for example, host regular gatherings for prayer and worship, enhancing, in this way, the devotional character of the community and helping to infuse a new spirit into the collective life of its inhabitants. The House of Justice writes of those engaged in such service:

**“Responding to the inmost longing of every heart to commune with its Maker, they carry out acts of collective worship in diverse settings, uniting with others in prayer, awakening spiritual susceptibilities, and shaping a pattern of life distinguished for its devotional character.”<sup>13</sup>**

Another way families contribute to community life is through the support they lend to classes for the spiritual education of children. The House of Justice reminds every community:

**“Let them never forget the imperative to tend to the needs of the children of the world and offer them lessons that develop their spiritual faculties and lay the foundations of a noble and upright character.”<sup>14</sup>**

Families provide such support by offering their homes as venues for classes, by helping to facilitate their smooth functioning in various ways, and, in general, by promoting the establishment of classes for successive grades in their village or neighborhood. Some

parents assist teachers with one or another activity during lessons, while a few, who are so inclined, are trained as teachers themselves. That every child, regardless of his or her background, may benefit from a proper education is the primary concern of all:

**“Aware of the aspirations of the children of the world and their need for spiritual education, they extend their efforts widely to involve ever-growing contingents of participants in classes that become centers of attraction for the young and strengthen the roots of the Faith in society.”<sup>15</sup>**

The young ones in a family, too, contribute to the vibrancy of community life. The spiritual education they receive from a tender age nurtures in them the qualities, attitudes, and habits that selfless service to the community requires. As they grow and receive proper training and guidance, their capacity to engage in acts of service is enhanced. Their participation, starting at the age of 11 or 12, in the junior youth spiritual empowerment program plays a critical role in preparing them for a life of service. In collaboration with other members of their junior youth group, and with support from an older youth serving as an animator, they learn to design and carry out projects that try to improve some aspects of the life of the village or neighborhood in which they reside. For such projects to succeed, groups often draw on the talents of the members of the community and the assistance families render.

What we should realize in this respect is that

**“when efforts to multiply and strengthen children’s classes and junior youth groups foster a community’s sense of ownership for the education of younger generations, they lead to an increase in collective capacity to implement even more complex endeavors.”<sup>16</sup>**

Families are also indispensable to the success of efforts that aim to improve the material and intellectual life of the community:

**“A natural outcome of the rise both in resources and in consciousness of the implications of the Revelation for the life of a population is the stirrings of social action. Not infrequently, initiatives of this kind emerge organically out of the junior youth spiritual empowerment program or are prompted by consultations about local conditions that occur at community gatherings. The forms that such endeavors can assume are diverse and include, for example, tutorial assistance to children, projects to better the physical environment, and activities to improve health and prevent disease.”<sup>17</sup>**

Yet another especially important way parents contribute to the progress of a community is by participating in an expanding conversation on the education of the young—a conversation that will enable them to achieve a shared understanding on how to raise the next generation and that will weave strong bonds of affection and solidarity in their village or neighborhood and strengthen its social fabric. The House of Justice advises us:

**“Social consciousness is heightened naturally as, for example, lively conversations proliferate among parents regarding the aspirations of their children . . .”<sup>18</sup>**



Gradually, then, every family within the population begins to derive benefits from a process of collective transformation and from a “culture of mutual support” founded on “fellowship and humble service”, one that “lays great emphasis on education and learning”.

As before, reread the above ideas and passages and spend time reflecting on the sequence in which they are presented. You may then carry out the following exercises, which will help you think through how you will go about discussing with others the relationship between the family unit and the community.

1. We are convinced that a family will advance when it is concerned not only for the well-being of its own members but for the welfare of the entire community and the progress of human civilization. Sadly, certain ideas that contradict this conviction have become prevalent in many societies. If we are not careful, such ideas can inadvertently shape our worldview. Below are a number of statements that convey ideas of this kind. Discuss them in your group and write in the spaces provided statements that convey more appropriate thoughts. One example is provided to assist you.

- a. My family comes first.

We have to teach our children to care as much for other families as they do their own.

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- b. Let others take care of their own children; my child deserves the best.

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- c. If the members of every household focus their energies and efforts solely on improving the conditions of their own family, the community as a whole will prosper.

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- d. The world is in turmoil, and I cannot do anything about it. My only real responsibility is to my family.

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- e. If my child spends a lot of time helping others, he or she will never accomplish his or her own goals.

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- f. Loyalty to family transcends all other allegiances.

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- g. Our family should become prominent so that others respect us.

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- h. As parents, if we raise our children to be good, we have done our part in contributing to the betterment of society.

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- i. How can our family think about the education of the children in the community when we barely have enough financial resources to take care of our own affairs!

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- j. If I pay too much attention to service to the Cause my family life will suffer.

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2. The social arrangement that has traditionally existed in many places is that of an extended family, in which aunts, uncles, and grandparents share responsibility for raising children along with the parents. Regrettably this kind of social arrangement is becoming less and less common around the world. But even in regions where the extended family still exerts some influence and its members rely on one another, to varying degrees, they are not isolated from the rest of society. Ideally, then, whatever the circumstances, families within a locality would collaborate to ensure the well-being of all the young ones in the community. What possibilities might exist in your locality to strengthen bonds of fellowship and solidarity among a few families that live close to one another? In what way could they support one another in caring for children?

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3. In today's world, ties that for centuries held community members together are being eroded, and even the family unit is in crisis. With the other members of your group, discuss how the community-building activities—classes for children, groups of junior youth, circles of study open to all, devotional gatherings, and visits to homes—help us resist the forces that contribute to alienation and align ourselves with constructive processes.

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4. Now, in light of your discussion above, describe the ways in which families in your neighborhood or village are working to advance the material and spiritual progress of the community. How can the conversation suggested in this unit help raise their awareness of the significance of their contribution to the community-building process?

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## SECTION 5

Before we continue our story, it may be worthwhile for you to pause and consider the posture you will assume in seeking to initiate and sustain a conversation on the education and upbringing of children, largely, though not exclusively, among families in your village or neighborhood. As you know from your study of Book 2 and your experience since then, our thoughts and attitudes when we visit the homes of families have a profound effect on the degree to which such visits strengthen the spiritual and social fabric of the community. With the other members of your group, discuss what might result from each of the following:

- Giving the impression that you want to teach families how to raise their children
- Making comments that are critical of the way parents are raising their children
- Insisting on what you feel is the “right” way of doing things
- Creating the expectation among families that there is an immediate solution for every challenge they face in raising children
- Approaching conversation in a consultative spirit
- Seeking to explore, together with those you are visiting, relevant ideas from the writings and their implications for family life and for the relationship between family and the community
- Adopting a posture of learning

Of course, since those early days when you completed Book 2, you have gained—in addition to considerable experience in paying visits to homes and in conversing on matters of spiritual import—a great deal of knowledge of the Faith, both from your study of later books in the sequence and from your own personal exploration of the writings. Much of what you study here, then, will draw on ideas and concepts that by now are not only familiar to you but have also become integral to your thinking.

With such a breadth of experience and knowledge, you may now wish to prepare to visit one or two of the families or individuals you identified in Section 2. The ideas in Section 3 will assist you in inviting the members of each household to participate in the series of conversations envisioned, while those in Section 4 will enable you to discuss in your next meeting with them the relationship between the family and the community. The following questions may help guide you in your preparations: How will you begin the discussion? Which quotations from each section will you share—all of them or a small selection? What points do you hope will come across? How do you imagine your own understanding of the themes under discussion will expand through the exchange of ideas with others and through the experience and knowledge they bring to the conversation? It is suggested that you write down your thoughts in a separate notebook, in which you could also record your reflections after the visits. If possible, you should continue in this way with each subsequent section, creating as you proceed through the unit an experience in parallel with the small group of friends in the story.

## SECTION 6

Gina was greatly inspired by her conversation with Alejandra and Maribel on the community and the family. Ever since her son started to attend Bahá’í children’s classes more than three years ago, Gina and her husband have watched in appreciation as different kinds of activities started to multiply in the neighborhood and the sense of community gradually became more pronounced. She is happy that her family is benefiting from this development.

For some time now, Maribel and the two couples—Alejandra and Martin and Daniela and Francisco—have been thinking about where to begin their exploration of the Bahá’í teachings on

education in earnest. They recall from their study of Book 1 two paragraphs that seem to contain certain fundamental convictions that would inform any approach to the education and upbringing of children:

**“Having created the world and all that liveth and moveth therein, He, through the direct operation of His unconstrained and sovereign Will, chose to confer upon man the unique distinction and capacity to know Him and to love Him—a capacity that must needs be regarded as the generating impulse and the primary purpose underlying the whole of creation . . . Upon the inmost reality of each and every created thing He hath shed the light of one of His names, and made it a recipient of the glory of one of His attributes. Upon the reality of man, however, He hath focused the radiance of all of His names and attributes, and made it a mirror of His own Self. Alone of all created things man hath been singled out for so great a favor, so enduring a bounty.**

**“These energies with which the Daystar of Divine bounty and Source of heavenly guidance hath endowed the reality of man lie, however, latent within him, even as the flame is hidden within the candle and the rays of light are potentially present in the lamp. The radiance of these energies may be obscured by worldly desires even as the light of the sun can be concealed beneath the dust and dross which cover the mirror. Neither the candle nor the lamp can be lighted through their own unaided efforts, nor can it ever be possible for the mirror to free itself from its dross. It is clear and evident that until a fire is kindled the lamp will never be ignited, and unless the dross is blotted out from the face of the mirror it can never represent the image of the sun nor reflect its light and glory.”<sup>19</sup>**

After reviewing the above passage, the small group decides to gather quotations from the writings that shed light on some of the ideas it presents. Eventually, through their study, they identify several themes around which they might organize their next few conversations. The first is that of human potential and the role of education in realizing it:

When we think about the education of children in our community, one of the immediate questions we ask ourselves is: “How can the young be assisted in developing their full potential?” In trying to answer this question, we need to keep in mind certain fundamental convictions. First, every human being has the capacity to know God and to love Him, a capacity that is the very purpose underlying the whole of creation. Second, of all created things, only the human being has been endowed with the potentiality to reflect all the names and attributes of God. Finally, without the guidance of His Manifestations, we would be unable to realize the vast potential with which we have been so bountifully invested by our Creator. The following quotations from Bahá’u’lláh’s Writings give us insight into these convictions:

**“Thou didst wish to make Thyself known unto men; therefore, Thou didst, through a word of Thy mouth, bring creation into being and fashion the universe. There is none other God except Thee, the Fashioner, the Creator, the Almighty, the Most Powerful.”<sup>20</sup>**

In the human being **“are potentially revealed all the attributes and names of God to a degree that no other created being hath excelled or surpassed.”<sup>21</sup>**

**“Through the Teachings of this Daystar of Truth every man will advance and develop until he attaineth the station at which he can manifest all the potential forces with which his inmost true self hath been endowed.”<sup>22</sup>**

A number of images help us envision the potential latent within us—a mine filled with precious gems, a seed from which will appear a mighty tree, a candle and a lamp, both of which have the potential to emit light; Bahá'u'lláh tells us, “Neither the candle nor the lamp can be lighted through their own unaided efforts.” All of these images point to the inherent potential of the human being that can only be released through proper education and training. Bahá'u'lláh states:

**“Man is the supreme Talisman. Lack of a proper education hath, however, deprived him of that which he doth inherently possess. Through a word proceeding out of the mouth of God he was called into being; by one word more he was guided to recognize the Source of his education; by yet another word his station and destiny were safeguarded. The Great Being saith: Regard man as a mine rich in gems of inestimable value. Education can, alone, cause it to reveal its treasures, and enable mankind to benefit therefrom.”<sup>23</sup>**

And ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us:

**“We must strive with energies of heart, soul and mind to develop and manifest the perfections and virtues latent within the realities of the phenomenal world, for the human reality may be compared to a seed. If we sow the seed, a mighty tree appears from it. The virtues of the seed are revealed in the tree; it puts forth branches, leaves, blossoms, and produces fruits. All these virtues were hidden and potential in the seed. Through the blessing and bounty of cultivation these virtues became apparent. Similarly, the merciful God, our Creator, has deposited within human realities certain latent and potential virtues. Through education and culture these virtues deposited by the loving God will become apparent in the human reality, even as the unfoldment of the tree from within the germinating seed.”<sup>24</sup>**

We know that spiritual qualities such as love, generosity, justice, and compassion are the most brilliant gems that lie hidden within the human reality; they represent the most excellent fruits of human existence. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá advises:

**“Certainly, certainly, neglect not the education of the children. Rear them to be possessed of spiritual qualities, and be assured of the gifts and favors of the Lord.”<sup>25</sup>**

There are also unique endowments latent in our inmost beings that are associated with the powers of the mind, powers of which the rest of creation is deprived:

**“... the power of intellectual investigation and scientific acquisition is a higher virtue specialized to man alone. Other beings and organisms are deprived of this potentiality and attainment. God has created or deposited this love of reality in man.”<sup>26</sup>**

It is by the aid of the teachings of God and through the study of the sciences and the arts that all these potentialities can be realized. Thus does ‘Abdu’l-Bahá exhort us with respect to the young:

**“Strive thou with heart and soul; see to it that the children are raised up to embody the highest perfections of humankind, to such a degree that every one of them will be trained in the use of the mind, in acquiring knowledge, in humility and lowliness, in dignity, in ardor and love.”<sup>27</sup>**

To receive the benefits of an education that brings to light their hidden potentialities, children must be helped, from a young age, to understand that the acquisition of knowledge and the development of spiritual qualities require the exercise of will and the exertion of effort:

**“Unto each one hath been prescribed a preordained measure, as decreed in God’s mighty and guarded Tablets. All that which ye potentially possess can, however, be manifested only as a result of your own volition.”<sup>28</sup>**

**“The greater the effort exerted for the refinement of this sublime and noble mirror, the more faithfully will it be made to reflect the glory of the names and attributes of God, and reveal the wonders of His signs and knowledge.”<sup>29</sup>**

Reread the above paragraphs and passages several times. You may find it helpful to identify with the members of your group the sequence of ideas presented, many of which you encountered in previous courses. After you have done so, you are encouraged to carry out the following exercises:

1. The words of Bahá’u’lláh impress upon us the importance of viewing each human being as a mine rich in gems of inestimable value, gems that the process of education has to bring forth. Every child has the potential to develop those attributes of heart and mind that will radiate light to the world. But it is only through proper education that this latent potential can be realized. Think of how, in its original condition, a gem is rough and dull; only after it is cut and polished does it show forth its luminosity and brilliance. Similarly, the potential to manifest truthfulness, for example, is realized in the individual when he or she is encouraged from a tender age to speak the truth and to be a seeker of truth. How might a heightened awareness of the role education plays in developing attributes latent within human reality affect the way parents approach the upbringing of their children?

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2. Just as a seed needs the sun’s warmth, the rain, and nutrients to grow into a tree that bears fruit, children need a proper environment in which to develop the potential latent in them. What should characterize this nurturing environment? Do your best to describe the elements of such an environment as listed on the next page. To assist you, the following words and phrases are provided. Try to use as many of them, or their derivatives, as possible.

order, cleanliness, refinement, consideration, love, discipline, rigor, humility, obedience, joy, selflessness, compassion, agreement, unity, care, wisdom, kindness, encouragement, respect, serenity, calmness, composure, trust in God, hopefulness, steadfastness, firmness, constancy, contentment, patience, thankfulness, generosity, humble fellowship, collaboration, work, effort, learning, promotion of knowledge, duty, solidarity, sacrifice, service, honesty, trustworthiness

- a. The way the household is organized: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - b. The qualities and attitudes that characterize interactions within the home: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - c. The language the family members use to communicate with one another: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - d. The way decisions are made within the family: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - e. How the family deals with a crisis: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - f. The values that are embedded in the culture of the community: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. The kind of potential we are discussing here has to do with the powers of the soul. Every child is endowed with the capacity to manifest spiritual qualities such as compassion and



generosity, which a proper education must strive to cultivate. Similarly, education must seek to develop the intellectual capacities of a child. Among these are, for instance, the capacity to read and comprehend the written word and to ask questions about what one observes in the natural world. It is, of course, true that the degree to which individuals can excel in one or another field of learning differs. Yet proper education exerts a great deal of influence in that it can enable every youngster to develop, up to a certain level, the capabilities associated with the main disciplines of knowledge. Later, as an adult, he or she can go on to achieve mastery in one or more areas. Our belief in the potential of each child and the role education plays in releasing it helps us recognize the faulty thinking that underlies some common statements we hear about children. Look at the statements below. What are the consequences of the kind of thinking they represent? Have you heard similar statements that can be added to this list?

- Some lack powers of concentration and will always have difficulty focusing.
- Some can only learn visually through diagrams, maps, charts, and pictures, and they will have difficulty learning purely through written and spoken words.
- Some are oriented towards the arts and will have great difficulty understanding the most basic elements of science and mathematics.
- Some can only learn through hands-on experience and will have difficulty in dealing with abstract thought and in understanding abstract ideas.
- Some are so lazy by nature that they will grow up to be a burden on society.
- Some are so rebellious by nature that they will grow up to break the law.
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_

4. As part of their upbringing, children must learn the value of putting forth effort. This can prove challenging in a world where one idea being aggressively promoted is that, the smarter we are, the less effort we need to exert to achieve our goals. People seek quick fixes and immediate results; there is little patience for anything that requires time. No doubt, the rise in certain kinds of computer technologies has lent credence to the notion “the faster the better”. Children raised in cultures that subscribe to such an outlook tend to avoid the toil that is actually necessary to accomplish things. When faced with solving a difficult problem, understanding a challenging subject, or completing a strenuous task, they are not motivated to try or do the bare minimum to get by. How can children come to appreciate that any intellectual or spiritual attainment requires the exertion of effort and

that the more noble the goal the greater the effort demanded? Write some of your thoughts in the space provided.

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5. We need to help children develop those habits and attitudes that enable them to benefit from sound education. To receive illumination, the heart of a young person must be open to the rays of the sun; susceptibilities of the spirit must grow and inner powers—like the power of comprehension, of thought, of memory, of imagination—must be strengthened through engagement with bodies of knowledge. We should make sure that certain habits of the mind which hinder the capacity of children to receive the light of knowledge do not take root. What are some of the forces that give rise to habits such as the ones below?
  - Viewing everything one is taught with a suspicion that denies the existence of truth
  - Being critical of new knowledge and questioning its validity, before engaging with it at a reasonable level of depth
  - Viewing every attainment of humanity, both spiritual and scientific, with a degree of cynicism that undermines the authority of accumulated knowledge
  - Viewing truth, knowledge, and morality as relative to culture
  - Favoring personal opinions and preferences over moral truths and scientifically proven facts
  - Dismissing any spiritual or scientific insight that does not appear to serve an immediate practical purpose
6. If the young ones in the community are to resist the forces that tend to create indifference and apathy towards knowledge, they should be assisted in strengthening many spiritual qualities and in forming appropriate attitudes towards learning. Look at the list of characteristics below. With your fellow participants in this course, discuss the significance of each in the context of a life that is dedicated to the acquisition and diffusion of knowledge.

- Detachment from personal preferences and desires
- Rejection of speculative and unfounded opinions
- Abandonment of self and ego in search after truth
- Readiness to give up one’s prejudices and trivial notions
- Willingness to push aside superstitious ideas
- Readiness to weigh the validity of beliefs in light of science and reason
- Open-mindedness
- Passion for truth and justice
- Eagerness to reflect on profound ideas and concepts
- Readiness to reflect on one’s deeds and actions
- Avoidance of criticism for the sake of criticism
- Readiness to correct one’s mistaken notions
- Rejection of pride and vainglory
- Avoidance of gossip
- Humility
- Flexibility
- Agility of mind
- Resistance to passivity
- Willingness to collaborate with others to attain unity of thought
- Eagerness to penetrate the mysteries of creation
- Yearning to achieve spiritual and intellectual excellence
- Thirst for true understanding
- Love for reality
- Respect for the accumulated knowledge of humanity
- Respect for sound wisdom and experience

## SECTION 7

The next theme the group identifies in their study of quotations related to education is one closely tied to the subject of latent potential—that is, our view of human nature. Below is the sequence of ideas they prepare for their visits.

When we speak about human potential and the role education plays in releasing it, we need to be on our guard against two notions which, often placed in opposition to each other, underlie so much of popular discourse. One is that human beings, naturally prone to goodness, have some innate sense of dignity and honor which will prevent them from doing

wrong. This position suggests that children should be allowed to grow without interference; if there is any role for education or training at all, it is to make sure the child's natural inclinations are given room to develop and to ward off outside influences. The other is that children are born as blank slates; they are neither inherently good nor inherently evil. Just as one can draw anything on a blank slate, one can mold a child into anything one wishes. In other words, education can set any objectives it so desires and then go about achieving them by whatever means it determines best; the question of latent potential is essentially irrelevant.

We need to take care, lest we fall under the influence of the dichotomous thinking to which these two exaggerated notions give rise. While we obviously reject the notion of the individual as a "blank slate", we find equally erroneous the idea that a child is capable of developing his or her heavenly potential unaided. 'Abdu'l-Bahá explains in this connection:

**"There are some who imagine that an innate sense of human dignity will prevent man from committing evil actions and insure his spiritual and material perfection. That is, that an individual who is characterized with natural intelligence, high resolve, and a driving zeal, will, without any consideration for the severe punishments consequent on evil acts, or for the great rewards of righteousness, instinctively refrain from inflicting harm on his fellow men and will hunger and thirst to do good. And yet, if we ponder the lessons of history it will become evident that this very sense of honor and dignity is itself one of the bounties deriving from the instructions of the Prophets of God. We also observe in infants the signs of aggression and lawlessness, and that if a child is deprived of a teacher's instructions his undesirable qualities increase from one moment to the next. It is therefore clear that the emergence of this natural sense of human dignity and honor is the result of education."**<sup>30</sup>

The Bahá'í teachings make clear that human beings are born with both a higher nature and a lower nature; parents, of course, catch glimpses of both in their children from a very young age. 'Abdu'l-Bahá tells us:

**"In man there are two natures; his spiritual or higher nature and his material or lower nature. In one he approaches God, in the other he lives for the world alone. Signs of both these natures are to be found in men. In his material aspect he expresses untruth, cruelty and injustice; all these are the outcome of his lower nature. The attributes of his Divine nature are shown forth in love, mercy, kindness, truth and justice, one and all being expressions of his higher nature. Every good habit, every noble quality belongs to man's spiritual nature, whereas all his imperfections and sinful actions are born of his material nature."**<sup>31</sup>

Clearly, the higher nature in a human being should dominate and conquer the lower nature:

**"Man has the power both to do good and to do evil; if his power for good predominates and his inclinations to do wrong are conquered, then man in truth may be called a saint. But if, on the contrary, he rejects the things of God and allows his evil passions to conquer him, then he is no better than a mere animal."**<sup>32</sup>

Undoubtedly, the outcome of any training the young ones in a community receive will be affected by the degree of capacity they each possess and by the will and effort they exert, as well as by factors such as the quality of their social environment. What parents should not lose sight of, however, is that, in the education of their children, they play a significant role in strengthening their spiritual nature so that it dominates and gains mastery over the material nature. The following words of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá give us insight in this regard:

**“Man is in the ultimate degree of materiality and the beginning of spirituality; that is, he is at the end of imperfection and the beginning of perfection. He is at the furthestmost degree of darkness and the beginning of the light. That is why the station of man is said to be the end of night and the beginning of day, meaning that he encompasses all the degrees of imperfection and that he potentially possesses all the degrees of perfection. He has both an animal side and an angelic side, and the role of the educator is to so train human souls that the angelic side may overcome the animal. Thus, should the divine powers, which are identical with perfection, overcome in man the satanic powers, which are absolute imperfection, he becomes the noblest of all creatures, but should the converse take place, he becomes the vilest of all beings. That is why he is the end of imperfection and the beginning of perfection.”<sup>33</sup>**

And we read the following in a letter written on behalf of Shoghi Effendi:

**“The child when born is far from being perfect. It is not only helpless, but actually is imperfect, and even is naturally inclined towards evil. He should be trained, his natural inclinations harmonized, adjusted and controlled, and if necessary suppressed or regulated, so as to ensure his healthy physical and moral development. Bahá’í parents . . . should endeavor to inculcate, gently and patiently, into their youthful minds such principles of moral conduct and initiate them into the principles and teachings of the Cause with such tactful and loving care as would enable them to become ‘true sons of God’ and develop into loyal and intelligent citizens of His Kingdom. This is the high purpose which Bahá’u’lláh Himself has clearly defined as the chief goal of every education.”<sup>34</sup>**

You should, as before, read the above paragraphs and passages several times until you have internalized the sequence of ideas presented. Having done so, you can turn to the exercises below, which will help you reflect further on the theme of human nature.

1. The two erroneous conceptions of human nature discussed above can give rise to equally erroneous approaches to how parents raise children—one in which a child’s natural inclinations are given free reign by the parents and the other in which parents, without due regard for their child’s capacity and talents, try to control every aspect of his or her growth and development. What do you think might be some of the consequences of each approach?

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2. What are some of the characteristics of the human being that, as mentioned in the passage from ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, are expressions of our lower nature?

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3. What are some attributes that are expressions of our higher nature?

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4. Complete the following sentences:

- a. Man is in the \_\_\_\_\_ degree of \_\_\_\_\_ and the \_\_\_\_\_ of \_\_\_\_\_ .
- b. Man is at the \_\_\_\_\_ of \_\_\_\_\_ and the \_\_\_\_\_ of \_\_\_\_\_ .
- c. Man is at the \_\_\_\_\_ degree of \_\_\_\_\_ and the \_\_\_\_\_ of the \_\_\_\_\_ .
- d. The station of man is the \_\_\_\_\_ of \_\_\_\_\_ and the \_\_\_\_\_ of \_\_\_\_\_ .
- e. Man encompasses \_\_\_\_\_ the degrees of \_\_\_\_\_ and he potentially possesses \_\_\_\_\_ the degrees of \_\_\_\_\_ .
- f. Man has both an \_\_\_\_\_ side and an \_\_\_\_\_ side.
- g. The role of the educator is to so \_\_\_\_\_ human souls that the angelic side may \_\_\_\_\_ the animal.
- h. If the divine powers, which are identical with \_\_\_\_\_ , overcome in man the satanic powers, which are \_\_\_\_\_ , he will become the \_\_\_\_\_ .

- i. If the satanic powers overcome in man the divine powers, he becomes the \_\_\_\_\_.  
\_\_\_\_\_. That is why he is the end of \_\_\_\_\_ and the  
beginning of \_\_\_\_\_.
5. Decide which of the following are true:
- \_\_\_\_\_ Unaided and without interference, a child's natural intelligence will fully develop.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Children will learn to discern right from wrong through their innate sense of dignity.
- \_\_\_\_\_ The natural sense of human dignity and honor can only emerge through proper education.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Our nobility is manifested when our natural instincts fully express themselves without the imposition of any standards of conduct.
- \_\_\_\_\_ If the material nature overcomes the spiritual, a human being will become the lowest of all created things.
- \_\_\_\_\_ If the spiritual nature overcomes the material, a human being will become the noblest of all creatures.
6. The writings of the Faith describe a dynamic interplay between the spiritual and material nature of the human being. We do not view our material nature as inherently sinful, as something that should be rejected. Rather we see it as the product of physical evolution and recognize that its impulses must be governed by our higher, spiritual nature. This is the chief aim of education. The kind of upbringing we speak of, then, is not one that cultivates disdain for our material nature or that seeks to create guilt in a child. The challenge before parents is to work gently and patiently with their children so that their natural inclinations are harmonized, adjusted, and controlled and come to be directed towards noble goals. Take, for instance, anger. Anger surely is a sign of the lower nature and should never be given free reign. But when anger is a response to injustice and oppression, it can impel us to exert effort along proper channels towards their elimination. Greed can be another manifestation of the lower nature—of base passions. However, when controlled by the higher nature, it can find expression in an unquenchable thirst for knowledge and in a growing desire to show forth compassion, high-mindedness, and justice. There are, of course, some inclinations that, as Shoghi Effendi suggests, a child must learn to quell entirely. A few examples of such inclinations are listed below. What words and counsels might parents use in guiding their children when they see even the tiniest expressions of these promptings of the lower nature? What spiritual susceptibilities can be developed within a child to help him or her to eliminate such promptings? Try to describe them.

Aggression: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

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Cruelty: \_\_\_\_\_

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Injustice: \_\_\_\_\_

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Lawlessness: \_\_\_\_\_

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## SECTION 8

Following their discussion on human nature, Gina mentions to Alejandra and Maribel that she has shared some of the ideas they have been exploring with two of her neighbors who have young children. The mothers have shown an interest in learning more about how the teachings of the Faith can help the community gain a proper perspective on education. Gina suggests that they be invited, along with their husbands, to join the conversation when Alejandra and Maribel next visit.

That evening, Alejandra and Martin go with their infant daughter to Daniela and Francisco's home for dinner. Maribel is already there helping the family prepare the meal. After they eat, their discussion turns naturally to their efforts in the neighborhood and to the visits they have just concluded. They are excited that more parents will be joining the conversation at Gina's house. "The importance of spiritual education seems particularly significant for parents of young children," says Martin, referring to the next topic they have chosen to explore. "Every child should be nurtured spiritually from a tender age." The group reviews the quotations they have gathered and talks for a while about the concept of spiritual education and some related ideas they remember from their study of Book 3. By the end of the evening, they have developed the following outline for their upcoming conversations:

To ensure that the gems latent within the children of our community are discovered and polished and their higher nature properly nurtured, we must think carefully about the kind of education they receive. Education must encompass all aspects of a child's growth, his or her spiritual development in addition to physical and intellectual growth. The Guardian states:



**“... Bahá'u'lláh considered education as one of the most fundamental factors of a true civilization. This education, however, in order to be adequate and fruitful, should be comprehensive in nature and should take into consideration not only the physical and the intellectual side of man but also his spiritual and ethical aspects.”<sup>35</sup>**

Parents need to pay special attention to the spiritual education of their children from the earliest age. “Qualities of the spirit”, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá says, “are the basic and divine foundation, and adorn the true essence of man”. Let us think further about what spiritual education entails. The capacity conferred upon the human being to know God and to love Him is the primary purpose underlying the whole of creation. The parents of a child, long before any formal training begins, nurture in the pure soil of his or her heart the seeds of the love of God:

**“From the very beginning, the children must receive divine education and must continually be reminded to remember their God. Let the love of God pervade their inmost being, commingled with their mother’s milk.”<sup>36</sup>**

Fear of God is an indispensable factor in this education. That something we do could cause displeasure to the one we love is a natural fear. Children intuitively, out of the love they have for their parents, avoid conduct that would make them unhappy. Likewise, when the flame of God’s love is ignited in the heart of a child, he or she will not want to do anything that would displease Him. This is very different from the type of fear often associated with religion that can unfortunately be instilled in people from a young age. Eschewing utterly such a practice, spiritual education is concerned with the dynamic interaction between love of God and fear of God. Thus does ‘Abdu’l-Bahá explain this interaction:

**“Train these children with divine exhortations. From their childhood instill in their hearts the love of God so they may manifest in their lives the fear of God and have confidence in the bestowals of God. Teach them to free themselves from human imperfections and to acquire the divine perfections latent in the heart of man.”<sup>37</sup>**

The intensity of one’s love of God increases through the power of attraction. If the heart is not attracted by the light of His beauty, the spirit will not be moved:

**“The flame of the fire of love, in this world of earth and water, burns by the power of attraction and not through human effort and striving, although through the latter one may indeed acquire knowledge, learning, and other perfections. It is the light of the divine Beauty, then, that must stir up and move the spirit through its attractive power.”<sup>38</sup>**

The spiritual training children receive at home should, accordingly, help them recognize true beauty and become enamored of it:

**“... that which eternally endureth is the Beauty of the True One, for its splendor perisheth not and its glory lasteth forever; its charm is all-powerful and its attraction infinite.”<sup>39</sup>**

The “magnet” of the love of God draws unto us the “knowledge of God”, and the light of this love is in turn “kindled, through the knowledge of God”. Spiritual education, then, needs to nurture in children a thirst for knowledge—above all, knowledge of the True One:

**“Although to acquire the sciences and arts is the greatest glory of mankind, this is so only on condition that man’s river flow into the mighty sea, and draw from God’s ancient source His inspiration. . . . If, then, the pursuit of knowledge lead to the beauty of Him Who is the Object of all Knowledge, how excellent that goal . . .”**<sup>40</sup>

In the pursuit of knowledge, one’s face should be continually turned towards Divine beauty—the beauty of the Word of God, the beauty of the teachings of Bahá’u’lláh manifested in human thought and character, the beauty of heavenly attributes reflected in the mirror of the human heart, the beauty of the Faith’s standards against which every human attainment is to be measured. The forces of attraction to beauty and thirst for knowledge awakened through spiritual education will aid our children as they grow in steering a fruitful course in life.

**“It is incumbent upon thee to acquire the various branches of knowledge, and to turn thy face toward the beauty of the Manifest Beauty, that thou mayest be a sign of saving guidance amongst the peoples of the world . . .”**<sup>41</sup>

‘Abdu’l-Bahá expresses in these words His hopes for the spiritual education children receive under the loving care of their mothers:

**“Thus shall these tender infants be nurtured at the breast of the knowledge of God and His love. Thus shall they grow and flourish, and be taught righteousness and the dignity of humankind, resolution and the will to strive and to endure. Thus shall they learn perseverance in all things, the will to advance, high-mindedness and high resolve, chastity and purity of life. Thus shall they be enabled to carry to a successful conclusion whatsoever they undertake.”**<sup>42</sup>

You are encouraged to reflect on the above sequence of ideas and to carry out the corresponding exercises as you have done with the earlier themes.

1. Complete the sentences below:
  - a. Education should take into consideration not only the physical and the intellectual side of the individual but also \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - b. From the very beginning, children must receive \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - c. From the very beginning, children must continually be reminded to \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - d. The \_\_\_\_\_ should pervade their inmost being, commingled with their mother’s milk.

- e. From their childhood, the \_\_\_\_\_ should be instilled in their hearts so they may manifest in their lives the \_\_\_\_\_ and have confidence in \_\_\_\_\_ .
2. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us that children are “even as young plants”. “Teaching them the prayers”, He says, “is as letting the rain pour down upon them, that they may wax tender and fresh, and the soft breezes of the love of God may blow over them, making them to tremble with joy.” Clearly, then, for this love to pervade their beings, children need to learn many prayers by heart and acquire the habit of daily communion with God. Discuss the significance of prayer in the development of a child as you reflect on the following statements, which are drawn from the writings you studied in Book 1. How might the insights you gain from them be shared with the families you visit?
- Prayer is conversation with God.
  - The greatest attainment or the sweetest state is none other than conversation with God.
  - In the highest prayer, human beings pray only for the love of God, not because they fear Him or hell, or hope for bounty or heaven.
  - God knows the wishes of all hearts, but the impulse to pray is a natural one, springing from our love for God.
  - We should live in a state of prayer.
  - Prayer creates spirituality, mindfulness and celestial feelings.
  - Prayer engenders susceptibilities of the higher intelligence.
  - Prayer burns away the veils that shut us out from God’s beauty.
  - Prayer can both kindle our own souls and attract the hearts of others.
  - It behooves the servant to pray and seek assistance from God and to supplicate and implore His aid.
  - God in His consummate wisdom will decree whatsoever He desireth, and we should bow down our heads in submission to God’s Will and put our trust in Him.
  - When we gather together to recite the verses revealed by God, the doors of true knowledge will open to our inner beings, our souls will be endowed with steadfastness, and our hearts will be filled with radiant joy.

Now discuss with the members of your group how families in a community can help one another to reinforce in their children the habit of daily prayer.

3. In the past, most notably in Book 3, you have thought about the fear of God, which Bahá'u'lláh states is the “prime factor” in the education of humanity. Fear of God is inseparable from the boundless love for God that grows in the human heart. The force of love engenders fear—the fear of losing love. This fear causes one to strive to align one’s will with the Will of the Beloved and to abstain from whatsoever may in the least weaken the bond that connects us to our Creator. Therefore, parents and other adults should give thought to the characteristics that distinguish the kind of language that can engender in children appropriate thoughts and sentiments towards God—a language that diverges entirely from the kind which, stripped of any tender emotion, instills in them the fear of His scourge and punishment. Knowing that love of God and the fear of displeasing Him educates the hearts and minds of children, what counsel can parents give to

– motivate them to strive for spiritual excellence? \_\_\_\_\_

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– help them restrain the promptings of their lower nature and develop their higher nature?

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– instill a sense of responsibility in them towards the well-being of others? \_\_\_\_\_

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4. We know that love of God ignites in the heart the yearning to obey His laws and teachings, and obedience opens the channels of the soul to attain to the knowledge of God. In the context of the spiritual education of children, discuss how obedience to God’s command, engendered by the love and knowledge of Him, is indispensable to

- the acquisition of spiritual qualities.
- the development of the powers of the mind.
- the rectification of morals.
- the illumination of the conscience.
- the liberation of the soul from the captivity of self and passion.
- the development of love for humanity.

5. Now complete the following sentences:
- The flame of the \_\_\_\_\_ burns by the power of \_\_\_\_\_ and not through human \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_.
  - Through human effort and striving one may acquire \_\_\_\_\_, \_\_\_\_\_, and other \_\_\_\_\_.
  - It is the \_\_\_\_\_ of the divine \_\_\_\_\_ that must \_\_\_\_\_ and move the spirit through its \_\_\_\_\_.
  - That which endures forever is the \_\_\_\_\_ of the \_\_\_\_\_.
  - The \_\_\_\_\_ of the Beauty of the True One \_\_\_\_\_ not and its \_\_\_\_\_ lasts forever.
  - The charm of the Beauty of the True One is \_\_\_\_\_.
  - The attraction of the Beauty of the True One is \_\_\_\_\_.
  - If the pursuit of knowledge leads to the \_\_\_\_\_ of Him Who is the \_\_\_\_\_ of all \_\_\_\_\_, how \_\_\_\_\_.

6. The Word of God is the magnet which draws the hearts of children to the Everlasting and Peerless Beauty. When they are attracted to this Source, they will be able to distinguish between true beauty and what disguises itself in its name. Read the excerpts from the Writings below and discuss in your group how true beauty is manifested both in the language employed and in the profound ideas that are conveyed.

**“O Son of Spirit! My first counsel is this: Possess a pure, kindly and radiant heart, that thine may be a sovereignty ancient, imperishable and everlasting.”<sup>43</sup>**

**“O Friends! Abandon not the everlasting beauty for a beauty that must die, and set not your affections on this mortal world of dust.”<sup>44</sup>**

**“O mystic nightingale! Abide not but in the rose garden of the spirit. O messenger of the Solomon of love! Seek thou no shelter except in the Sheba of the well-beloved, and O immortal phoenix! dwell not save on the mount of faithfulness. Therein is thy habitation, if on the wings of thy soul thou soarest to the realm of the infinite and seekest to attain thy goal.”<sup>45</sup>**

**“O Son of Spirit! Burst thy cage asunder, and even as the phoenix of love soar into the firmament of holiness. Renounce thyself and, filled with the spirit of mercy, abide in the realm of celestial sanctity.”<sup>46</sup>**

**“Strive thou, that haply thou mayest achieve a deed the fragrance of which shall never fade from the earth.”<sup>47</sup>**

7. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us: “The Word of God may be likened to the life-giving breezes of the divine springtime. When chanted in spiritual tones, it bestoweth the breath of life and granteth true salvation. It bringeth forth a garden of roses from the pure soil, and wafteth its musk-laden fragrance throughout the world.” Keeping in mind the above exercise, write a few sentences about the penetrative influence of the Word of God in shaping the thought and character of the young.

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8. Telling children stories from the lives of the Central Figures of the Faith and from the early days of the Cause is a potent instrument in a process of spiritual education. You are, no doubt, aware that the children in your village or neighborhood learn many such stories in the weekly classes they attend for their spiritual education. Call to mind some stories of this kind and say a few words about how they

- fan the fire of the love of God in the hearts of children.
- deepen their understanding of the station of the Manifestations of God, particularly of the Báb and Bahá’u’lláh, as those perfect Mirrors reflecting the light of God’s names and attributes.
- give children glimpses of the spiritual forces released through the appearance of the Manifestations of God.
- give them insights into God’s purpose for humanity and endow them with a sense of mission to champion the Cause.
- set for them, in the life of the perfect Exemplar, a standard of conduct towards which they should constantly aspire.

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9. While the community offers classes for the spiritual education of children beginning at the tender age of five or six, this aspect of their development is a matter to which parents must give attention long before their sons and daughters reach that age and well beyond it. The Universal House of Justice makes clear in this connection: “Independent of the level of

their education, parents are in a critical position to shape the spiritual development of their children. They should not ever underestimate their capacity to mold their children's moral character. For they exercise indispensable influence through the home environment they consciously create by their love of God, their striving to adhere to His laws, their spirit of service to His Cause, their lack of fanaticism, and their freedom from the corrosive effects of backbiting." Discuss with other members of your group how each of the following might contribute to the spiritual development of children:

The parents' love of God: \_\_\_\_\_

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The striving of parents to adhere to God's laws: \_\_\_\_\_

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The spirit of service to the Cause of God that animates parents: \_\_\_\_\_

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The lack of fanaticism displayed by parents: \_\_\_\_\_

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The efforts made by parents to remain free from the corrosive effects of backbiting: \_\_\_\_\_

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10. It is equally important for parents to seize the opportunity that moments of intimate conversation provide to help children gain insights into spiritual topics, nurturing in this way their spiritual susceptibilities. In this light, discuss with the other participants in your group the following statement from 'Abdu'l-Bahá: "It is incumbent upon every father and mother to counsel their children over a long period, and guide them unto those things which lead to everlasting honor."
11. On the basis of the ideas presented in this section, write a paragraph describing the nature of the spiritual education children should receive at home.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

## SECTION 9

The small gathering at Gina and her husband's home is uplifting. She prepares a sweet bread and fresh fruit juice for her guests. The presence of the two additional couples who live on her street enriches the conversation about the spiritual education of children. The parents exchange thoughts and ideas with one another and raise questions that have long been on their minds. One parent remarks, "We have talked about how the love and knowledge of God should be nurtured in a child's heart from a tender age, but it is very difficult to do this in the environment in which we live where irreligion is becoming more and more dominant." "Yes, this is true," Maribel responds. "That is why it is so important that our children develop the kind of faith and understanding that will enable them to combat the forces of materialism as they grow up." Alejandra suggests that they discuss the theme of faith when they next meet.

During the week, Maribel and the two couples put together the following set of quotations and ideas to prepare themselves for the conversation they will have at Gina's home and with the other households they are visiting:

Bahá'u'lláh tells us that it is the duty of parents to raise their children to be staunch in faith:

**“It is the bounden duty of parents to rear their children to be staunch in faith, the reason being that a child who removeth himself from the religion of God will not act in such a way as to win the good pleasure of his parents and his Lord. For every praiseworthy deed is born out of the light of religion, and lacking this supreme**



**bestowal the child will not turn away from any evil, nor will he draw nigh unto any good.”<sup>48</sup>**

However, in today’s world, there are many misconceptions about faith. In the minds of some, faith has come to be associated with superstitious beliefs and irrational thought. The prevalent notions to which such associations have given rise, with their roots in certain dogmatic practices, are not in accord with our understanding of faith. True religious faith demands that we turn away from blind imitation:

**“First among the great principles revealed by Him is that of the investigation of reality. The meaning is that every individual member of humankind is exhorted and commanded to set aside superstitious beliefs, traditions and blind imitation of ancestral forms in religion and investigate reality for himself.”<sup>49</sup>**

Moreover, faith is intimately connected to reason; there can be no contradiction between the two:

**“If religious belief and doctrine is at variance with reason, it proceeds from the limited mind of man and not from God; therefore, it is unworthy of belief and not deserving of attention; the heart finds no rest in it, and real faith is impossible. How can man believe that which he knows to be opposed to reason? Is this possible? Can the heart accept that which reason denies? Reason is the first faculty of man, and the religion of God is in harmony with it.”<sup>50</sup>**

Far from being irrational, faith is founded on conscious knowledge and is expressed in action for the good of humanity. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us:

**“... faith compriseth both knowledge and the performance of good works.”<sup>51</sup>**

Investigation of reality requires that we open our inner and outer eyes:

**“... we must thank God that He has created for us both material blessings and spiritual bestowals. He has given us material gifts and spiritual graces, outer sight to view the lights of the sun and inner vision by which we may perceive the glory of God. He has designed the outer ear to enjoy the melodies of sound and the inner hearing wherewith we may hear the voice of our Creator.”<sup>52</sup>**

And it is when, in their search after truth, individuals come to recognize in His Manifestation the beauty of the Eternal One and resolve to follow His teachings that the spirit of faith fills their beings. Bahá’u’lláh states:

**“Do thou ponder these momentous happenings in thy heart, so that thou mayest apprehend the greatness of this Revelation, and perceive its stupendous glory. Then shall the spirit of faith, through the grace of the Merciful, be breathed into thy being, and thou shalt be established and abide upon the seat of certitude.”<sup>53</sup>**

The spirit of faith proceeds from the breath of the Holy Spirit, from the grace of God that emanates from His Manifestation and brings life to all things. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us:

**“This spirit proceeds from the breath of the Holy Spirit, and through a power born of God it becomes the cause of everlasting life. It is that power which makes the earthly soul heavenly and the imperfect man perfect. It cleanses the impure, unlooses the tongue of the silent, sanctifies the bondslaves of passion and desire, and confers knowledge upon the ignorant.”<sup>54</sup>**

When the human spirit is thus illumined by the spirit of faith, then do new portals of understanding open wide. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá explains:

**“... the human spirit, unless it be assisted by the spirit of faith, cannot become acquainted with the divine mysteries and the heavenly realities. It is like a mirror which, although clear, bright, and polished, is still in need of light. Not until a sun-beam falls upon it can it discover the divine mysteries.”<sup>55</sup>**

As the spirit of faith penetrates one’s being, it dissipates doubt and leads to certitude. In a world that is increasingly distracted and confused, our children need assurance and certainty more than ever. They need to know that they can turn to God at all times and under all conditions and to have faith in the unfailing guidance and protection that comes from following the teachings of His Manifestation:

**“Pass beyond the baser stages of doubt and rise to the exalted heights of certainty.”<sup>56</sup>**

**“Attire yourselves, O people, with the raiment of certitude, that it may protect you from the darts of idle fancy and vain imaginings and that ye may be numbered with the faithful in these days—days wherein none may attain certitude nor achieve constancy in the Cause of God save by renouncing that which is current amongst men and by turning towards this hallowed and refulgent Beauty.”<sup>57</sup>**

**“Only when the lamp of search, of earnest striving, of longing desire, of passionate devotion, of fervid love, of rapture, and ecstasy, is kindled within the seeker’s heart, and the breeze of His loving-kindness is wafted upon his soul, will the darkness of error be dispelled, the mists of doubts and misgivings be dissipated, and the lights of knowledge and certitude envelop his being.”<sup>58</sup>**

Read the above paragraphs and passages several times and reflect carefully on the theme introduced. Once you have gained some familiarity with the sequence of ideas, you will find it helpful to carry out the exercises below.

1. Complete the following sentences:
  - a. It is the \_\_\_\_\_ of parents to rear their children to be \_\_\_\_\_.
  - b. A child who removes him or herself from the \_\_\_\_\_ will not act in such a way as to win the \_\_\_\_\_ of his or her \_\_\_\_\_ and his or her \_\_\_\_\_.
  - c. Every praiseworthy \_\_\_\_\_ is born out of the \_\_\_\_\_.

- d. Lacking religion, a child will not turn away from \_\_\_\_\_ .
- e. Lacking religion, a child will not draw nigh unto \_\_\_\_\_ .
2. As you reflect now on the above sentences, it must be clear that the light of religion should guide the thoughts and actions of children. In this connection, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us: “If religion is opposed to reason and science, faith is impossible; and when faith and confidence in the divine religion are not manifest in the heart, there can be no spiritual attainment.” In light of the above passages from the Writings, decide which of the following statements are true:
- \_\_\_\_\_ Faith implies that children blindly imitate the beliefs of their parents.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Children should be left free to investigate reality by themselves; they should not be educated according to the teachings of Bahá’u’lláh.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Cultivating faith in children contributes to their understanding of both physical and spiritual reality.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Cultivating faith in children develops their spiritual perception.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Children should not be encouraged to ask too many questions, for doing so could undermine their faith in God.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Studying the laws of nature and having an inquisitive mind strengthen faith.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Faith in God is indispensable to the development of spiritual qualities.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Studying science weakens children’s faith in God.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Overcoming the promptings of the lower nature requires faith in God.
- \_\_\_\_\_ The power of reason is fortified in children when they are assisted in distinguishing between faith and superstitious beliefs.
3. To have faith is to know the truth and to act upon it. Why are both necessary? \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
4. To be seekers of truth, individuals need to develop their intellectual and spiritual powers from a young age. They must be guided, in their search for insights into the workings of the universe and the mysteries enshrined in God’s Revelation, by the lights of both reason and faith. How do the following help the children in a community develop the requisite powers?

The habit of praying: \_\_\_\_\_

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The acquisition of scientific knowledge: \_\_\_\_\_

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The habit of turning to the Writings for guidance: \_\_\_\_\_

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Obedience to the teachings of God: \_\_\_\_\_

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Memorization of the Word of God: \_\_\_\_\_

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The habit of reflecting on one's deeds: \_\_\_\_\_

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The development of capacity to serve the community: \_\_\_\_\_

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5. We know that we cannot gain insights into spiritual reality without the aid and assistance of the divine Manifestations and Their teachings. It is through the power of the Holy Spirit

that the human spirit is illumined with the spirit of faith. Reflect on the following sentences as you complete them:

- a. The spirit of faith proceeds from the \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - b. The spirit of faith makes the earthly soul \_\_\_\_\_ and the imperfect man \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - c. The spirit of faith cleanses the \_\_\_\_\_ , unlooses the \_\_\_\_\_ , sanctifies the \_\_\_\_\_ , and confers knowledge upon the \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - d. The human spirit can only become acquainted with the \_\_\_\_\_ and the \_\_\_\_\_ if it be assisted by the \_\_\_\_\_ .
6. Discuss in your group how faith in God is indispensable to the development of the following attributes in children:
- An outlook on life filled with hope and optimism
  - The ability to turn stumbling blocks into stepping stones for progress
  - Faith in the potentialities of one's fellow human beings and in the bright future Bahá'u'lláh has envisioned for humanity
  - An unyielding desire to serve the Cause and humanity
7. The light of faith transforms doubt into certainty, a certainty free of superstition and fanaticism. What are some of the spiritual convictions that parents should help their children develop?

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## SECTION 10

Alejandra and Daniela are seated on a bench in the yard of the facility where an institute campaign is taking place. It is the lunch break, and a couple of youth from a study circle that Francisco is guiding through Book 2 are playing with Daniela's twin boys. Alejandra's little girl has fallen asleep in her stroller. Looking in the direction of the children playing, Alejandra says: "As I was reading the writings this morning, I came across several passages that reminded me of

the dangers of self. I realized how careful we need to be as parents to avoid doing things that could unintentionally bolster the ego of our children. The writings teach us to guard against the promptings of the insistent self, but the obsession in society with glorifying the individual makes this challenging.” Alejandra and Daniela talk about this theme for some time and feel that they should explore it in the next set of visits they make. Here is the sequence of ideas that emerges from the study of the writings they later undertake with Maribel and their husbands, Martin and Francisco:

Turning towards God in all circumstances requires that we turn our backs to the promptings of the ego and quiet the voice of the insistent self. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá says that we can “see in a nursing child, from the beginning of its life, the signs of greed, of anger and of ill-temper” and that “self-love is kneaded into the very clay of man”. Such signs point to aspects of the lower nature that have to be dominated by the higher nature. In a healthy family environment, children will over time learn to curb their selfish traits and to be concerned for the welfare of others. The difficulty lies in the fact that so many forces in society are pushing all of us, including our children, in the opposite direction. Both subtle and overt messages tell individuals to think of themselves before others, to do whatever will serve their own interests, and to place themselves at the center of everything. We would do well to ponder on the following passages:

**“... there is no veil more obstructive than the self, and however tenuous that veil may be, at the last it will completely shut a person out, and deprive him of his portion of eternal grace.”<sup>59</sup>**

**“... if he show the slightest taint of selfish desires and self-love, his efforts will lead to nothing and he will be destroyed and left hopeless at the last.”<sup>60</sup>**

**“O people of the world! Follow not the promptings of the self, for it summoneth insistently to wickedness and lust; follow, rather, Him Who is the Possessor of all created things . . .”<sup>61</sup>**

In the world today, self-gratification is increasingly fostered in individuals from childhood; wants and desires, shaped by a culture of consumerism, are to be instantly satisfied, lending strength to certain patterns of thought in the individual that are especially detrimental to the progress of a young child. What is important to realize is that giving in to a child’s every desire hampers his or her spiritual and intellectual growth. Latent potential is manifested only as the human being is freed from the promptings of the insistent self. Thus does Bahá’u’lláh tell us:

**“O My Servant! Thou art even as a finely tempered sword concealed in the darkness of its sheath and its value hidden from the artificer’s knowledge. Wherefore come forth from the sheath of self and desire that thy worth may be made resplendent and manifest unto all the world.”<sup>62</sup>**

A youngster must be helped to gain a deeper and deeper knowledge of his or her true self—the self which is pleasing to God—and to recognize what leads to loftiness and what is the cause of degradation:

**“... man should know his own self and recognize that which leadeth unto loftiness or lowliness, glory or abasement, wealth or poverty.”<sup>63</sup>**

**“Honesty, virtue, wisdom and a saintly character redound to the exaltation of man, while dishonesty, imposture, ignorance and hypocrisy lead to his abasement.”<sup>64</sup>**

**“O Son of Spirit! I created thee rich, why dost thou bring thyself down to poverty? Noble I made thee, wherewith dost thou abase thyself? Out of the essence of knowledge I gave thee being, why seekest thou enlightenment from anyone beside Me?”<sup>65</sup>**

As the love of God grows in the heart of a child, it will leave no room for self-adoration and self-love:

**“O Son of Man! If thou lovest Me, turn away from thyself; and if thou seekest My pleasure, regard not thine own; that thou mayest die in Me and I may eternally live in thee.”<sup>66</sup>**

**“O Son of Spirit! There is no peace for thee save by renouncing thyself and turning unto Me; for it behooveth thee to glory in My name, not in thine own; to put thy trust in Me and not in thyself, since I desire to be loved alone and above all that is.”<sup>67</sup>**

The love for God we feel in our hearts finds expression, of course, in love for His creation. Children should learn that they attain eternal happiness when they forget their own interests and direct their thoughts and actions to the well-being of others:

**“Your utmost desire must be to confer happiness upon each other. Each one must be the servant of the others, thoughtful of their comfort and welfare. In the path of God one must forget himself entirely. He must not consider his own pleasure but seek the pleasure of others. He must not desire glory nor gifts of bounty for himself but seek these gifts and blessings for his brothers and sisters.”<sup>68</sup>**

**“Is any larger bounty conceivable than this, that an individual, looking within himself, should find that by the confirming grace of God he has become the cause of peace and well-being, of happiness and advantage to his fellow men? No, by the one true God, there is no greater bliss, no more complete delight.”<sup>69</sup>**

And while in matters of the spirit, as in any worthy endeavor, children need to be encouraged, it is equally true that excessive praise can reinforce egotism, pride, and self-absorption. It is instructive for all of us, especially parents, to remember how ‘Abdu’l-Bahá offered encouragement:

**“Verily I render thanks unto God for having aided you to serve His Cause in His great vineyard.”<sup>70</sup>**

**“Verily, I praise my supreme Lord for choosing you to call in His Name among the people, for attracting you to the beauty of the All-Glorious, and for strengthening you to render His Cause victorious.”<sup>71</sup>**

Parents also need to take care, lest, in the way they educate their young ones, they cultivate ambitions in them not conducive to their true happiness or to their spiritual and intellectual growth:

**“... the cares of the lower things of life should not be allowed to monopolize all the thoughts and aspirations of a human being. The heart’s ambitions should ascend to a more glorious goal, mental activity should rise to higher levels! Men should hold in their souls the vision of celestial perfection, and there prepare a dwelling-place for the inexhaustible bounty of the Divine Spirit.**

**“Let your ambition be the achievement on earth of a Heavenly civilization! I ask for you the supreme blessing, that you may be so filled with the vitality of the Heavenly Spirit that you may be the cause of life to the world.”<sup>72</sup>**

**“The fulfillment of our personal ambitions in life is very seldom what brings us happiness. On the contrary, it usually arouses an entire group of new ambitions. On the other hand, when we immerse ourselves in our duties both as human beings, to our families and our associates, and as Bahá’ís toward the Cause of God and serving it to the best of our ability in the circumstances in which we find ourselves, we begin to know what happiness means.”<sup>73</sup>**

After reading the above sequence of ideas several times as you have done in previous sections, you may find it beneficial to carry out the following exercises:

1. Complete the sentences below.
  - a. There is \_\_\_\_\_ veil more \_\_\_\_\_ than the \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - b. However \_\_\_\_\_ that \_\_\_\_\_ may be, at the last it will \_\_\_\_\_ shut us out and \_\_\_\_\_ us of our portion of \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - c. If we show the slightest taint of \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ , our efforts will \_\_\_\_\_ and we will be \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ at the last.
  - d. We are counselled not to \_\_\_\_\_ the promptings of the \_\_\_\_\_ , for it summons \_\_\_\_\_ to \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - e. We are to \_\_\_\_\_ , rather, Him Who is the \_\_\_\_\_ of all \_\_\_\_\_ things.
2. The “insistent self” acts as a veil that shuts us out from the rays of the Sun of Truth, depriving us of that portion of eternal grace God has destined for us; if unchecked, it diminishes our capacity to
  - receive heavenly confirmations.
  - receive God’s love.



- attain the good pleasure of the Lord.
- obtain illumination from the knowledge of God.
- inhale the sweetness of pure acts carried out for His sake.
- manifest generosity.

Now, can you think of some other capacities that can be diminished if the insistent self is left unchecked?

- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_

3. In a world in which the feverish pursuit of self-interest is considered key to advancement, how can parents help their children, as they grow older, to understand that efforts motivated by selfish desires will not bear enduring fruit and that self-love will ultimately lead them to despair?

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4. For youngsters to acquire a knowledge of their true selves, they must come to recognize what leads us to abasement and what conduces to glory. In each of the following, how can parents guide children to achieve the nobility that represents their true selves? Write your thoughts in the spaces provided and share them with your fellow participants in this course.

Their relationships with family members and friends: \_\_\_\_\_

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The language they use: \_\_\_\_\_

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Their pastimes: \_\_\_\_\_

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5. It is necessary to deepen a child’s knowledge of that dimension of the self which is pleasing to God. Our conception of human nobility, however, is completely at odds with romantic notions of the self so prevalent today. From so many sources, we hear slogans that sing the praise of the individual and ask us to look solely within ourselves for confidence, for knowledge, for ways to succeed, and even for standards to guide us. The unwarranted belief in the powers of a glorified self that such slogans try to inspire in us leads but to disillusionment. To gain a proper appreciation of their true nobility, children should be taught to humbly turn their hearts and thoughts towards the Sun of Truth, so that they can become illumined with the light of true understanding. Read each of the slogans below and find a statement from the above set of quotations that negates it. The first one has been completed as an example:

- a. Always think of yourself first.

“In the path of God one must forget himself entirely. He must not consider his own pleasure but seek the pleasure of others.”

- b. You will attain your potential when you love yourself and fulfill all your desires.

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- c. Follow your dreams and you will one day achieve wealth, honor, and greatness.

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- d. Indulge yourself because you deserve it.

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- e. Success comes from believing you can achieve anything you desire.

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- f. Happiness is to look within ourselves and love whatever we find.

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- g. You are the center of your universe, and that is where you must be anchored.

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- h. Pursue your own goals and ambitions at whatever cost, and you will find happiness.

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- i. Trust your personal feelings and preferences and they will guide you to discover how great you truly are.

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- j. You are all that matters; seek as much pleasure as possible while life lasts.

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Now take a moment to review the exercise you have just carried out. Discuss in your group how the passages from the writings diverge completely from the kind of thinking that the statements articulate.

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The discussion you have undertaken must have made it clear to you that the young in today's society face an enormous challenge in striving to liberate themselves from those entrenched patterns of thinking that give free reign to the dictates of self and passion. To meet this challenge, they need to recognize the fallacy of numerous ideas to which they are constantly exposed and allow the truths enshrined in passages such as the above to infuse their thoughts and actions. What can families and communities do to assist them in this regard?

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6. What should be of great concern to us is how our intentions and deeds are viewed in the sight of God, and not how they are perceived by others. However, it is the latter that media and popular culture emphasize, fostering in people a craving for approval, for recognition and for praise. From childhood, individuals are encouraged to show off their talents and to exaggerate their accomplishments. If we are not vigilant, service to others in such a culture can easily become a means for bolstering ego and self-image. Of course, parents need to encourage their children to strive towards worthy goals but in a way that does not inflate the ego. Write below some words of encouragement that turn the attention of a youngster away from the insistent self and towards the Source from which noble thoughts and deeds originate. A few examples are provided below.

- How wonderful that you are making an effort and God is confirming you.
- It pleases God to see you serve others with love.
- How blessed you are to be able to learn the Word of God by heart and share it with others.
- When you study and use what you learn for the progress of your community, you are thanking God for the power of intellect He has bestowed on you.

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7. Another concept that requires attention here is related to the competitive spirit which is so often cultivated in youngsters with the aim of spurring them to excellence. What the spirit of competition actually does, among other things, is to give license to the insistent self. The basis for true excellence is not to be found in the desire to gain ascendancy over others but in the individual's innate attraction to beauty and perfection. Discuss how, in helping children learn the ways of harmony and develop the qualities needed for cooperation, we are aiding them to turn away from self and achieve excellence.

\_\_\_\_\_  
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\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

8. Now take some time to reflect on the last two quotations in the above sequence of ideas and discuss the following questions:
- Which type of ambition leads to discontent and which to lasting joy?
  - What are some worthy goals towards which parents can guide their children to aspire?
  - How does working towards the goals you have identified assist the young ones in the community to "hold in their souls the vision of celestial perfection" and to contribute to the "achievement on earth of a Heavenly civilization"?

## SECTION 11

"So far," Martin begins the next meeting among the small group of collaborators, "we have discussed a number of themes that are central to our efforts to nurture the young members of our community: the concept of human potential; the two natures of the human being, the higher and the lower; the significance of spiritual education at home in releasing the potential of children and in strengthening their higher nature; and the importance of their acquiring faith and certitude. We have also looked at the imperative to help our children guard against the promptings of the insistent self." "The question is," he continues, "in what direction should we take our exploration now?"

The group reflects on issues that have arisen in conversation with parents. Among them, the subject of discipline seems to be of particular concern. Some parents have expressed thoughts such as, "When we were children, we were obedient to our parents. We saw how hard they worked. We loved them and wanted to please them. But times have changed. Society is encouraging children to do as they please and even to defy their parents, whose moral authority is increasingly

undermined.” Below is the sequence of ideas the group organizes in the hope of addressing some of the concerns expressed.

In most discussions about discipline there is a tendency to think of two extreme approaches. One is dictatorial—that is, setting strict and rigid rules and resorting to harsh punishments for disobedience. The other approach is permissive; it gives unrestricted freedom to children and encourages them to indulge their every whim. In an environment characterized by permissiveness, youngsters grow to be self-centered. They come to think that the fulfillment of their desires and fancies is more important than anything else, and they find themselves captives of “self”.

To be sure, there is an appropriate approach to discipline that serves the aim of spiritual education. Just like young plants that need the care of a gardener to thrive and flourish, our children, too, need the kind of love from their parents that will impel them to work and strive and to put forth every effort to develop their full potential. Will not the plant that is pruned well by the gardener bear the most beautiful blossoms and the most abundant fruit? Children, who are just beginning to learn about this world, and whose powers of perception, discernment, and reasoning are only beginning to develop, require the loving discipline of their parents:

**“Love demands discipline, the courage to accustom children to hardship, not to indulge their whims or leave them entirely to their own devices.”<sup>74</sup>**

This discipline entails that they “lovingly but insistently be guided to live up to Bahá’í standards” and grow to serve the Cause and humanity:

**“... exert every effort to educate the children, so that from infancy they will be trained in Bahá’í conduct and the ways of God, and will, even as young plants, thrive and flourish in the soft-flowing waters that are the counsels and admonitions of the Blessed Beauty.”<sup>75</sup>**

**“He will pray that under your loving care and guidance this dear child may grow in body, as well as in spirit, and receive such a training as will enable him, later on, to wholeheartedly embrace and serve the Cause. This is indeed your most sacred obligation as Bahá’í parents, and upon the manner and degree of its fulfillment will assuredly depend the success and happiness of your family life.”<sup>76</sup>**

Moreover, parental discipline born of love trains children to distinguish right from wrong and that which is beautiful from that which is ugly:

**“The purport is this, that to train the character of humankind is one of the weightiest commandments of God, and the influence of such training is the same as that which the sun exerteth over tree and fruit. Children must be most carefully watched over, protected and trained; in such consisteth true parenthood and parental mercy.**

**“Otherwise, the children will turn into weeds growing wild . . . knowing not right from wrong, distinguishing not the highest of human qualities from all that is mean and vile . . .”<sup>77</sup>**

Discipline will naturally take different forms at different stages in the life of a child. At first, much of the discipline will come from the directives of parents who provide clear and consistent guidance to their children. Through the provision of appropriate reward and punishment, children will come to learn that there are consequences for both their actions and their inaction. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá counsels:

**“Therefore is it incumbent upon the mothers to rear their little ones even as a gardener tendeth his young plants. Let them strive by day and by night to establish within their children faith and certitude, the fear of God, the love of the Beloved of the worlds, and all good qualities and traits. Whensoever a mother seeth that her child hath done well, let her praise and applaud him and cheer his heart; and if the slightest undesirable trait should manifest itself, let her counsel the child and punish him, and use means based on reason, even a slight verbal chastisement should this be necessary. It is not, however, permissible to strike a child, or vilify him, for the child’s character will be totally perverted if he be subjected to blows or verbal abuse.”<sup>78</sup>**

Further, He says:

**“The child must not be oppressed or censured because it is undeveloped; it must be patiently trained.”<sup>79</sup>**

As children grow, they will have to acquire the inner discipline to be guided by the susceptibilities of the higher nature and, ultimately, to view the undertaking of an unseemly deed as punishment in itself:

**“Therefore must the individual be trained from his infancy in such a way that he will never undertake to commit a crime, will, rather, direct all his energies to the acquisition of excellence, and will look upon the very commission of an evil deed as in itself the harshest of all punishment, considering the sinful act itself to be far more grievous than any prison sentence. For it is possible so to train the individual that, although crime may not be completely done away with, still it will become very rare.”<sup>80</sup>**

Individuals should, from a young age, be assisted in understanding that, out of His infinite love for us, God has given us laws to guide us and to shield us. They should be helped to see that when, in our love for Him, we obey His commandments we find true freedom. Bahá’u’lláh states:

**“Observe My commandments, for the love of My beauty.”<sup>81</sup>**

**“Think not that We have revealed unto you a mere code of laws. Nay, rather, We have unsealed the choice Wine with the fingers of might and power.”<sup>82</sup>**

**“Know assuredly that My commandments are the lamps of My loving providence among My servants, and the keys of My mercy for My creatures.”<sup>83</sup>**

**“True liberty consisteth in man’s submission unto My commandments, little as ye know it. Were men to observe that which We have sent down unto them from the Heaven of Revelation, they would, of a certainty, attain unto perfect liberty. Happy is**

**the man that hath apprehended the Purpose of God in whatever He hath revealed from the Heaven of His Will that pervadeth all created things. Say: The liberty that profiteth you is to be found nowhere except in complete servitude unto God, the Eternal Truth. Whoso hath tasted of its sweetness will refuse to barter it for all the dominion of earth and heaven.”<sup>84</sup>**

Unfettered freedom, so aggressively promoted today, leads to discontentment in the individual and chaos and confusion in society. Parents, in educating their children, will do well to take the following warning of Bahá’u’lláh to heart:

**“Liberty must, in the end, lead to sedition, whose flames none can quench. Thus warneth you He Who is the Reckoner, the All-Knowing. Know ye that the embodiment of liberty and its symbol is the animal. That which beseemeth man is submission unto such restraints as will protect him from his own ignorance, and guard him against the harm of the mischief maker. Liberty causeth man to overstep the bounds of propriety, and to infringe on the dignity of his station. It debaseth him to the level of extreme depravity and wickedness.”<sup>85</sup>**

When youngsters learn to view obedience to the laws of God as an expression of their free will, their efforts to acquire perfections and to exercise initiative will contribute to the common good:

**“With respect to your discussion of the relationship between obedience to parents on the one hand and individual self-expression, freedom, and spiritual growth on the other, the House of Justice suggests an alternative understanding for your consideration. Although individual persons are responsible for their own actions and spiritual development, individuals do not exist in isolation, but as parts of families and communities. Deciding to forgo one’s personal wishes in deference to one’s parents—or to the institutions of the Faith, civil authorities, or the law for that matter—represents an expression of free will, not a curtailment of it. By choosing to obey, a child can contribute to unity of the family and thereby further the Cause of God.”<sup>86</sup>**

After reading and reflecting on the above sequence of ideas, you may turn to the exercises below.

1. Complete the following sentences:
  - a. Love demands \_\_\_\_\_, the \_\_\_\_\_ to \_\_\_\_\_ children to \_\_\_\_\_, not to \_\_\_\_\_ their whims or \_\_\_\_\_ to their \_\_\_\_\_.
  - b. With the \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ of parents, children are to grow in \_\_\_\_\_, as well as in \_\_\_\_\_.
  - c. They should receive such a training as will enable them, later on, to wholeheartedly \_\_\_\_\_.



- d. To \_\_\_\_\_ the \_\_\_\_\_ of humankind is one of the \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ of God.
  - e. The \_\_\_\_\_ of such training is the same as that which the \_\_\_\_\_ exerts  
over \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - f. Children must be most carefully \_\_\_\_\_ , \_\_\_\_\_ and  
\_\_\_\_\_ ; this constitutes true \_\_\_\_\_ and parental \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - g. If children are not carefully watched over, protected and trained, they will turn into  
\_\_\_\_\_ growing wild and will not know \_\_\_\_\_ from \_\_\_\_\_ or be  
able to distinguish the \_\_\_\_\_ of \_\_\_\_\_ from all that  
is \_\_\_\_\_ .
2. In light of the above passages, discuss the following questions with your group:
- a. Why does the love parents have for their children demand discipline?
  - b. What shape does discipline take without love?
  - c. Parents need to look for standards in the writings of the Faith; standards of conduct cannot be based on some arbitrary social norm that, at one or another time, is deemed appropriate. How should parents go about identifying and deepening their understanding of divine standards?
  - d. What happens when parents set standards of conduct for their children but do not abide by these standards themselves?
3. Decide which of the following are implied by the statement “Love demands discipline, the courage to accustom children to hardship”:
- \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should intentionally create difficult situations in order to train their children.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should help their children learn the discipline of completing a task, especially when it requires time and effort.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should help their children become accustomed to getting bullied.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should teach their children to uphold their integrity under trying circumstances.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should encourage their children to abandon all desires.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should help their children abandon whims and desires that are detrimental to themselves and to their families.

- \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should encourage their children to persevere in striving towards noble goals.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should help their children develop the vigor necessary for strenuous physical work.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should help their children focus their minds on important matters and on solving difficult problems.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should treat their children harshly.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should teach their children to serve with joy even under difficult circumstances.
  - \_\_\_\_\_ Parents should help their children develop the ability to overcome crises with calm determination.
4. In seeking advice on how to raise children, parents should be wary of certain ideas promoted in the name of autonomy and independence that sound appealing. Below are some pieces of advice, reflecting beliefs shaped by unrestricted individualism, that might be offered to a parent. Discuss them in your group and, for each one, think of some alternative words of advice in keeping with guidance found in the writings. In your deliberations, consider the relationship between individual autonomy and obedience to the teachings, between freedom and submission to the Will of God.
- Choice is something personal; parents should abstain from guiding their young children in the decisions they make.
  - Children should not be admonished when they do something wrong; they should figure out for themselves what is wrong and what is right.
  - Children should be given total autonomy in their affairs, otherwise they will not manifest their full potential.
  - Strength of character comes from independence of will. Therefore, parents should in no way curtail the freedom of children.
  - Children should be able to clarify their own feelings, their own beliefs, and their own value system without any outside interference.
  - Parents should support the choices made by children, even if they decide not to uphold moral standards.
  - Parents should never give answers that clarify what is right and wrong to any questions asked by children because doing so curtails their independence of thought.
  - Parents should not assume any authority on most matters; within the family, everyone—including young children—should have a vote on all decisions.

- Rebelliousness is to be encouraged as a healthy step on the way to adulthood; a degree of rebellion can help bring about the independence of the child.
  - To attain independence, youngsters should be taught to accept themselves as they are.
5. Parents must show forth a great deal of love and patience in training their children. Small acts to bring joy to the heart of the child, such as a warm acknowledgment of good behavior, will serve as a well-earned reward. Similarly, a simple gesture of displeasure often signals to a child that he or she is doing something wrong. When, on some occasions, a slight verbal chastisement may be needed, parents must ensure that it is done with respect for the dignity of the child. Which of the following should characterize the language used by parents to speak to their children?

|            |             |           |            |
|------------|-------------|-----------|------------|
| Harshness  | Anger       | Warmth    | Calmness   |
| Irritation | Care        | Annoyance | Gentleness |
| Love       | Frustration | Patience  | Firmness   |
| Moderation | Tenderness  | Aloofness | Respect    |

6. In Book 3, children’s class teachers are given the following advice: When it becomes necessary to apply small and appropriate sanctions, they should first clearly explain to a child why he or she is being sanctioned. They then need to apply the sanction immediately after the misbehavior occurs, otherwise the child will not be able to connect the punishment to the misconduct. In light of this advice, which is also applicable to parents, discuss in your group the following questions:
- a. Sometimes parents respond leniently to serious misconduct, while being overly punitive of small mistakes. Can you think of some examples? How might such inconsistency affect the conduct of a child?
  - b. Can parents, in their choice of sanction, create confusion in the minds of children? For example, there are many duties children should learn to carry out with joy. What would be the consequences of giving a child one of these duties as a sanction?
7. Misconceived notions of freedom and discipline give rise to approaches that are not conducive to the sound development of a child. The influence on a child’s character, when such approaches are adopted, becomes clearly manifest as he or she reaches the age of puberty. What might be observed in the character of a teenager whose parents followed one or more of the practices below in his or her training from an early age?
- Never saying no to a child
  - Ignoring misconduct
  - Offering external rewards in exchange for the fulfillment of duties

- Not expecting a child to follow standards of upright conduct unless an explanation that is acceptable to him or her is given on every occasion
  - Giving a child exaggerated praise
  - Shaming a child for mistakes
  - Never providing explanation for what is expected of a child
  - Comparing a child with others
  - Criticizing a child in front of others
  - Routinely withdrawing love as a consequence of misconduct
  - Striking a child now and again
8. Implicit in the sequence of ideas presented in this section is the understanding that proper training in childhood helps an individual to acquire inner discipline as he or she approaches maturity. You may find it useful to discuss in your group why the development of inner discipline is necessary not only if we are to uphold the standards of the Faith in our personal lives, as well as in our service to the Cause, but also if we are to excel in any field of human endeavor. Does such a discipline stifle creativity, as is commonly believed? Or does it, in fact, provide a channel for the proper expression and enhancement of the power of imagination?
9. In considering the question of discipline, parents often are faced with the challenge of how they can protect their children from the harmful influences of the media environment that surrounds them—the music they listen to, the films and television programs produced for their consumption, the video games designed for them, the messages that are exchanged on social media. How could the kind of conversation you have initiated among families offer an opportunity to explore strategies they could collectively develop to address this challenge? Such explorations would necessarily shed light on the habits and patterns of conduct that family life should foster. They would need to go further, however, to consider those elements of culture—songs, dramas, stories—that have emerged from the people’s interaction with the Word of God. How might such elements flourish and become more and more prevalent in the village or neighborhood?

## SECTION 12

A member of the Area Teaching Committee has come to visit the neighborhood to learn more about how the conversation on the education and upbringing of children is unfolding. He is encouraged to discover that there are now almost twenty families involved, as well as a few teachers from the neighborhood preschool and primary school. It seems that, some time ago, Maribel began sharing the insights she was gaining with other friends serving in the neighborhood, and a number of children’s class teachers subsequently joined the effort to extend the conversation to additional households. Many parents who were formerly unaware of the institute’s educational activities now want their children to participate in children’s classes and junior youth groups, and some of the young

mothers, including Gina and her friends, have shown an interest in serving as teachers for Grade 1. Maribel is in the process of preparing them for this service by taking them through the first few courses of the main sequence. The member of the Committee is greatly heartened by his visit.

Not long after, the two couples and Maribel, while consulting on recent developments, note how many thoughts the discussion around obedience and freedom elicited from parents. Those with sons and daughters in their early teens, in particular, expressed deep concern about the present social environment so laden with moral dangers. “Everyone seemed to catch a glimpse,” says Daniela, “of how a process of spiritual education, in seeking to foster certain attributes in the young, will help prepare them to confront the challenges they will be facing as they leave their childhood behind.” “That is true,” agrees Alejandra. “God willing, by the time they make the transition from early adolescence to the period of youth, they will have developed a strong sense of purpose that will enable them to withstand the negative forces operating in society.” The small group of coworkers are reminded of the following passage written on behalf of the Guardian:

**“We cannot segregate the human heart from the environment outside us and say that once one of these is reformed everything will be improved. Man is organic with the world. His inner life molds the environment and is itself also deeply affected by it. The one acts upon the other and every abiding change in the life of man is the result of these mutual reactions.**

**“No movement in the world directs its attention upon both these aspects of human life and has full measures for their improvement, save the teachings of Bahá’u’lláh. And this is its distinctive feature. If we desire therefore the good of the world we should strive to spread those teachings and also practice them in our own life. Through them will the human heart be changed, and also our social environment provides the atmosphere in which we can grow spiritually and reflect in full the light of God shining through the revelation of Bahá’u’lláh.”<sup>87</sup>**

“Reading these words again,” says Alejandra, “reminds me of the importance of the twofold moral purpose discussed in Book 5: to take charge of one’s own intellectual and spiritual growth and to contribute to the transformation of society. Is not one of the aims of the educational process we have been discussing over the past several weeks for young people to reach the stage where they understand and act on this twofold purpose?” The group decides that they should try to gain further insights into this aim. After looking into the writings, they develop the following sequence of ideas for exploration:

If we aim to raise our children simply to be good and to avoid harming others, they will not be able to resist the destructive forces of materialism, corruption and moral laxity gathering momentum in society. Without a strong sense of moral purpose, they will end up adopting the values that are aggressively propagated through television, music, film, and now social media. Young ones need to be assisted in gaining knowledge and skills and in acquiring spiritual qualities and praiseworthy attitudes and, at the same time, be encouraged to exert effort to contribute to the transformation of their communities. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá once said to a group of children:

**“My hope is that your parents may educate you spiritually and give you thorough moral training. May you develop so that each one of you shall become imbued with all the virtues of the human world. May you advance in all material and spiritual**

**degrees. May you become learned in sciences, acquire the arts and crafts, prove to be useful members of human society and assist the progress of human civilization.”<sup>88</sup>**

Just as in the womb one develops the physical faculties necessary for this life, in this world each of us must develop the heavenly powers required for the world beyond:

**“In the beginning of his life man was in the world of the womb, wherein he developed the capacity and worthiness to advance to this world. The powers necessary for this world he acquired in that world. He needed eyes in this world; he obtained them in the world of the womb. He needed ears in this world; he obtained them there. All the powers that were needed in this world he acquired in the world of the womb. In that world he became prepared for this world, and when he entered this world he saw that he possessed all the requisite powers and had acquired all the limbs and organs necessary for this life, in that world. It followeth that in this world too he must prepare for the world beyond. That which he needeth in the world of the Kingdom he must obtain and prepare here. Just as he acquired the powers necessary for this world in the world of the womb, so, likewise, he must obtain that which he will need in the world of the Kingdom—that is to say, all the heavenly powers—in this world.”<sup>89</sup>**

**“... just as, if human life in the womb were limited to that uterine world, existence there would be nonsensical, irrelevant—so too if the life of this world, the deeds here done and their fruitage, did not come forth in the world beyond, the whole process would be irrational and foolish.”<sup>90</sup>**

God’s purpose in sending His Manifestations is to guide us so that in this world we can develop the spiritual qualities and powers required for the soul’s eternal journey towards His presence:

**“The purpose of the one true God in manifesting Himself is to summon all mankind to truthfulness and sincerity, to piety and trustworthiness, to resignation and submissiveness to the Will of God, to forbearance and kindliness, to uprightness and wisdom. His object is to array every man with the mantle of a saintly character, and to adorn him with the ornament of holy and goodly deeds.”<sup>91</sup>**

These powers and qualities do not appear spontaneously, nor are they developed in a vacuum; they are purposefully acquired in action as we strive to contribute to the betterment of the world:

**“This Wronged One testifieth that the purpose for which mortal men have, from utter nothingness, stepped into the realm of being, is that they may work for the betterment of the world and live together in concord and harmony.”<sup>92</sup>**

**“All men have been created to carry forward an ever-advancing civilization.”<sup>93</sup>**

Service is the arena in which the pursuit of one’s own intellectual and spiritual growth is harmonized with one’s efforts to advance civilization:

**“God has given us eyes, that we may look about us at the world, and lay hold of whatsoever will further civilization and the arts of living. He has given us ears, that**

**we may hear and profit by the wisdom of scholars and philosophers and arise to promote and practice it. Senses and faculties have been bestowed upon us, to be devoted to the service of the general good; so that we, distinguished above all other forms of life for perceptiveness and reason, should labor at all times and along all lines, whether the occasion be great or small, ordinary or extraordinary, until all mankind are safely gathered into the impregnable stronghold of knowledge. We should continually be establishing new bases for human happiness and creating and promoting new instrumentalities toward this end. How excellent, how honorable is man if he arises to fulfill his responsibilities; how wretched and contemptible, if he shuts his eyes to the welfare of society and wastes his precious life in pursuing his own selfish interests and personal advantages. Supreme happiness is man's, and he beholds the signs of God in the world and in the human soul, if he urges on the steed of high endeavor in the arena of civilization and justice.”<sup>94</sup>**

**“That one indeed is a man who, today, dedicateth himself to the service of the entire human race. The Great Being saith: Blessed and happy is he that ariseth to promote the best interests of the peoples and kindreds of the earth.”<sup>95</sup>**

While one is actively engaged in service, one's heart, detached from all things, should turn to the Kingdom of God:

**“Bahá'u'lláh has thereby encouraged action and stimulated service. But the energies of the heart must not be attached to these things; the soul must not be completely occupied with them. Though the mind is busy, the heart must be attracted toward the Kingdom of God in order that the virtues of humanity may be attained from every direction and source.”<sup>96</sup>**

The highest aim of education must be to help each succeeding generation draw closer to the vision of a “new race of men”, those who will rise above the material conditions of the world and dedicate all their efforts to the upliftment of their fellow human beings.

**“A race of men, incomparable in character, shall be raised up which, with the feet of detachment, will tread under all who are in heaven and on earth, and will cast the sleeve of holiness over all that hath been created from water and clay.”<sup>97</sup>**

**“The children who are trained in the world-embracing teachings of Bahá'u'lláh cannot but grow up to be a truly new race of men. He hopes these young people will prepare themselves for the great task which will face them in the future, that of helping to rebuild the world with the aid and inspiration of the Bahá'í teachings.”<sup>98</sup>**

By now, you have grown accustomed to rereading the paragraphs and quotations, reflecting on the theme carefully, and learning the content well as you prepare for your own visits. Take some time to do this here and then carry out the following exercises:

1. ‘Abdu'l-Bahá likens this physical world to the world of the womb; just as a human being develops physical organs necessary for this world in the womb of the mother, he or she must acquire here the spiritual and heavenly powers that are needed for the next world. We, therefore, view this world from a perspective that diverges from certain other widespread perspectives. For example, we do not consider this world to be merely a place

for one's own enjoyment and satisfaction, or a place rife with pain and suffering that has to be endured, or a place filled with allurements from which we must flee in order to attain spiritual perfection. Discuss in your group how holding to such views would lead to approaches to life that hinder the development of powers necessary for the next world. Why is making effort to transform this world essential to our preparation for the next?

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2. How does the awareness that life on earth is but one small portion of our eternal journey towards God enable us to channel our sense of purpose in a proper direction? What are some appropriate ways in which parents can foster this awareness in their children from a young age?

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3. Completing the sentences below will help you reflect on the two dimensions of the sense of purpose that should shape the life of a youngster as she or he grows into an adult:

- a. The purpose of the one true God in \_\_\_\_\_ is to summon all mankind to \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, to \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, to \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ to the Will of God, to \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, to \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_.
- b. God's object in manifesting Himself is to \_\_\_\_\_ every man with the \_\_\_\_\_, and to \_\_\_\_\_ him with the \_\_\_\_\_.



- c. The purpose for which human beings have been created is that they may \_\_\_\_\_  
for \_\_\_\_\_ and live together in \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_.
- d. The purpose for which human beings have been created is to \_\_\_\_\_  
an \_\_\_\_\_.
- e. God has given us \_\_\_\_\_, that we may \_\_\_\_\_ us at the  
\_\_\_\_\_, and lay hold of whatsoever will \_\_\_\_\_  
and the \_\_\_\_\_.
- f. God has given us \_\_\_\_\_, that we may \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ by the wisdom  
of scholars and philosophers and \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_.
- g. God has given us \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, that we may be devoted to  
the \_\_\_\_\_; so that we, distinguished above all  
other forms of life for \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, should \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, whether the occasion be \_\_\_\_\_  
or \_\_\_\_\_, \_\_\_\_\_ or \_\_\_\_\_, until all mankind  
are \_\_\_\_\_ into the impregnable \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_.
4. We are aware that our development as individuals is inseparable from our efforts to  
contribute to the transformation of society. In fact, these two aspects of moral purpose are  
intimately connected and reinforce one another. Let us consider the implications of giving  
prominence to one at the expense of the other by answering the questions below. As you  
do so, think about the educational process in which you have been engaged since you began  
your study of the institute courses, a process that has helped to strengthen in you a sense  
of this twofold purpose.
- a. The practice of ascetism, which is prohibited in the writings of the Faith, is an extreme  
example of devoting attention to the development of the inner self at the expense of  
any contribution to social good. Of course, there are less extreme examples. How can  
each of the following result from a focus on developing one's own intellectual or even  
spiritual powers in isolation from conscious effort to contribute to the transformation  
of society?

Egotism: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

Self-righteousness: \_\_\_\_\_

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Guilt: \_\_\_\_\_

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Sense of superiority: \_\_\_\_\_

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Loss of objectivity: \_\_\_\_\_

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- b. History is rife with cases of those whose strong sense of purpose to bring about change in society was distorted, resulting in acts of cruelty and oppression. How can the following be manifested by an individual who has a strong sense of purpose but does not pay equal attention to the acquisition of spiritual qualities that direct it along appropriate channels?

Insensitivity to the legitimate needs and aspirations of others: \_\_\_\_\_

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Loss of compassion: \_\_\_\_\_

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Disregard for human dignity: \_\_\_\_\_

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Intolerance for the shortcomings of others: \_\_\_\_\_

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Dishonesty: \_\_\_\_\_

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Hypocrisy: \_\_\_\_\_

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Desire to control others: \_\_\_\_\_

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5. Bahá'u'lláh states that the true human being must dedicate himself to the service of the entire human race. Service helps us bring the two aspects of our moral purpose together. As we act, we improve the conditions of the world around us and, in the process, grow spiritually and intellectually and gain new capacities. The more we act, the more we grow, and the more capable we become of rendering service to humanity. Discuss this idea in light of the path of service on which you are embarked. How do the acts of service that define it steer us away from the dangers mentioned in the above exercise?

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6. In most societies, children shoulder family responsibilities from an early age. For instance, they care for their younger siblings and help with cleaning, cooking, and other household chores. How does taking on these responsibilities develop nascent capacities in children that can later be extended to service in the community as they enter the period of early adolescence, a stage in life when consciousness is expanded and intellectual abilities are broadened and deepened?

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7. Too often goodness is presented to youngsters as a passive thing. Parents can fall into the trap of lecturing their children, giving moralizing speeches, and reducing praiseworthy conduct to a list of dos and don'ts. At best, such measures elicit temporary compliance, and at worst they lead to indifference and apathy, especially as children grow older. In contrast, inculcating in children a strong sense of twofold purpose creates in them joy and motivation to learn and to act. As they approach their mid-teens, they are empowered to take charge of their own spiritual and intellectual growth and contribute to the transformation of society. They still need the guidance of their parents in the decisions they make, in the social spaces they choose to frequent, and in the friendships they form. Yet parents should not view them as fragile beings who must be protected from outside influences. Quite the opposite. They can learn to stand up for good and combat ignorance and injustice. The junior youth spiritual empowerment program, now present in most localities, is helping youngsters to do just that, by joining study with service to the community. How can parents reinforce the aims of the program and ensure their sons and daughters receive its full benefit? What are some characteristics that distinguish conversations in the home that can generate enthusiasm in children to develop their powers and contribute, as they grow older, to the transformation of the world?

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8. We cannot disregard the powerful social forces—many of which are associated with the processes of disintegration—to which children will be increasingly exposed as they grow up. The family has to be the environment in which the spiritual strength to resist these forces can be developed. What are some characteristics of the family environment that can help children combat the following forces?

Violence and aggression: \_\_\_\_\_

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## SECTION 13

It may be worthwhile for you to pause here and reflect on how the conversation you are fostering in your village or neighborhood is unfolding. To begin, think about how it has grown in terms of the number of those involved. How has this growth been achieved? Besides the household visit, what other spaces have opened up for you to promote the conversation? Have you found it possible, for example, to engage those in a regular devotional gathering in a discussion around the quotations on a given theme? You should consider, as well, the extent to which the number of those involved in the conversation grew through natural connections between families and friends in your neighborhood or village, as it did in our story through Gina. Below is some space for you to write down your observations.

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Now, beyond the expansion of the conversation in terms of numbers involved, there is the propagation of the ideas and concepts discussed, which, it is expected, would occur in a natural way. One could imagine, for example, that Gina and her friends would begin to introduce insights gleaned from the conversation in their day-to-day interactions—in gatherings with relatives and among members of their extended families, in meetings of parent-teacher associations, in family consultations. In this connection, referring to villages and neighborhoods such as yours that have become centers of intense activity, the Universal House of Justice states:

**“Where the implementation of core activities is accompanied with ongoing and rich conversation about associated Bahá’í teachings and the Person of Bahá’u’lláh, the influence of the Faith permeates an ever-broader cross section of the population. Thus, in a natural and unobtrusive way, a wide array of individuals and families grow in their familiarity with the teachings of Bahá’u’lláh and the nature of His Mission. In their own lives and in the life of the community, they begin to witness and to experience the transformation that comes from exposure to and interaction with the Word of God, including its practical application.”<sup>99</sup>**

Do you have any anecdotes that show how insights on the education and upbringing of children addressed in the conversation have begun to propagate themselves in the wider population?

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## SECTION 14

Following the discussion on the theme of twofold purpose, our small group of friends think it is timely to take up a topic of particular significance: relationships within the family and their effect on the development of children. So many of the patterns of interaction within the family unit—some persisting from the past and others shaped by current societal forces—must be transformed in keeping with the vision of humanity’s approaching maturity. This, of course, is a theme that requires much thought, and it will surely elicit a great deal of discussion among those you visit. Below is an initial set of ideas, similar to the one that the friends in our story might have prepared, for your study and reflection, together with some related exercises.

Humanity passes through various phases in its development, phases that can be likened to the stages of growth in the life of an individual: infancy, childhood, adolescence, and adulthood. It is our view that in our collective life we have passed the stages of infancy and childhood and entered the turbulent period of adolescence, and we now stand at the threshold of maturity, a stage which will see the unification of the entire human race. As humanity advances towards maturity, the relationships that bind society together—those between the individual, the institutions, and the community—must be increasingly characterized by cooperation, reciprocity, and mutual support. Qualities such as love, justice and generosity should more and more be manifested within the family—the most fundamental unit of society—and then extended to interactions in the community. Children should grow up in environments free from relationships tainted by contention, dominance, control, and manipulation, as well as those given to permissiveness and laxity. We must labor diligently to transform the relationships within our families according to those standards that are to distinguish a mature humanity.

Regarding love and unity within the family, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá says:

**“Note ye how easily, where unity existeth in a given family, the affairs of that family are conducted; what progress the members of that family make, how they prosper in the world. Their concerns are in order, they enjoy comfort and tranquility, they are secure, their position is assured, they come to be envied by all. Such a family but addeth to its stature and its lasting honor, as day succeedeth day.”<sup>100</sup>**

**“If love and agreement are manifest in a single family, that family will advance, become illumined and spiritual; but if enmity and hatred exist within it, destruction and dispersion are inevitable.”<sup>101</sup>**

‘Abdu’l-Bahá, regarding the integrity of the family bond, explains the following:

**“According to the teachings of Bahá’u’lláh the family, being a human unit, must be educated according to the rules of sanctity. All the virtues must be taught the family. The integrity of the family bond must be constantly considered, and the rights of the individual members must not be transgressed. The rights of the son, the father, the mother—none of them must be transgressed, none of them must be arbitrary. Just as the son has certain obligations to his father, the father, likewise, has certain obligations to his son. The mother, the sister and other members of the household have their certain prerogatives. All these rights and prerogatives must be conserved, yet the unity of the family must be sustained. The injury of one shall be considered the injury of all; the comfort of each, the comfort of all; the honor of one, the honor of all.”<sup>102</sup>**

The Universal House of Justice further states that the “relationship between family members represents a complex of mutual and complementary duties and responsibilities” and that, when these duties and responsibilities are carried out within the family, they “are conducive to its unity”.

Parents, of course, have many duties towards their children, not least among them, the duty of tending to their spiritual and material education; children, in turn, should strive to bring gladness to the hearts of their parents:

**“Bahá’u’lláh has placed great emphasis on the duties of parents toward their children, and He has urged children to have gratitude in their hearts for their parents, whose good pleasure they should strive to win as a means of pleasing God Himself.”<sup>103</sup>**

**“There should be a spirit of mutual respect and consideration between parents and children, in which the children turn to their parents for advice and direction, and the parents train and nurture their offspring. The fruit of this relationship is that the children grow into adulthood with their powers of discrimination and judgment refined, so that they can steer the course of their lives in a manner most conducive to their welfare.”<sup>104</sup>**

The patterns of behavior and interaction that children learn in the home environment will be carried to other spheres of human activity:

**“The family unit, the nucleus of human society, constitutes a space within which praiseworthy morals and essential capacities must be developed, for the habits and patterns of conduct nurtured in the home are carried into the workplace, into the social and political life of the country, and finally into the arena of international relations.”<sup>105</sup>**

Changes in the character of relationships within families are clearly visible in villages and neighborhoods where a growing number of people are ready to take part in the transformative process set in motion by the institute, as noted by the House of Justice:

**“Through participation in the educational process promoted by the training institute, they are motivated to reject the torpor and indifference inculcated by the forces of**



**society and pursue, instead, patterns of action which prove life altering. Where this approach has advanced for some years in a neighborhood or village and the friends have sustained their focus, remarkable results are becoming gradually but unmistakably evident. . . . The character of relationships within families—molded by assumptions centuries old—alters perceptibly.”<sup>106</sup>**

If relationships of dominance and contention are to be transformed into those befitting a mature humanity, our entire conception of power must undergo change. Although the following message from the House of Justice was written in the context of political processes, it has a bearing on the type of power that sometimes comes into play in family relationships:

**“Clearly the concept of power as a means of domination, with the accompanying notions of contest, contention, division and superiority, must be left behind. This is not to deny the operation of power; after all, even in cases where institutions of society have received their mandates through the consent of the people, power is involved in the exercise of authority. But political processes, like other processes of life, should not remain unaffected by the powers of the human spirit that the Bahá’í Faith—for that matter, every great religious tradition that has appeared throughout the ages—hopes to tap: the power of unity, of love, of humble service, of pure deeds. Associated with power in this sense are words such as ‘release’, ‘encourage’, ‘channel’, ‘guide’ and ‘enable’. Power is not a finite entity which is to be ‘seized’ and ‘jealously guarded’; it constitutes a limitless capacity to transform that resides in the human race as a body.”<sup>107</sup>**

1. Completing the sentences below will help you reflect on the importance of love and unity within the family.
  - a. Where unity exists in a given family, the affairs \_\_\_\_\_.
  - b. Where unity exists in a given family, the members \_\_\_\_\_.
  - c. Where unity exists in a given family, they \_\_\_\_\_.
  - d. Where unity exists in a given family, their concerns \_\_\_\_\_.
  - e. Where unity exists in a given family, they enjoy \_\_\_\_\_.
  - f. Where unity exists in a given family, they are \_\_\_\_\_.
  - g. Where unity exists in a given family, their position \_\_\_\_\_.
  - h. Where unity exists in a given family, they come \_\_\_\_\_.
  - i. Such a family but \_\_\_\_\_ to its \_\_\_\_\_ and its \_\_\_\_\_, as day succeeds day.
  - j. If \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ are manifest in a single family, that family will \_\_\_\_\_, become \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_.

- k. If \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ exist within a family, \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ are \_\_\_\_\_ .
2. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us that every member of the family—the mother, the father, the son, the daughter, the brother, the sister—has certain rights and certain obligations. Can you say a few words explaining your understanding of the relationship between the rights of each and the responsibilities he or she has towards the other members and towards the unity and welfare of the entire family?
- \_\_\_\_\_
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3. To reflect further on rights and responsibilities within the family, discuss the following questions:
- a. What would be the result of each member thinking only of his or her own interests with no consideration for the unity of the family as a whole?
- b. What would happen if everyone insisted on advancing his or her own interests without fulfilling his or her obligations? Would the integrity of the family be maintained in such a state?
- c. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us, “All the virtues must be taught the family.” Is it possible for spiritual qualities such as generosity, forgiveness, and compassion to be manifested within a home where every member of the family is primarily concerned with his or her own interests?
4. Parents are responsible for guiding their children in such a way as to refine their powers of discrimination and judgment, so that upon reaching adulthood “they can steer the course

of their lives in a manner most conducive to their welfare.” During this age of transition in the life of humanity, the enhancement of these powers in youngsters takes on particular significance. As the disintegration of the old order accelerates, they should develop capacities that will enable them to grasp how its disruptive force influences people’s minds and hearts. So, too, must they be capable of discerning the constructive power inherent in the processes of integration, processes to which they must consecrate all their energies. What is the nature of the challenge youngsters today face in trying to discriminate between each of the following? What are some of the concepts they should understand if they are to develop the necessary powers of discrimination and judgment? What spiritual qualities, habits of mind, and attitudes do they need to acquire?

Right and wrong: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

Truth and falsehood: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

What is beneficial and what causes harm: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

What leads to honor and what leads to abasement: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

5. A healthy and harmonious family is one in which operate those spiritual principles that should guide the affairs of society. Write a few words about how each of the following interrelated principles can contribute to the well-being of a family:

The equality of men and women: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

Justice: \_\_\_\_\_

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Cooperation and reciprocity: \_\_\_\_\_

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6. The teachings of the Faith call upon us to transcend all limited expressions of love. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us that the love of family is limited; it is not uncommon to see members of the same family who disagree or even dislike each other. Love for the people of one’s country, likewise, is finite; it can cause animosity towards all others, and even fellow countrymen dispute amongst themselves. Love of race is also limited; a person may love the people of his or her own race and resent all others, and there are even people of the same race who dislike each other. Political love is also uncertain; it is bound up with the contempt of one party for the other. Love for all humanity is the one perfect, limitless, and universal love; it can only be achieved, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá says, by the power of the Divine Spirit. So it is that He urges us all to grow in the light of the Sun of Truth and, reflecting this luminous love unto all humankind, to become united in its radiance. Discuss how the relations within a family might improve when every member aspires to reflect universal love.
7. The Universal House of Justice mentions that participants in the educational process promoted by the training institute are motivated to reject the torpor and indifference inculcated by the forces of society and to adopt new patterns of action. Discuss with the members of your group some of the changes in the character of relationships within the family that are emerging in your own community as the courses of the institute take root.
8. In society today, it is not unusual to observe in relationships among family members the operation of the type of power associated with domination and contest. Everyone acknowledges that this leads to an unhealthy family environment. What is not generally recognized is that the fundamental relationships that sustain society, including those within the family, will only be reshaped and transformed when humanity, during its passage to maturity, learns to draw on the powers of the human spirit. Consider the following powers. How does drawing on them close the door to control, manipulation, domination, and contention in family relationships? Write some of your thoughts in the spaces provided.

The power of selfless love: \_\_\_\_\_

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The power of humble service: \_\_\_\_\_

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The power of pure deeds: \_\_\_\_\_

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The power of wisdom and intellect: \_\_\_\_\_

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The power of inner perception: \_\_\_\_\_

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The power of refined and moderate speech: \_\_\_\_\_

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9. There is a tendency in the world at large to pass blame for the shortcomings of the education of the younger generation to different entities: parents accuse schools and teachers for their failure to raise intellectually sound individuals; schools blame parents for not bringing up children who can go through the rigor of academic training; and both hold the community and the structures that govern society responsible, at least in part. As community-building efforts advance, such contentious attitudes cannot but change. All must work together in a spirit of learning and collaboration. Think of a school in your neighborhood or village, or one nearby with which you are familiar. Can you give some examples of how the protagonists mentioned above—parents, the school and teachers, the community and the structures that govern society—might collaborate for the progress and well-being of youngsters?

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10. Children must be assisted in recognizing that the source of all power is God. They need to learn that it is in acknowledging our powerlessness and utter poverty before Him that we are inspired to draw on the ocean of His riches. In helping to cultivate within the hearts of children this relationship with their Creator, you may wish to reflect on the following passage from one of the prayers of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá:

**“How can I succeed unless Thou assist me with the breath of the Holy Spirit, help me to triumph by the hosts of Thy glorious kingdom, and shower upon me Thy confirmations, which alone can change a gnat into an eagle, a drop of water into rivers and seas, and an atom into lights and suns?”<sup>108</sup>**

## SECTION 15

To help you reflect further on the nature of the transformation required in relations among family members, as well as between the family and community, three interrelated themes are presented in this and the next two sections. Here you will look at the theme of rectitude of conduct, which is followed by the importance of purity in Section 16 and freedom from prejudice in Section 17. In reviewing each theme and in carrying out the corresponding exercises, you should be thinking, as always, about how you can draw on the concepts and ideas to further the conversation you are promoting in your village or neighborhood.

One of the features of a mature society is that families will carry out their affairs with rectitude of conduct. The image of a straight path on which we walk individually and collectively helps us gain insight into the nature of such rectitude.

**“The straight path is the one which guideth man to the dayspring of perception and to the dawning-place of true understanding and leadeth him to that which will redound to glory, honor and greatness.”<sup>109</sup>**

The laws and principles of the Faith guide our steps on this path and illumine it with the light of truth. In this connection, the Universal House of Justice reminds us that the Guardian

**“appealed to the believers to exemplify rectitude of conduct in every aspect of their lives—in their business dealings, in their domestic lives, in all manner of employment, in every service they render to the Cause and to their people—and to observe its requirements in their uncompromising adherence to the laws and principles of the Faith.”<sup>110</sup>**

An individual who acts with rectitude of conduct displays justice, equity, truthfulness, honesty, fair-mindedness, and trustworthiness—spiritual qualities that are a reflection of divine attributes in the mirror of the human heart. A family exemplifying rectitude of conduct manifests these same qualities in the management of its own affairs and in its efforts to contribute to the betterment of the community. The honor and integrity of a family lie in how such qualities shape its relationships, both among its members and with others. The teachings of Bahá’u’lláh shed a much greater light on spiritual qualities than any that has guided human understanding in the past. Let us first consider justice.

At the level of the individual, justice is that faculty of the human soul which enables one to see with one's own eyes.

**“O Son of Spirit! The best beloved of all things in My sight is Justice; turn not away therefrom if thou desirest Me, and neglect it not that I may confide in thee. By its aid thou shalt see with thine own eyes and not through the eyes of others, and shalt know of thine own knowledge and not through the knowledge of thy neighbor. Ponder this in thy heart; how it behooveth thee to be. Verily justice is My gift to thee and the sign of My loving-kindness. Set it then before thine eyes.”<sup>111</sup>**

To see, by the aid of justice, with our own eyes, we need to free ourselves from idle fancy and imitation:

**“The essence of all that We have revealed for thee is Justice, is for man to free himself from idle fancy and imitation, discern with the eye of oneness His glorious handiwork, and look into all things with a searching eye.”<sup>112</sup>**

Justice is also a universal quality that must operate at all levels of society; it trains the world, obliterates oppression and is the cause of unity:

**“That which traineth the world is justice, for it is upheld by two pillars, reward and punishment. These two pillars are the sources of life to the world.”<sup>113</sup>**

**“By the righteousness of God! Justice is a powerful force. It is, above all else, the conqueror of the citadels of the hearts and souls of men, and the revealer of the secrets of the world of being, and the standard-bearer of love and bounty.”<sup>114</sup>**

**“The light of men is Justice. Quench it not with the contrary winds of oppression and tyranny. The purpose of justice is the appearance of unity among men.”<sup>115</sup>**

**“We entreat God to deliver the light of equity and the sun of justice from the thick clouds of waywardness, and cause them to shine forth upon men. No light can compare with the light of justice. The establishment of order in the world and the tranquility of the nations depend upon it.”<sup>116</sup>**

Justice and truth are intimately connected:

**“... happy are they that have recognized the Truth; happy are they that judge with fairness in all matters and hold fast to the Cord of My inviolable Justice.”<sup>117</sup>**

**“Verily, justice is a lamp that guideth man aright amidst the darkness of the world and shieldeth him from every danger.”<sup>118</sup>**

Justice interacts with a host of other spiritual qualities, among them generosity and compassion:

**“... if thine eyes be turned towards justice, choose thou for thy neighbor that which thou choosest for thyself.”<sup>119</sup>**

**“O ye beloved of the Lord! The Kingdom of God is founded upon equity and justice, and also upon mercy, compassion, and kindness to every living soul.”<sup>120</sup>**

**“Ye are the fruits of one tree and the leaves of one branch; be ye compassionate and kind to all the human race. Deal ye with strangers the same as with friends, cherish ye others just as ye would your own.”<sup>121</sup>**

**“Be ye the trustees of God amongst His creatures, and the emblems of His generosity amidst His people.”<sup>122</sup>**

To carry out our personal and collective affairs with rectitude of conduct, we must hold fast to the highest standards of truthfulness and honesty, shun hypocrisy, and combat corruption:

**“Truthfulness is the goodliest of qualities as it comprehendeth all other virtues. A truthful person will be protected from all moral afflictions, will shrink from every evil deed, and be preserved from every wicked act, inasmuch as all vices and misdeeds are the very antithesis of truthfulness, and a truthful man will hold them all in utter abhorrence.”<sup>123</sup>**

**“He is the true servant of God, who, in this day, were he to pass through cities of silver and gold, would not deign to look upon them, and whose heart would remain pure and undefiled from whatever things can be seen in this world, be they its goods or its treasures. I swear by the Sun of Truth! The breath of such a man is endowed with potency, and his words with attraction.”<sup>124</sup>**

**“Only if you demonstrate the rectitude of conduct to which the writings of the Faith call every soul will you be able to struggle against the myriad forms of corruption, overt and subtle, eating at the vitals of society.”<sup>125</sup>**

When we exercise justice, equity, truthfulness and honesty, we become worthy of the trust of our fellow human beings. Trustworthiness is the principal means by which a family, a community and society at large achieves prosperity.

**“... trustworthiness is the chief means of attracting confirmation and prosperity. We entreat God to make of it a radiant and mercifully showering rain-cloud that shall bring success and blessings to thy affairs. He of a truth is the All-Bountiful, the Gracious.”<sup>126</sup>**

1. To reflect further on the theme of rectitude of conduct, complete the following sentences:
  - a. The straight path guides us to \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_.
  - b. The straight path leads us to \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_.



- c. We are called upon to exemplify rectitude of conduct in \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ and to observe its requirements \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ .
2. It is the light that shines forth from the laws and principles of the Faith that illuminates the straight path, and living in accordance with these divine laws and principles is an indispensable condition of rectitude of conduct. Yet we hear more and more these days that parents are not supposed to instill values in their children. They should learn to discover their own values in accordance with their personal preferences and inclinations. Parents should then support whatever moral code their children adopt. Of course, when parents do step aside, children are not making moral choices in a vacuum, for popular culture has no qualms in imposing on them, under the guise of neutrality, its standard, captured in the following statement: “All values are equal.” Often those who defend this motto have not thoughtfully considered its implications. Below are several pairs of statements that reflect values which clearly contradict each other. What would be the consequences of conveying the message to children in their upbringing, whether consciously or not, that the two are equivalent? How might youngsters be affected if they do not learn to recognize their incompatibility?
- selfless service to humanity
  - self-promotion in the service one performs
- \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
- generation of wealth in a way that improves the material conditions of many
  - accumulation of wealth to gain power and prestige
- \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
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- sacrifice of lower passions for that which is higher in human nature
  - gratification of lower passions regardless of the consequences
- \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

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- love for the entire human family
  - love for one’s own country above all others
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- excellence in work
  - expediency in work
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- focus given to the powers of the mind and the qualities of the soul
  - preoccupation with physical looks and fashionable adornments
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3. Some hold to the view that an unchangeable feature of human existence is that different groups and individuals in society espouse irreconcilable values. Such a view leads to moral relativism, a position in which religion is considered but one among many belief systems. A family that strives to manage its affairs with rectitude of conduct rejects moral relativism; it aspires to live according to the laws and principles of the Faith. Listed below are three such principles. Add a few others and then discuss the significance of upholding these principles in the home, not only for the education of children but also for the unity, honor and progress of the family as a whole.

- Abstaining from backbiting
- Treating sons and daughters equally in all respects
- Investigating reality in all matters

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4. Based on the quotations you have studied in this section, write as many sentences as possible that describe justice. An example has been provided below.

The best beloved of all things in God's sight is justice.

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5. With the above statements you have written in mind, discuss the following questions:

- a. How does the knowledge we derive from studying the writings of the Faith and from our efforts to translate them into action help us acquire the spiritual quality of justice—the quality that aids us in seeing with our own eyes? How do blind imitation and idle fancy hamper its development?
- b. In society today, the concept of justice to which children are generally exposed focuses merely on rights and entitlements. Unfortunately, then, their thinking about justice tends to be shaped solely by what they believe they deserve, by what they consider is fair to them. What are the consequences, for the individual and for society, of human beings becoming driven from a young age to passionately defend their own rights without learning at the same time to show forth compassion, generosity, and forgiveness?
- c. Even when the notion of fairness is evoked in defending the rights of others, the language employed can be individualistic. So often, the responsibility individuals must shoulder to ensure that the entire community prospers is ignored. A young person must therefore be guided to appreciate that justice requires the achievement of harmony between individual welfare and collective prosperity. Which of the following convictions would help him or her develop a proper understanding of the requirements of justice in the social realm?

\_\_\_\_\_ Justice requires that each individual's rights are defended—this, irrespective of considerations for the well-being of society.

\_\_\_\_\_ The rights of the individual members of society will always conflict with demands imposed by social structures.

\_\_\_\_\_ The interconnectedness of all things suggests that the well-being of any one individual or any one human group is closely linked to the prosperity of the whole.

- \_\_\_\_\_ Conflicts of interest between individuals and groups is an inherent feature of social existence, not susceptible to change.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Harmony between individual welfare and collective prosperity is not only possible but is, indeed, an inevitable feature of humanity's coming of age.
- \_\_\_\_\_ So long as the rights of individuals and groups are pitted against one another we will not be able to advance towards a just society.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Individual welfare and collective prosperity will be harmonized as individuals in growing numbers work selflessly for the betterment of the world.
6. We will not be able to achieve lofty goals if we use means that are inconsistent with high moral standards. The purpose of justice is the appearance of unity among human beings. Justice will not be achieved through means that are the very antithesis of its purpose—through violence, contention, and strife. Which of the following statements would help a young person grasp this idea and which would create misunderstanding and confusion in his or her mind? Mark them with a “G” or an “M” accordingly.
- \_\_\_\_\_ It is sometimes necessary to use violence to fight injustice.
- \_\_\_\_\_ The causes of injustice can best be brought to light through strife and contention.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Violence, even when it is used to support a just cause, destroys human dignity.
- \_\_\_\_\_ The creation of a just society can only be achieved through means that engender greater mutual understanding and unity among people.
- \_\_\_\_\_ Any instrument that increases hatred and discord places formidable obstacles on the path towards justice.
- \_\_\_\_\_ A society without compassion and generosity cannot be a truly just society.
- \_\_\_\_\_ The exercise of justice gives rise to greater cooperation and reciprocity among people.
7. Justice is upheld by the two pillars of reward and punishment. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá states: “An individual has no right to seek revenge, but the body politic has the right to punish the criminal. Such punishment is intended to dissuade and deter others from committing similar crimes. It is for the protection of the rights of man and does not constitute revenge, for revenge is that inner gratification that results from returning like for like.” In a society where revenge is encouraged and glorified through movies and social media, how can the young ones be helped to see how hollow and short-lived is the inner gratification that results from it and how damaging it is to the soul to return like for like?
8. The sense of justice that is to characterize the relationships among families in a community is inseparable from the qualities of generosity and compassion. Consider the following situations:

- The drinking water supply in a portion of a neighborhood is found to be contaminated with lead from aging pipes. The consumption of such water can cause severe health issues. Should only those families whose water supply is affected work to alleviate the situation or should other families in the community also extend their assistance to resolve the problem?
- A new school building is to be erected. Should it be centrally located and convenient for most children in the community or should it be closer to the homes of those families who can pay for its construction?
- There is a natural disaster and the homes of ten families in a village are damaged. Should the other families in the community contribute to the reconstruction of the damaged homes?
- A bridge to cross a river is built very close to the fields that belong to a few families. Should these families leave a narrow path on the periphery of their fields to allow everyone easy access to the bridge? Or should they plant on all available land and block easy access to the bridge for others?
- There are a few elderly people in the neighborhood who live on their own. When an epidemic disrupts the supply of food and basic necessities, should not the other families in the community organize among themselves to make sure that these individuals have what they need?

Now think of situations, similar to the ones above, that you may have encountered in your own village or neighborhood. Drawing on these situations, describe how relationships among families can manifest those qualities that are the requirement of justice.

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9. Truthfulness and honesty are essential attributes of a family that strives to exercise rectitude of conduct in its domestic life, in its dealings, and in its service to the Cause and humanity. Discuss the veracity of the following statements:
- Children are not adversely affected when their parents lack honesty in their business dealings so long as they strive to be honest and truthful at home.

- Children learn to be hypocritical when they see that, in public, their parents speak about the importance of kindness but say unkind words about members of the community when they are at home.
  - Children whose parents encourage them to cut corners in the pursuit of their goals and to exaggerate their achievements will form a skewed sense of what truthfulness and honesty mean.
  - Children whose parents pay excessive attention to material gains and do not place sufficient emphasis on spiritual matters are at greater risk of acquiring attitudes and habits that extinguish the light of honesty.
  - The success and honor of a family lie in the scrupulous honesty and absolute sincerity of its members in all their dealings with others in the community.
10. There are numerous forces operating in society which can hamper our ability to investigate truth, one of the most insidious of which is propaganda. It can take the form of misinformation, half-truths, and sometimes blatant lies. Youngsters are increasingly the objects of such propaganda, especially through social media. Facts are twisted, and distorted ideas propagated on a wide scale, almost instantaneously. Satisfaction of passions and desires is pronounced as a fundamental right and given free reign. Ultimately, however, this assault on the hearts and minds of the young creates profound emptiness and despair. It is, therefore, extremely important for young people to develop the ability to sort out information from misinformation, truth from fancy. What is more, they need to acquire the capacity to search for meaning embedded in the writings of the Faith and to draw from them insights into profound themes such as human purpose and identity, into the nature of those bonds that connect us with our Creator and with each other, into the reality of service and human progress. Discuss how each of the three educational imperatives—the program for the spiritual education of children, the junior youth spiritual empowerment program, and the main sequence of courses—contributes, in its own way, to such capacity.
11. Children should, of course, be taught to be honest, to never cheat or lay their hands on what does not belong to them. But if, in their youth, they are to resist the forces of corruption and be empowered to fight against them, they should also learn to recognize those elements of culture that are inconsistent with standards of rectitude. How can young people be assisted, for example, in seeing that greed—a greed which is celebrated by the media, which condones deceit and dishonesty, and which is built into the very structure of present-day society—is a chief cause of injustice? How are they to be taught contentment when they are surrounded by an environment that continually breeds greed? What are the characteristics of a family life that helps them avoid becoming manipulated by illusory pictures of opulence and glamour? Write some of your thoughts in relation to these questions in the space below.

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12. One of the features of today's society is the growing lack of trust among people, between human groups, and between individuals and institutions. Trustworthiness is, therefore, a cardinal quality that must be taught the family. If its youngest members are to grow into adults that will contribute to the construction of the new civilization envisioned by Bahá'u'lláh, they should learn to imbue with trust every relationship they forge. It is important, then, that children, both through wise counsel and the example of the adults around them, be taught to exercise faithfulness and fidelity in their relationships, to preserve the sanctity of the pledges they make, and to shoulder their responsibilities with joy. Which of the following attitudes and habits reinforce the development of trustworthiness and which hinder it? Mark them with an "R" or an "H" accordingly. Do not be satisfied with simply marking each as one or the other but discuss the reasons for doing so.

- \_\_\_\_\_ Self-righteousness
- \_\_\_\_\_ Indifference towards the property and rights of others
- \_\_\_\_\_ Respect for truth
- \_\_\_\_\_ Boastfulness and pretension
- \_\_\_\_\_ Promptitude
- \_\_\_\_\_ Impartiality in one's judgment
- \_\_\_\_\_ Radiant acquiescence in carrying out one's tasks
- \_\_\_\_\_ Sloppiness in one's words and deeds
- \_\_\_\_\_ Enthusiasm and eagerness in fulfilling one's duties
- \_\_\_\_\_ Precision and accuracy
- \_\_\_\_\_ Respect for the property and rights of others

Can you think of other attitudes and habits that children should develop and still others that they should make sure to resist in their efforts to manifest trustworthiness?

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How can the trust that should bind together the families in your neighborhood or village be strengthened? Write some of your thoughts in the space below.

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13. To end this section, you are encouraged to commit the following passage to memory:

**“It behooveth ye all so to adorn your inner and outer beings that, robed in trustworthiness, girt with righteousness and arrayed in truthfulness and rectitude, ye may become a means for the exaltation of the Cause and the education of the human race.”<sup>127</sup>**

## SECTION 16

Another feature of a mature society is that family life will be characterized by purity and sanctity. As the processes of the disintegration of an old order gain momentum, we witness in the society around us the efflorescence of “theories that are the very negation of purity, of morality and chastity”. If young people are to resist the influence of such theories on their minds and hearts, they need to get glimpses of the spiritual brilliance which only the pure can reflect and aspire to become pure channels of divine grace. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá says:

**“The children . . . must be constantly encouraged and made eager to gain all the summits of human accomplishment, so that from their earliest years they will be taught to have high aims, to conduct themselves well, to be chaste, pure, and undefiled, and will learn to be of powerful resolve and firm of purpose in all things.”<sup>128</sup>**

Purity is of primary significance to our spiritual development:

**“My first counsel is this: Possess a pure, kindly and radiant heart, that thine may be a sovereignty ancient, imperishable and everlasting.”<sup>129</sup>**

**“First in a human being’s way of life must be purity, then freshness, cleanliness, and independence of spirit. First must the stream bed be cleansed, then may the sweet river waters be led into it. Chaste eyes enjoy the beatific vision of the Lord and know what this encounter meaneth; a pure sense inhaleth the fragrances that blow from the rose gardens of His grace; a burnished heart will mirror forth the comely face of truth.”<sup>130</sup>**

Out of the whole world, God has chosen the human heart as His abode. Our ultimate desire in sanctifying our hearts of unworthy thoughts and passions is that they may become worthy of His habitation:



**“He hath chosen out of the whole world the hearts of His servants, and made them each a seat for the revelation of His glory. Wherefore, sanctify them from every defilement, that the things for which they were created may be engraven upon them. This indeed is a token of God’s bountiful favor.”<sup>131</sup>**

**“O Son of Being! Thy heart is My home; sanctify it for My descent. Thy spirit is My place of revelation; cleanse it for My manifestation.”<sup>132</sup>**

Polishing the mirror of the heart from the dust and dross of this world enables it to receive divine bounties and to reflect the light of the Sun of Truth, opening to it the doors of knowledge:

**“The most important thing is to polish the mirrors of hearts in order that they may become illumined and receptive of the divine light. One heart may possess the capacity of the polished mirror; another, be covered and obscured by the dust and dross of this world. Although the same Sun is shining upon both, in the mirror which is polished, pure and sanctified you may behold the Sun in all its fullness, glory and power, revealing its majesty and effulgence; but in the mirror which is rusted and obscured there is no capacity for reflection, although so far as the Sun itself is concerned it is shining thereon and is neither lessened nor deprived. Therefore, our duty lies in seeking to polish the mirrors of our hearts in order that we shall become reflectors of that light and recipients of the divine bounties which may be fully revealed through them.”<sup>133</sup>**

**“The more pure and sanctified the heart of man becomes, the nearer it draws to God, and the light of the Sun of Reality is revealed within it. This light sets hearts aglow with the fire of the love of God, opens in them the doors of knowledge and unseals the divine mysteries so that spiritual discoveries are made possible.”<sup>134</sup>**

As to the dust that covers the mirror of the heart and what is required to purify it, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us:

**“What is the dust which obscures the mirror? It is attachment to the world, avarice, envy, love of luxury and comfort, haughtiness and self-desire; this is the dust which prevents reflection of the rays of the Sun of Reality in the mirror. . . . But sincerity, justice, humility, severance, and love for the believers of God will purify the mirror and make it radiant with reflected rays from the Sun of Truth.”<sup>135</sup>**

We achieve purity through strength, through the powers of reason, understanding, and intelligence:

**“The hearts of all children are of the utmost purity. They are mirrors upon which no dust has fallen. But this purity is on account of weakness and innocence, not on account of any strength and testing, for as this is the early period of their childhood, their hearts and minds are unsullied by the world. They cannot display any great intelligence. They have neither hypocrisy nor deceit. This is on account of the child’s weakness, whereas the man becomes pure through his strength. Through the power of intelligence he becomes simple; through the great power of reason and understanding and not through the power of weakness he becomes sincere. When he attains**

**to the state of perfection, he will receive these qualities; his heart becomes purified, his spirit enlightened, his soul is sensitized and tender—all through his great strength. This is the difference between the perfect man and the child. Both have the underlying qualities of simplicity and sincerity—the child through the power of weakness and the man through the power of strength.”<sup>136</sup>**

To state that we become pure through strength and the power of understanding suggests that we must learn to recognize and overcome those traits—the manifestations of the lower nature—that impair purity:

**“O My Servant! Purge thy heart from malice and, innocent of envy, enter the divine court of holiness.”<sup>137</sup>**

**“Holy words and pure and goodly deeds ascend unto the heaven of celestial glory. Strive that your deeds may be cleansed from the dust of self and hypocrisy and find favor at the court of glory; for ere long the assayers of mankind shall, in the holy presence of the Adored One, accept naught but absolute virtue and deeds of stainless purity.”<sup>138</sup>**

Purity is intimately connected to modesty, temperance, and decency. They all involve the exercise of moderation:

**“In all matters moderation is desirable. If a thing is carried to excess, it will prove a source of evil.”<sup>139</sup>**

**“Consider for instance such things as liberty, civilization and the like. However much men of understanding may favorably regard them, they will, if carried to excess, exercise a pernicious influence upon men.”<sup>140</sup>**

**“Human utterance is an essence which aspireth to exert its influence and needeth moderation. As to its influence, this is conditional upon refinement which in turn is dependent upon hearts which are detached and pure.”<sup>141</sup>**

**“That which beseemeth man is submission unto such restraints as will protect him from his own ignorance, and guard him against the harm of the mischief maker.”<sup>142</sup>**

**“Let there be naught in your demeanor of which sound and upright minds would disapprove, and make not yourselves the playthings of the ignorant.”<sup>143</sup>**

As to the faculty that guards us from committing unseemly acts, keeping us within the bounds of moderation, Bahá'u'lláh states:

**“Indeed, there existeth in man a faculty which deterreth him from, and guardeth him against, whatever is unworthy and unseemly, and which is known as his sense of shame.”<sup>144</sup>**

While the prompting of the ego drains us of the vitality required to accomplish noble acts, purity releases tremendous energy and power:

**“Within the very breath of such souls as are pure and sanctified far-reaching potentialities are hidden. So great are these potentialities that they exercise their influence upon all created things.”<sup>145</sup>**

**“One righteous act is endowed with a potency that can so elevate the dust as to cause it to pass beyond the heaven of heavens. It can tear every bond asunder, and hath the power to restore the force that hath spent itself and vanished.”<sup>146</sup>**

To assist children in developing the powers necessary to resist the pernicious forces operating in society, parents will do well to reflect on the following statement of the Universal House of Justice on the theme of purity:

**“The forces at work on the hearts and minds of the young, to whom the Guardian directed his appeal most fervently, are pernicious indeed. Exhortations to remain pure and chaste will only succeed to a limited degree in helping them to resist these forces. What needs to be appreciated in this respect is the extent to which young minds are affected by the choices parents make for their own lives, when, no matter how unintentionally, no matter how innocently, such choices condone the passions of the world—its admiration for power, its adoration of status, its love of luxuries, its attachment to frivolous pursuits, its glorification of violence, and its obsession with self-gratification. It must be realized that the isolation and despair from which so many suffer are products of an environment ruled by an all-pervasive materialism. And in this the friends must understand the ramifications of Bahá’u’lláh’s statement that ‘the present-day order’ must ‘be rolled up, and a new one spread out in its stead.’”<sup>147</sup>**

And as children grow into adulthood, parents undoubtedly hope they will join the ranks of an increasing number of young people who, drawing on the provisions of the global Plans of the Faith, are striving to contribute to the regeneration of the world:

**“Throughout the world today, young people are among the most enthusiastic supporters of the Plan and the most ardent champions of the Cause; their numbers will, we are certain, increase from year to year. May every one of them come to know the bounties of a life adorned with purity and learn to draw on the powers that flow through pure channels.”<sup>148</sup>**

The Guardian writes that it is such youth who

**“can contribute so decisively to the virility, the purity, and the driving force of the life of the Bahá’í community, and upon whom must depend the future orientation of its destiny, and the complete unfoldment of the potentialities with which God has endowed it.”<sup>149</sup>**

1. To reflect further on the concept of purity, complete the following sentences:
  - a. First in our way of life must be \_\_\_\_\_, then \_\_\_\_\_, \_\_\_\_\_, and \_\_\_\_\_. First the stream bed must be \_\_\_\_\_, then the \_\_\_\_\_ may be led into it.

- b. God has chosen out of the whole world the \_\_\_\_\_ of His \_\_\_\_\_ and made them each a \_\_\_\_\_.
  - c. We must sanctify our hearts from \_\_\_\_\_, that the things for which they were created \_\_\_\_\_.
  - d. Our hearts are God's \_\_\_\_\_. We must \_\_\_\_\_ our hearts for God's \_\_\_\_\_.
  - e. Our spirit is God's \_\_\_\_\_. We must \_\_\_\_\_ our spirits for God's \_\_\_\_\_.
  - f. The most important thing is to \_\_\_\_\_ the mirrors of our \_\_\_\_\_.
  - g. We polish the mirrors of hearts in order that they may become \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_ of the \_\_\_\_\_.
  - h. When the Sun \_\_\_\_\_ upon the \_\_\_\_\_ which is polished, \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, we may behold the \_\_\_\_\_ in all its \_\_\_\_\_, \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_, revealing its \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_.
2. We find two metaphors in the above quotations from 'Abdu'l-Bahá that give us insight into what it means to be adorned with purity. The first is that of a stream bed. Just as the stream bed must be cleansed of dirt if fresh water is to flow through it, so too must our hearts and minds be purified of every unworthy thought, passion and motive. Discuss what bounties of God will not reach us when our hearts and minds are obstructed with such impurities.
- The second metaphor is that of a mirror. When dust and dross are entirely removed from the face of the mirror, it reflects the light of the sun in all its splendor. Similarly, the purer our hearts, the more they reflect heavenly qualities.
- a. According to 'Abdu'l-Bahá, what is the "dust which obscures the mirror" of the heart?  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - b. What will "purify the mirror and make it radiant with reflected rays from the Sun of Truth"? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. Bahá'u'lláh counsels us in the Kitáb-i-Aqdas with the words "Be ye the very essence of cleanliness amongst mankind", and 'Abdu'l-Bahá states that, "in every aspect of life, purity and holiness, cleanliness and refinement, exalt the human condition and further the development of man's inner reality". "Even in the physical realm," He tells us, "cleanliness will conduce to spirituality." How can we explain to children the idea that cleanliness and

refinement conduce to spirituality? Below are some statements that can help you think about this question.

- God loves cleanliness and refinement.
  - Cleanliness and order are pleasing to the eye.
  - We can see beauty and refinement in God’s creation.
  - Just as we become clean when we wash away dust and dirt from our bodies, our garments, and our homes, we become pure when we cleanse our hearts and minds from thoughts and feelings that are not pleasing to God.
  - We defile our tongues when we use words that belittle another human being.
  - Our words and deeds become refined when they are not stained with selfish desires.
4. “The most important thing,” ‘Abdu’l-Bahá says, “is to polish the mirrors of hearts in order that they may become illumined and receptive of the divine light.” Having studied the quotations in this section, write a number of statements that, drawing upon the words and phrases below, attempt to describe the meaning of the various dimensions of purity.

cleanse, heart, sanctify, defilement, sincere, illumined, receptive, light, radiant, dross, sun, Sun of Reality, polished, rust, reflect, envy, malice, motive, thought, action, purpose, purity, purify, pure, self-desire, spirit, hypocrisy, attachment, pride, greed, sincere, sincerity, justice, humility, detachment, love of luxury, love for others, love of God

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Now share with the other members of your group some of the sentences you have written and consult together about how you would expand on them in such a way that the young ones in a family would be able to understand the importance of polishing the mirror of their hearts. For example, if you used the word “hypocrisy” in a sentence, describing it as the dust that covers the mirror of the heart, you would need to explain the idea to children by providing examples of the type of behavior that shows hypocrisy.

5. Spiritual qualities, such as justice, generosity, truthfulness, and kindness, can only manifest their brilliance when our deeds are purified of the dust of self and hypocrisy. In the absence of purity, behavior that seems like the outward expression of a quality can become an instrument for advancing personal goals and ambitions. Describe how self-aggrandizement can be the motivating force behind acts that appear to be the manifestations of each of the following qualities. An example has been provided to help you.

Generosity: When tainted by the dust of self, acts of generosity are used to gain popularity and fame.

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Justice: \_\_\_\_\_

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Truthfulness: \_\_\_\_\_

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Kindness: \_\_\_\_\_

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6. Purity can mistakenly be associated with naivety. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá clarifies that the purity we seek is one that arises out of strength and not out of weakness, out of intelligence and not out of innocence. Without discernment and effort, it would be impossible to attain the heights of purity. Take some time to reflect on the following statements and write a few of your thoughts in the space provided:

- a. Through the power of intelligence, an individual becomes simple.
- b. Through the power of reason and understanding, an individual becomes sincere.
- c. Through the power of strength, a person’s soul becomes sensitized and tender.

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7. Another common misunderstanding is to associate purity with strict denial of any delight that life might offer. Of course, single-minded pursuit of pleasure does not confer true and lasting joy either. Hedonism and frivolity eventually give rise to despair. We can lead a chaste and pure life and at the same time benefit from all the bounties God has conferred on us. What is required is to be freed from the dictates of worldly passions and desires and to exercise “moderation in all that pertains to dress, language, amusements, and all artistic and literary avocations”.

In this connection, parents need to appreciate the effect of the choices they make on their children when those choices, however unintentionally, condone the passions of the world. They should realize, for example, that the degree of emphasis placed on looks and appearance will determine how attached children will be to the vanities of this world and, as a result, how oblivious they will be of the need to enhance the powers of the mind or the beauty of character. Parents should be conscious, to take another example, that driving their children to compete in order to be the first among their peers in their academic pursuits can nurture in them admiration for worldly power and status instead of passion for learning and for service to the Cause and humanity. Discuss in your group what types of choices a family might make to enable children to resist the following passions of the world:

- Admiration for power
  - Adoration of status
  - Love of luxuries
  - Attachment to frivolous pursuits
  - Glorification of violence
  - Obsession with self-gratification
8. We know that the sense of shame is that human faculty which impels one to stay away from unworthy thoughts and motives and to discard unseemly language and conduct; it deters one from approaching what the teachings of God condemn. That humanity has “polluted itself” with “evils and vices”, the Guardian warns us, is a result of it having transferred the allegiance owed to its Creator to the “gods of its own invention”. Consider, for example, doctrines that glorify “the hedonistic pursuit of material satisfactions”—the images, the words, and the ideas they promote and to which everyone, including children and young people, are constantly exposed. Discuss in your group how allegiance to such false doctrines weakens the sense of shame and removes those boundaries that safeguard human dignity.

9. Rather than merely telling their children to avoid what is shameful, parents should, in their interaction with them, draw on the force of attraction to beauty, specifically the beauty and purity of the sacred. In a world where everything sacred is profaned, the spiritual sense that enables people to recognize that which is sacred and to develop appropriate attitudes towards it is considerably weakened. How can children's spiritual susceptibilities be strengthened to appreciate the nature of sacredness? What are the distinct attitudes that should be fostered in children towards the sacred—the Word of God, the Manifestations of God, the duty to serve the Cause of God, communion with God, the law of God, the human heart? To approach these questions at the appropriate level of depth, you will benefit from reflecting on the following quotation:

**“ . . . it behooveth the people of truth that the signs of humility should shine upon their faces, that the light of sanctity should radiate from their countenances, that they should walk upon the earth as though they were in the presence of God and distinguish themselves in their deeds from all the dwellers of the earth. Such must be their state that their eyes should behold the evidences of His might, their tongues and hearts make mention of His name, their feet be set towards the lands of His nearness, and their hands take fast hold upon His precepts.”<sup>150</sup>**

10. Purity releases spiritual potential, increasing the power to serve humanity; lack of purity blocks the channels through which energy flows. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá reminds us that “to be pure and holy in all things is an attribute of the consecrated soul and a necessary characteristic of the unenslaved mind.” Discuss the following questions in your group:
- What is the relationship between purity and true freedom?
  - Selfish desires, worldly passions, fancies and vain imaginings enslave the mind. How does the freedom of an “unenslaved” mind endow acts with spiritual potency?
  - How do doors of knowledge open to the consecrated soul?
11. When in our endeavors we use methods that, while accepted as social norms, are far from pure, human energy is drained. This may sound counterintuitive, since achievement of goals in the world of politics, of corporations and even of organizations of civil society seems inconceivable without some calculative maneuvering and scheming and without forming expedient alliances that serve limited vested interests. However, those who subscribe to this view tend to overlook the fact that employing such methods in any sphere of action gives rise to suspicion, distrust, and cynicism among those who work together. Discuss how, in any endeavor to improve community life, resorting to means that are not completely pure dissipates collective energy and hinders real progress.

12. You may wish to end this section by memorizing the following quotation:

**“O My brother! A pure heart is as a mirror; cleanse it with the burnish of love and severance from all save God, that the true sun may shine therein and the eternal morning dawn. Then wilt thou clearly see the meaning of ‘Earth and heaven cannot contain Me; what can alone contain Me is the heart of him that believeth in Me.’ And thou wilt take up thy life in thy hand and with infinite longing cast it before thy newly found Beloved.”<sup>151</sup>**



## SECTION 17

Prejudice is a most formidable force that continues to hamper the spiritual and material advancement of all peoples. As humanity approaches its maturity, it must achieve complete freedom from prejudice, whether of race, class, creed, or color. Therefore, a most urgent question before those who are concerned with the education of the young is this: How are they to be empowered to banish all forms of prejudice that are being perpetuated from one generation to the next?

**“And among the teachings of Bahá’u’lláh is that religious, racial, political, economic and patriotic prejudices destroy the edifice of humanity. As long as these prejudices prevail, the world of humanity will not have rest.”<sup>152</sup>**

The Universal House of Justice thus counsels us:

**“So free must be your thoughts and actions of any trace of prejudice—racial, religious, economic, national, tribal, class, or cultural—that even the stranger sees in you loving friends.”<sup>153</sup>**

In our effort to eliminate prejudice, we should abandon outdated ideas and moral codes that correspond to humanity’s stage of childhood. Even a virtue such as loyalty, which historically has been associated with the family, as well as with larger units of society, can cause alienation if not tempered by love for all. The prevalence of an outlook that constantly divides people into separate groups provides fertile soil for sowing the seeds of prejudice; it creates indifference to the suffering of others and, in extreme cases, a perception that oppression might be justified.

**“How many the stable and united families that, in their intolerance towards one or another segment of society, instill in their younger generations an ‘us and them’ mentality, heedless of the fact that the transmission of such poisonous attitudes stifles in their children love for humanity and hampers their sense of justice.”<sup>154</sup>**

What gives rise to prejudice is, of course, ignorance—ignorance associated with blind imitation, superstition, and vain imaginings:

**“The root cause of wrongdoing is ignorance, and we must therefore hold fast to the tools of perception and knowledge.”<sup>155</sup>**

**“The perpetuation of ignorance is a most grievous form of oppression; it reinforces the many walls of prejudice that stand as barriers to the realization of the oneness of humankind . . .”<sup>156</sup>**

**“... the root cause of prejudice is blind imitation of the past—imitation in religion, in racial attitudes, in national bias, in politics.”<sup>157</sup>**

**“Man must cut himself free from all prejudice and from the result of his own imagination, so that he may be able to search for truth unhindered.”<sup>158</sup>**

**“... man must free himself from the weeds of ignorance, thorns of superstitions and thistles of imitations that he may discover reality in the harvests of true knowledge.”<sup>159</sup>**

A sense of superiority, even when not consciously acknowledged, in a most subtle way breeds prejudice. What might not be so readily understood is that self-exaltation and pride stem from ignorance, from a lack of knowledge of how we have been created:

**“O Children of Men! Know ye not why We created you all from the same dust? That no one should exalt himself over the other. Ponder at all times in your hearts how ye were created. Since We have created you all from one same substance it is incumbent on you to be even as one soul, to walk with the same feet, eat with the same mouth and dwell in the same land, that from your inmost being, by your deeds and actions, the signs of oneness and the essence of detachment may be made manifest. Such is My counsel to you, O concourse of light! Heed ye this counsel that ye may obtain the fruit of holiness from the tree of wondrous glory.”<sup>160</sup>**

**“Ever since the seeking of preference and distinction came into play, the world hath been laid waste. It hath become desolate. . . .**

**“Indeed, man is noble, inasmuch as each one is a repository of the sign of God. Nevertheless, to regard oneself as superior in knowledge, learning or virtue, or to exalt oneself or seek preference, is a grievous transgression.”<sup>161</sup>**

**“It behooveth you to abandon vainglory which causeth alienation and to set your hearts on whatever will ensure harmony.”<sup>162</sup>**

While prejudice must be eradicated from the structures and systems of institutions as well as from the culture of groups and communities, at the most fundamental level it must also be eliminated from the human heart. To burn away the veil of prejudice we need to acquire purity. ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us:

**“Cleanse ye your eyes, so that ye behold no man as different from yourselves. See ye no strangers; rather see all men as friends, for love and unity come hard when ye fix your gaze on otherness. And in this new and wondrous age, the Holy Writings say that we must be at one with every people; that we must see neither harshness nor injustice, neither malevolence, nor hostility, nor hate, but rather turn our eyes toward the heaven of ancient glory. For each of the creatures is a sign of God, and it was by the grace of the Lord and His power that each did step into the world; therefore they are not strangers, but in the family; not aliens, but friends, and to be treated as such.”<sup>163</sup>**

**“Let them purify their sight and behold all humankind as leaves and blossoms and fruits of the tree of being.”<sup>164</sup>**

Prejudice will not be obliterated until the consciousness of the oneness of humankind permeates the hearts and souls of all the peoples of the earth:

**“In this wondrous Revelation, this glorious century, the foundation of the Faith of God and the distinguishing feature of His Law is the consciousness of the Oneness of Mankind.”<sup>165</sup>**

The Guardian further states:

**“Let there be no misgivings as to the animating purpose of the world-wide Law of Bahá’u’lláh. Far from aiming at the subversion of the existing foundations of society, it seeks to broaden its basis, to remold its institutions in a manner consonant with the needs of an ever-changing world. It can conflict with no legitimate allegiances, nor can it undermine essential loyalties. Its purpose is neither to stifle the flame of a sane and intelligent patriotism in men’s hearts, nor to abolish the system of national autonomy so essential if the evils of excessive centralization are to be avoided. It does not ignore, nor does it attempt to suppress, the diversity of ethnical origins, of climate, of history, of language and tradition, of thought and habit, that differentiate the peoples and nations of the world. It calls for a wider loyalty, for a larger aspiration than any that has animated the human race. It insists upon the subordination of national impulses and interests to the imperative claims of a unified world. It repudiates excessive centralization on one hand, and disclaims all attempts at uniformity on the other. Its watchword is unity in diversity such as ‘Abdu’l-Bahá Himself has explained: *‘Consider the flowers of a garden. Though differing in kind, color, form and shape, yet, inasmuch as they are refreshed by the waters of one spring, revived by the breath of one wind, invigorated by the rays of one sun, this diversity increaseth their charm and addeth unto their beauty. How displeasing to the eye if all the flowers and plants, the leaves and blossoms, the fruit, the branches and the trees of that garden were all of the same shape and color! Diversity of hues, form and shape enricheth and adorneth the garden, and heighteneth the effect thereof. In like manner, when divers shades of thought, temperament and character, are brought together under the power and influence of one central agency, the beauty and glory of human perfection will be revealed and made manifest. Naught but the celestial potency of the Word of God, which ruleth and transcendeth the realities of all things, is capable of harmonizing the divergent thoughts, sentiments, ideas and convictions of the children of men.’*”<sup>166</sup>**

The education children receive at home can help develop in them the attributes that characterize those who strive to bring about union and harmony among all peoples and nations of the world.

**“In this illumined age that which is confirmed is the oneness of the world of humanity. Every soul who serveth this oneness will undoubtedly be assisted and confirmed.”<sup>167</sup>**

**“... O ye beloved of the Lord and friends of God, arise, and with the whole enthusiasm of your hearts, with all the eagerness of your souls, strive to unfurl the standards of unity in the midmost heart of the world and cause, with valiant might, the ocean of oneness to surge.”<sup>168</sup>**

1. Complete the following sentences:

a. The root cause of wrongdoing is \_\_\_\_\_ .

- b. The perpetuation of ignorance is a \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - c. The perpetuation of ignorance reinforces the \_\_\_\_\_  
that stand as \_\_\_\_\_ to the \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ .
  - d. The root cause of prejudice is \_\_\_\_\_ .
  - e. Man must \_\_\_\_\_ from \_\_\_\_\_ and from the  
result of his own \_\_\_\_\_ , so that he may be able to \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_ .
  - f. Man must \_\_\_\_\_ from the weeds of \_\_\_\_\_ , thorns of  
\_\_\_\_\_ and thistles of \_\_\_\_\_ that he may discover  
\_\_\_\_\_ in the harvests of \_\_\_\_\_ .
2. Having reflected on the above statements, write some of your thoughts on the following questions and then share your insights with the other members of your study group:
- a. What is the nature of the oppression that is perpetuated by ignorance?  
  
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\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - b. People subscribe to erroneous and harmful ideas, often products of human imagination and fancy, due to lack of knowledge. What are some examples of such ideas from which we must free ourselves if we are to succeed in putting an end to prejudices of one kind or another?  
  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. Acknowledging that we should do away with various forms of prejudice is necessary but not sufficient. If prejudice is not to be perpetuated from one generation to the next, it is essential that individuals learn to discard the habit of categorizing and assigning value to people according to race, nationality, culture, class, gender and economics. The home environment, where the child internalizes so many of the standards that guide him or her later in life, plays a principal role in removing the virus of prejudice. Describe some of the elements of a home environment—the thoughts that are expressed, the words that are

spoken, the deeds that are performed—that is illumined by the truths enshrined in statements such as the ones below.

**“... regard ye not one another as strangers. Ye are the fruits of one tree, and the leaves of one branch.”<sup>169</sup>**

**“Do not be satisfied until each one with whom you are concerned is to you as a member of your family.”<sup>170</sup>**

**“... man must recognize the oneness of humanity, for all in origin belong to the same household, and all are servants of the same God.”<sup>171</sup>**

**“... the various races of humankind lend a composite harmony and beauty of color to the whole. Let all associate, therefore, in this great human garden even as flowers grow and blend together side by side without discord or disagreement between them.”<sup>172</sup>**

**“If we investigate the foundations of the divine religions, we find them to be one, absolutely changeless and never subject to transformation.”<sup>173</sup>**

**“This is one globe, one land, one country. God did not divide it into national boundaries. He created all the continents without national divisions.”<sup>174</sup>**

**“Only if you perceive honor and nobility in every human being—this independent of wealth or poverty—will you be able to champion the cause of justice.”<sup>175</sup>**

**“Divine Justice demands that the rights of both sexes should be equally respected since neither is superior to the other in the eyes of Heaven. Dignity before God depends, not on sex, but on purity and luminosity of heart. Human virtues belong equally to all!”<sup>176</sup>**

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4. Seeking to advance oneself over another is a most harmful tendency that feeds prejudice. Children can easily acquire a sense of superiority by being exposed to ingrained but false beliefs at home, in school, in the community and through media. Consider how, through subtle allusions repeatedly made by adults around them, the young subconsciously begin to believe that entire groups are unintelligent, lazy, docile, culturally inferior, untrustworthy or unreliable. With what spiritual truths found in the Writings should we continually fill our hearts and minds in order to purge ourselves from the least feeling of superiority and pride? An example has been provided below.

God has created us all from the same dust.

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5. Prejudice blinds the eye and prevents one from seeing the truth even in the face of evidence. Spiritual qualities open the eye of the soul, lifting the veils that obscure its vision. Imagine, for example, a community in which most individuals in their relationships with one another strive to manifest genuine love and mature wisdom, true humility and extreme patience, purity and a keen sense of justice. Would you say that such a community will eventually, by the grace of God, succeed in freeing itself from prejudice? What are some of the veils that its inhabitants will ultimately be able to rend asunder?

From among the spiritual qualities mentioned in the previous paragraph, purity deserves special attention. Why does freedom from prejudice require purity of heart? On what powers can an individual whose thoughts, motives and purposes are pure draw to fight against prejudice?

The road that takes humanity towards its unification is long and beset with obstacles. The obligation to manifest spiritual qualities and attitudes necessary for the elimination of prejudice lies with everyone. Identify in the list below those attitudes that enable the peoples of the world to advance in obliterating prejudices of all kinds and those that hamper progress. Mark them with an “A” or an “H” accordingly.

- \_\_\_\_\_ Care and vigilance  
\_\_\_\_\_ Paternalism  
\_\_\_\_\_ Calm determination  
\_\_\_\_\_ Genuine sympathy

- \_\_\_\_\_ Indifference
- \_\_\_\_\_ Gratitude and thankfulness
- \_\_\_\_\_ Self-righteousness
- \_\_\_\_\_ Antipathy
- \_\_\_\_\_ Sincere friendliness
- \_\_\_\_\_ Self-abnegation
- \_\_\_\_\_ Willing cooperation
- \_\_\_\_\_ Suspicion
- \_\_\_\_\_ Trust
- \_\_\_\_\_ Cordiality
- \_\_\_\_\_ Aloofness
- \_\_\_\_\_ Pride and arrogance
- \_\_\_\_\_ Self-entitlement
- \_\_\_\_\_ Pity
- \_\_\_\_\_ Vindictiveness
- \_\_\_\_\_ Intolerance
- \_\_\_\_\_ Pretentiousness
- \_\_\_\_\_ Respect for human dignity

6. In the teachings of the Faith, we find many counsels regarding the manner of our association with each other. “They that are endued with sincerity and faithfulness”, for example, “should associate with all the peoples and kindreds of the earth with joy and radiance.” We are admonished to renounce “the spirit of strife and hostility” and begin to “associate in goodwill and fellowship”, to associate with our neighbor “with faces joyous and beaming with light”, to “associate in affectionate fellowship with stranger and friend alike,” and to “associate with one another with perfect humility and lowliness”. Do you see such qualities reflected in the way families in your neighborhood or village associate with one another? What are some examples that you have encountered?
7. Consciousness of the oneness of humankind is indispensable to the eradication of prejudice. Its guiding principle is unity in diversity. We witness in the world today a strange phenomenon. While diversity is increasingly celebrated, divisions among peoples of the world are simultaneously deepening with each passing day. Focusing solely on distinctions and differences cannot but result in separation and alienation. The following words of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá speak to this truth: “In the human kingdom itself there are points of contact, properties common to all mankind; likewise, there are points of distinction which separate race from race, individual from individual. If the points of contact, which are the common properties of humanity, overcome the peculiar points of distinction, unity is assured. On the other hand, if the points of differentiation overcome the points of agreement, disunion and weakness result.” Discuss in your group how activities fostered by the training

institute—“meetings that strengthen the devotional character of the community; classes that nurture the tender hearts and minds of children; groups that channel the surging energies of junior youth; circles of study, open to all, that enable people of varied backgrounds to advance on equal footing and explore the application of the teachings to their individual and collective lives”—are strengthening bonds of fellowship among diverse people. What elements of this community-building process contribute to unity in diversity by building on “the common properties” of humanity, thereby overcoming those points of distinction that lead to disunity?

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8. In Section 14 you reflected on the significance of unity within the family. It would be worthwhile to take a step further: What would enable members of a family to contribute to building environments of unity based on diversity in a community? To be builders of unity, we need to understand certain concepts with a reasonable degree of clarity and set aside mistaken notions that may be associated with them. What erroneous ideas should be dispelled in order to clearly grasp the following:

The universe is an interconnected whole, and harmonious civilization can only be built on the law of interconnectedness.

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Unity does not imply uniformity.

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Diversity and unity—unity of thought and vision—are not contradictory terms.

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Harmony can be achieved when diverse talents and abilities are brought together in the pursuit of a common purpose.

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Nothing but the power of the Word of God is capable of harmonizing the divergent thoughts, sentiments, ideas and convictions of the peoples of the world.

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9. To contribute to the building of harmonious families and communities, we need to learn the ways of consultation. Below are some of the qualities, attitudes, skills and habits with which you are familiar from your study of Book 10. Discuss why they are necessary to building unity within the family and the community:

- Having genuine concern for our fellow human beings
- Abstaining from fault-finding
- Expressing one's thoughts and ideas with kindness
- Speaking with frankness and honesty
- Generously sharing knowledge and experience
- Not shying away from difficult conversations
- Not being careless with one's words
- Lacking suspicion
- Weighing opinions with the utmost serenity, calmness, and composure
- Having purity of motive
- Having radiance of spirit
- Being detached from all else save God
- Being humble and lowly
- Being open-minded

- Being free from prejudice
- Being free from a domineering attitude
- Being free from estrangement
- Avoiding hypocrisy and manipulation
- Listening carefully to every point of view
- Listening with one’s spiritual ear
- Striving to explore underlying principles
- Bringing relevant experience to bear
- Acting with moderation and patience
- Being dispassionate and impartial
- Not thinking one is always right
- Not belittling the views of anyone

Now look at the following situations. What are some of the above characteristics that would be particularly helpful in building greater unity among those involved in each case? After thinking about these situations, you may wish to consider others you have encountered in your own village or neighborhood.

- a. Two families who live on the same street do not get along and will not allow their children to attend the same junior youth group.
  - b. A family formerly of modest means becomes wealthier than the rest of the families in their village or neighborhood. Soon, the members of the family begin to feel that they are better than others, and their neighbors become suspicious of them. As a result, the family stops participating in most community gatherings.
  - c. A father is unable to pay back a sum of money that he has borrowed from another member of the community, which leads to conflict between their two families.
  - d. A group of families is working together to grow crops and raise hens on a piece of land that is collectively owned. They cannot agree on how to fairly distribute what is produced, and tension arises.
10. To end this section, memorize the following quotation:

**“O ye friends of God! Exert ye with heart and soul, so that association, love, unity and agreement be obtained between the hearts, all the aims may be merged into one aim, all the songs become one song and the power of the Holy Spirit may become so overwhelmingly victorious as to overcome all the forces of the world of nature.”<sup>177</sup>**

## SECTION 18

It is not unreasonable to imagine that, as the five friends who have been central to our story—Alejandra and Martin, Daniela and Francisco, and Maribel—reflect on their experience in exploring the ideas from the last three sections, they would come to recognize the magnitude of the challenge before us all to transform the relationships that sustain families and communities. Let us suppose, then, that they identify three qualities—courage, wisdom, and humility—that they feel are particularly important in meeting this challenge. Below is the sequence of ideas they might well have organized for discussion.

To champion the cause of justice, to seek truth and uphold its standards, to build unity where people are divided, to strive to lead a pure life in a world in which base passions are given free rein—all of this requires immense courage. The following words of the Universal House of Justice on this topic were addressed to a group of youth:

**“To discharge your responsibilities, you will have to show forth courage, the courage of those who cling to standards of rectitude, whose lives are characterized by purity of thought and action, and whose purpose is directed by love and indomitable faith.”<sup>178</sup>**

Let us consider the source of courage:

**“The source of courage and power is the promotion of the Word of God, and steadfastness in His Love.”<sup>179</sup>**

**“Strive as much as ye can to turn wholly toward the Kingdom, that ye may acquire innate courage and ideal power.”<sup>180</sup>**

And, regarding the ends towards which we should exercise courage, we read the following:

**“Valiant acts will ensure the triumph of this Cause, and a saintly character will reinforce its power.”<sup>181</sup>**

**“O ye servants of the Sacred Threshold! The triumphant hosts of the Celestial Concourse, arrayed and marshaled in the Realms above, stand ready and expectant to assist and assure victory to that valiant horseman who with confidence spurs on his charger into the arena of service. Well is it with that fearless warrior, who armed with the power of true Knowledge, hastens unto the field, disperses the armies of ignorance, and scatters the hosts of error, who holds aloft the Standard of Divine Guidance, and sounds the Clarion of Victory. By the righteousness of the Lord! He hath achieved a glorious triumph and obtained the true victory.”<sup>182</sup>**

Manifesting courage and remaining steadfast in the Faith requires overcoming fear:

**“Whatever decreaseth fear increaseth courage.”<sup>183</sup>**

And it is the fear of God that eliminates all other kinds of fear:

**“And he that feareth not God, God shall make him to fear all things; whereas all things fear him who feareth God.”<sup>184</sup>**

Acts of courage are not carried out mindlessly. Courage needs to be modified by wisdom; our valiant acts are to be guided by the light of divine teachings. We read, for example, that our efforts to share with others gems of guidance from the writings should be

**“tempered with wisdom—not that wisdom which requireth one to be silent and forgetful of such an obligation, but rather that which requireth one to display divine tolerance, love, kindness, patience, a goodly character, and holy deeds.”<sup>185</sup>**

And we also read:

**“‘Not everything that a man knoweth can be disclosed, nor can everything that he can disclose be regarded as timely, nor can every timely utterance be considered as suited to the capacity of those who hear it.’ Such is the consummate wisdom to be observed in thy pursuits. Be not oblivious thereof, if thou wishest to be a man of action under all conditions.”<sup>186</sup>**

We will not attain true wisdom without the fear of God, the knowledge of God, and the recognition of His Manifestations:

**“Know ye that true wisdom is to fear God, to know Him, and to recognize His Manifestations. This wisdom, however, can be attained only by those who detach themselves from the world, and who walk in the ways of the good pleasure of their Lord.”<sup>187</sup>**

**“Say: The beginning of Wisdom and the origin thereof is to acknowledge whatsoever God hath clearly set forth . . .”<sup>188</sup>**

**“... whatsoever the universal Manifestation of God says and does is the very essence of wisdom and conformable to reality.”<sup>189</sup>**

Wisdom springs from the soil of a pure heart:

**“... sow the seeds of wisdom and knowledge in the pure soil of the heart, and keep them hidden, till the hyacinths of divine wisdom spring from the heart and not from mire and clay.”<sup>190</sup>**

Consultation and compassion increase the light of wisdom:

**“The Great Being saith: The heaven of divine wisdom is illumined with the two luminaries of consultation and compassion.”<sup>191</sup>**

In the absence of humility, courage can lead to pride and arrogance. True humility comes from humility before God and recognition that He is the source of power, perfection, and knowledge. Servitude to God is expressed in service to the Cause and to our fellow human beings:

**“O Son of Man! Humble thyself before Me, that I may graciously visit thee.”<sup>192</sup>**

**“Humility exalteth man to the heaven of glory and power, whilst pride abaseth him to the depths of wretchedness and degradation.”<sup>193</sup>**

**“Servitude to God lieth in servitude to the friends. One must be the essence of humility and the embodiment of meekness. One must become evanescence itself and be healed of every disease of the self, in order to become worthy of thralldom to the Threshold of the Almighty.”<sup>194</sup>**

**“Man’s greatness lieth in humility, and his abiding glory is found in lowliness, self-effacement, and servitude to the servants of the Lord. This, verily, is the greatest attainment in this resplendent Day.”<sup>195</sup>**

**“Act ye in such wise, showing forth pure and goodly deeds, and modesty and humility, that ye will cause others to be awakened.”<sup>196</sup>**

It is with humility that we turn to God, seeking from Him knowledge, understanding, wisdom, courage, and the strength to serve Him and His servants:

**“O Lord, my God! Give me Thy grace to serve Thy loved ones, strengthen me in my servitude to Thee, illumine my brow with the light of adoration in Thy court of holiness, and of prayer to Thy kingdom of grandeur. Help me to be selfless at the heavenly entrance of Thy gate, and aid me to be detached from all things within Thy holy precincts. Lord! Give me to drink from the chalice of selflessness; with its robe clothe me, and in its ocean immerse me. Make me as dust in the pathway of Thy loved ones, and grant that I may offer up my soul for the earth ennobled by the footsteps of Thy chosen ones in Thy path, O Lord of Glory in the Highest.”<sup>197</sup>**

1. Courage is often equated with mere acts of bravery in the face of danger, and sometimes it is associated with ill-perceived heroism, aimed at achieving unseemly or even cruel ends. In this connection, we are reminded of these words of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá: “Consider the ignorance and inconsistency of the human race. If a man kills another, no matter what the cause may be, he is pronounced a murderer, imprisoned or executed; but the brutal oppressor who has slain one hundred thousand is idolized as a hero, conqueror or military genius.” A different picture of courage, however, comes to our mind when we recall that its source is the promotion of the Word of God and steadfastness in His love. To reflect on the valor of those who labor in the field of service, fill in the blanks in the following sentence, drawn from one of the quotations we read above:

Well is it with that \_\_\_\_\_, who armed with the \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_, hastens unto the \_\_\_\_\_, disperses the \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_, and scatters the \_\_\_\_\_, who holds aloft the \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_, and sounds the \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_.

2. Children of today need to acquire courage so that, as they grow into youth and adults, they will be able to meet the three challenges we discussed earlier in the unit: to manage their personal and collective affairs with rectitude of conduct, to lead lives distinguished by their purity, and to build environments of unity in their homes and in the community. This becomes especially clear when we are reminded that the power and influence of the destructive forces operating in society, as described by the Guardian below, are increasing with every passing day.

**“The recrudescence of religious intolerance, of racial animosity, and of patriotic arrogance; the increasing evidences of selfishness, of suspicion, of fear and of fraud; the spread of terrorism, of lawlessness, of drunkenness and of crime; the unquenchable thirst for, and the feverish pursuit after, earthly vanities, riches and pleasures; the weakening of family solidarity; the laxity in parental control; the lapse into luxurious indulgence; the irresponsible attitude towards marriage and the consequent rising tide of divorce; the degeneracy of art and music, the infection of literature, and the corruption of the press; the extension of the influence and activities of those ‘prophets of decadence’ who advocate companionate marriage, who preach the philosophy of nudism, who call modesty an intellectual fiction, who refuse to regard the procreation of children as the sacred and primary purpose of marriage, who denounce religion as an opiate of the people, who would, if given free rein, lead back the human race to barbarism, chaos, and ultimate extinction—these appear as the outstanding characteristics of a decadent society, a society that must either be reborn or perish.”<sup>198</sup>**

In light of the above, discuss what shape courage would need to take, if an individual is to be capable of each of the following:

- Managing personal and community affairs with rectitude of conduct: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - Leading a pure life: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
  - Building environments of unity at home and in the community: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. Fear of God eliminates all other fears. What are some fears that are eliminated by courage—a courage born out of fearing nothing except that which may displease God? A few examples are provided below.
- The fear of being rejected for our beliefs \_\_\_\_\_
  - The fear of being ridiculed for our convictions \_\_\_\_\_

- The fear of exhibiting weaknesses and frailties
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_
- \_\_\_\_\_

4. We naturally associate wisdom with people who, through long years of learning and experience, have gained many a valuable insight into reality. But children, too, can be assisted in manifesting wisdom. Bahá'u'lláh says: “We beg of God to assist the children of His loved ones and adorn them with wisdom, good conduct, integrity and righteousness.” How, we should ask, are the seeds of wisdom to be planted in the pure hearts of the young? To reflect on this question, consider the list below. Towards which of these should children be encouraged?

- \_\_\_\_\_ Acting and speaking as though they are equal in knowledge and experience to adults
- \_\_\_\_\_ Listening to the wisdom of those with experience and knowledge
- \_\_\_\_\_ Expressing opinions about everything, even matters they know little about
- \_\_\_\_\_ Reflecting on the meaning of sentences and phrases from the Holy Texts
- \_\_\_\_\_ Just listening and being quiet all the time
- \_\_\_\_\_ Learning the value of silence and when one needs to observe it
- \_\_\_\_\_ Expressing thoughts, when appropriate, with humility
- \_\_\_\_\_ Showing forth patience under difficult circumstances
- \_\_\_\_\_ Learning to turn to the Word of God for guidance on all matters
- \_\_\_\_\_ Learning detachment from all save God
- \_\_\_\_\_ Learning to be compassionate
- \_\_\_\_\_ Showing forth courage in speaking about the teachings of the Faith
- \_\_\_\_\_ Seeking attention and praise in displaying their talents

5. To reflect on the quality of humility, complete the following sentences on the basis of the relevant quotations above:

- a. When we humble ourselves before God, He will \_\_\_\_\_ .

- b. Humility \_\_\_\_\_ us to the heaven of glory and power, while pride \_\_\_\_\_ us to the \_\_\_\_\_ .
- c. Servitude to \_\_\_\_\_ lies in servitude to \_\_\_\_\_ .
- d. We must be the \_\_\_\_\_ and the \_\_\_\_\_ .
- e. We must become \_\_\_\_\_ and be healed of \_\_\_\_\_ , in order to become worthy of \_\_\_\_\_ .
- f. Our greatness lies in \_\_\_\_\_ .
- g. Our abiding glory is found in \_\_\_\_\_ .
- h. We should act in such wise, showing forth \_\_\_\_\_ , and \_\_\_\_\_ , that we will cause \_\_\_\_\_ .

6. Reflecting on the above sentences helps us increase our understanding of the meaning of true humility. Can you think of some misconceptions that run counter to this understanding and that would undermine efforts to help the young ones in a community develop humility? Two examples have been provided.

Praise and recognition lead to greatness.

Humility indicates a sense of inferiority and weakness.

7. All spiritual qualities benefit from the exercise of wisdom and humility. We may speak truthfully, but without wisdom and humility, we could hurt the heart of our listener. To reflect on this idea, complete the following sentences:

Truthfulness without wisdom and humility can lead to \_\_\_\_\_

Acts of generosity without humility can lead to \_\_\_\_\_



Love without wisdom and humility can lead to \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

8. In striving to acquire true humility and help the young ones to aspire towards it, we should be aware of the dangers of false humility, on the one hand, and of pride, on the other. Discuss the following questions:
- a. What is false humility and in what sense is it an indication of pride?
  - b. Why is it that we cannot acquire true humility without humbling ourselves before God?
  - c. How does humility safeguard against self-righteousness?
9. Having had a chance to reflect carefully on the ideas above, write a paragraph that describes how humility, courage, and wisdom are interrelated.

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## SECTION 19

The two couples and Maribel feel grateful for the valuable insights they have gained both from their own exploration of various themes in light of the teachings and from the conversations they have had with families and individuals in their community. Of course, there are other concepts related to education that could be the subject of deliberation among a growing number of interested people. However, for now, they have decided to conclude this series of conversations with one final idea.

Family is one of the structures that lends stability to a community and promotes social harmony. In fact, it is the most fundamental. The nature of the interactions within it, the way it conducts its affairs, and the habits learned by its members—these extend beyond the family unit and determine the character of any civilization that is to emerge.

The education of children is a “sacred obligation” but also a sacred privilege, and parents no doubt hope to see their children grow to “become, in a not distant future, devoted servants and champions of the Cause.” A letter written on behalf of Shoghi Effendi states:

**“What a more sacred privilege, and also what a weightier responsibility than the task of rearing up the new generation of believers, and of inculcating into their youthful and receptive minds the principles and Teachings of the Cause, and of thus preparing them to fully assume, and properly discharge, the weighty responsibilities and obligations of their future life in the Bahá’í Community.”<sup>199</sup>**

We know that within the ocean of Bahá’u’lláh’s Revelation lie those gems of wisdom needed to free the human spirit, enabling it to soar to ever greater heights. Here, too, are found, the Universal House of Justice tells us, those “enduring ideals in whose light parents may raise children not simply in their own likeness, but with aspirations more exalted.” The task of educating the young according to the standards of the Faith is not a simple one, and at times it may even seem daunting. Undoubtedly, as we try to apply, in all humility, the insights we gain from the teachings on this subject, we will be able to modify our ways and employ approaches that are more effective. But, in the final analysis, it is to God that we entrust our children, realizing that all depends on His wondrous grace and bounty. The House of Justice, in a letter written on its behalf to an individual, says:

**“In parenthood, as in so many fields of endeavor, we can but do our best, aware that we shall inevitably fall short of the perfect standards towards which we strive, but confident that God will support those who labor in the path of His Faith, will answer our prayers and will make good our deficiencies.”<sup>200</sup>**

To reflect on the privilege and joy that belong to those who contribute to the education of the young, read the following passages:

**“O ye two servants at the Holy Threshold! We have been greatly cheered and refreshed to know that ye have organized meetings for the education of children. Whoso is active in those meetings whether as a teacher of the children or a sponsor, will certainly become the recipient of confirmations from the invisible Realm, and endless bounties will compass him about.**

**“With great joy, therefore, encouragement is offered for this highly laudable endeavor that ye may witness an exceeding great reward.**

**“Await ye the sure and certain confirmations of the All-Merciful.”<sup>201</sup>**

**“O thou steadfast in the Covenant! Your letter hath come and imparted great delight, with its word that, praised be God, the youth of the Abhá paradise are verdant and tender, from showers scattered out of clouds of heavenly grace; that they thrive and flourish in the April rains of heavenly guidance, and are progressing day by day.**

**“It is certain that each and every one of them will grow to be as a banner of guidance, a symbol of the bestowals that come from the Realm of the All-Glorious. They will be sweet-singing nightingales in the gardens of knowledge, gazelles delicate and comely, roaming the plains of the love of God. You must attach the greatest importance to the**

**education of children, for this is the foundation of the Law of God, and the bedrock of the edifice of His Faith.**

**“If it were known how much joy you have imparted through what hath been done for the children, the believers would surely educate all their children in the same way.”<sup>202</sup>**

**“Tend the young trees of the Abhá Paradise with the welling waters of His grace and peace and joy. Make them to flourish under the downpour of His bounty. Strive with all thy powers that the children may stand out and grow fresh, delicate, and sweet, like the ideal trees in the gardens of Heaven. All these gifts and bounties depend upon love for the Beauty of the All-Glorious, and on the blessings in the teachings of the Most High, and the spiritual instructions of the Supreme Concourse, and on ecstasy and ardor and diligent pursuit of whatsoever will redound to the eternal honor of the community of man.”<sup>203</sup>**

**“O thou who art steadfast in the Covenant! Thou hast exerted strenuous efforts for the education of children and I have been, and am, infinitely pleased with thee. Praise God, thou hast been enabled to serve in this field, and it is certain that the confirmations of the Abhá Kingdom will encompass thee, and thou shalt achieve prosperity and success. Today the training and education of the believers’ children is the preeminent goal of the chosen. It is the same as servitude to the Sacred Threshold and waiting upon the Blessed Beauty. Joyously, therefore, canst thou pride thyself on this.”<sup>204</sup>**

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- <sup>89</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 6 July 1912, *ibid.*, par. 2–3, pp. 315–16. (authorized translation)
- <sup>90</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 156.10, pp. 257–58.
- <sup>91</sup> *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá’u’lláh*, CXXXVII, par. 4, p. 338; also cited by Shoghi Effendi, *The Advent of Divine Justice* (Wilmette: Bahá’í Publishing Trust, 2006, 2018 printing), par. 39, p. 35.
- <sup>92</sup> From a Tablet revealed by Bahá’u’lláh, in *Trustworthiness: A Compilation of Extracts from the Bahá’í Writings*, compiled by the Research Department of the Universal House of Justice (London: Bahá’í Publishing Trust, 1987), no. 21, p. 5; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations* (Maryborough: Bahá’í Publications Australia, 1991), vol. 2, no. 2032, p. 332.
- <sup>93</sup> *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá’u’lláh*, CIX, par. 2, p. 243; also in the compilation *Social Action*, no. 22, p. 9.
- <sup>94</sup> ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, *The Secret of Divine Civilization*, par. 6, pp. 6–7; also in the compilation *Social Action*, no. 13, p. 4.
- <sup>95</sup> *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá’u’lláh*, CXVII, par. 1, p. 282; also in “Lawḥ-i-Maqṣúd” [Tablet of Maqṣúd], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 11.12, p. 205; also in the compilation *Social Action*, no. 8, pp. 2–3.
- <sup>96</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 11 June 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 4, p. 261.
- <sup>97</sup> Bahá’u’lláh, cited by Shoghi Effendi, *The Advent of Divine Justice*, par. 48, p. 47.
- <sup>98</sup> From a letter dated 25 December 1941 written on behalf of Shoghi Effendi to the Bahá’ís of Hobart, Australia, in *Bahá’í Education*, no. 145, p. 58; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 1, no. 678, p. 305.
- <sup>99</sup> From a letter dated 24 April 2018 written on behalf of the Universal House of Justice to a National Spiritual Assembly.

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- <sup>100</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 221.9, p. 385.
- <sup>101</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 25 May 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 3, p. 200; also in *Family Life*, no. 86, p. 67.
- <sup>102</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 2 June 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 15, pp. 232–33; also in *Family Life*, no. 80, p. 59.
- <sup>103</sup> From a letter dated 24 January 1993 written on behalf of the Universal House of Justice to an individual, in *Family Life*, no. 78, p. 57.
- <sup>104</sup> From a letter dated 25 July 1988 written on behalf of the Universal House of Justice to an individual, *ibid.*, no. 75, p. 53.
- <sup>105</sup> From a message dated 24 November 2009 of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá’ís of Iran, par. 2, published on Bahá’í Reference Library ([www.bahai.org](http://www.bahai.org)).
- <sup>106</sup> From the Riḍván 2013 message of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá’ís of the world, published in *Framework for Action*, no. 24.6, p. 164.
- <sup>107</sup> From a message dated 2 March 2013 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá’ís in Iran, *ibid.*, no. 23.13, p. 155.
- <sup>108</sup> From a Tablet to the Bahá’ís of the Southern States, published in *Tablets of the Divine Plan: Revealed by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá to the North American Bahá’ís* (Wilmette: Bahá’í Publishing Trust, 1993, 2006 printing), no. 10.13, p. 73; also in *Bahá’í Prayers*, p. 210.
- <sup>109</sup> From “Ṭarázát” [Ornaments], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 4.7, p. 34.
- <sup>110</sup> From a message dated 28 December 2010 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, published in *Framework for Action*, no. 16.32, p. 112.
- <sup>111</sup> *The Hidden Words*, Arabic no. 2, pp. 3–4.
- <sup>112</sup> From “Aṣḥ-i-Kullu’l-Khayr” [Words of Wisdom], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 10.22, p. 194.
- <sup>113</sup> From “Bishárát” [Glad-Tidings], *ibid.*, no. 3.23, p. 27.
- <sup>114</sup> *Epistle to the Son of the Wolf*, p. 32.
- <sup>115</sup> From “Kalimát-i-Firdawsíyyih” [Words of Paradise], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 6.25, p. 75; also in the compilation *Social Action*, no. 32, p. 16.
- <sup>116</sup> *Epistle to the Son of the Wolf*, pp. 28–29; also in the compilation *Social Action*, no. 34, p. 17.
- <sup>117</sup> From “Kalimát-i-Firdawsíyyih” [Words of Paradise], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 6.15, p. 69.
- <sup>118</sup> From a Tablet to Mírzá Abu’l-Faḍl, published in *The Tabernacle of Unity: Bahá’u’lláh’s Responses to Mánikchí Sháhí and Other Writings* (Haifa: Bahá’í World Centre, 2006), no. 2.60, p. 54.
- <sup>119</sup> From “Kalimát-i-Firdawsíyyih” [Words of Paradise], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 6.19, pp. 71–72.
- <sup>120</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 138.1, p. 220.
- <sup>121</sup> *Ibid.*, no. 35.8, p. 104.
- <sup>122</sup> *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá’u’lláh*, CXXXVI, par. 6, p. 336.
- <sup>123</sup> From a Tablet revealed by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in *Trustworthiness*, no. 42, p. 12; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 2, no. 2053, p. 338.
- <sup>124</sup> Bahá’u’lláh, cited by Shoghi Effendi, *The Advent of Divine Justice*, par. 39, p. 35.
- <sup>125</sup> From the Riḍván 2008 message of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá’ís of the world, published in *Framework for Action*, no. 10.8, p. 64.



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- <sup>126</sup> From a Tablet revealed by Bahá'u'lláh, in *Trustworthiness*, no. 34, pp. 8–9; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 2, no. 2045, p. 335.
- <sup>127</sup> From a Tablet revealed by Bahá'u'lláh, in *Trustworthiness*, no. 28, p. 7; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 2, no. 2039, p. 334.
- <sup>128</sup> *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 110.1, pp. 189–90.
- <sup>129</sup> *The Hidden Words*, Arabic no. 1, p. 3.
- <sup>130</sup> *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 129.2, p. 204.
- <sup>131</sup> *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, CXXXVI, par. 5, p. 336.
- <sup>132</sup> *The Hidden Words*, Arabic no. 59, p. 17.
- <sup>133</sup> From a talk given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá on 14 April 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 4, p. 19.
- <sup>134</sup> From a talk given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá on 26 May 1912, *ibid.*, par. 1, p. 204.
- <sup>135</sup> From a talk given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá on 25 July 1912, *ibid.*, par. 3, pp. 341–42.
- <sup>136</sup> From a talk given by 'Abdu'l-Bahá on 24 April 1912, *ibid.*, par. 2, p. 72.
- <sup>137</sup> *The Hidden Words*, Persian no. 42, p. 36.
- <sup>138</sup> *Ibid.*, Persian no. 69, p. 46.
- <sup>139</sup> From “Kalimát-i-Firdawsíyyih” [Words of Paradise], published in *Tablets of Bahá'u'lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 6.30, p. 78.
- <sup>140</sup> *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, CX, par. 1, p. 245; also in “Lawḥ-i-Maqṣúd” [Tablet of Maqṣúd], published in *Tablets of Bahá'u'lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 11.18, p. 208.
- <sup>141</sup> From “Lawḥ-i-Ḥikmat” [Tablet of Wisdom], published in *Tablets of Bahá'u'lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 9.20, p. 177.
- <sup>142</sup> Bahá'u'lláh, in *The Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, par. 123, p. 65; also in *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, CLIX, par. 2, p. 381.
- <sup>143</sup> Bahá'u'lláh, in *The Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, par. 159, p. 78.
- <sup>144</sup> From “Kalimát-i-Firdawsíyyih” [Words of Paradise], published in *Tablets of Bahá'u'lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 6.17, p. 70.
- <sup>145</sup> Bahá'u'lláh, cited by Shoghi Effendi, *The Advent of Divine Justice*, par. 39, pp. 34–35.
- <sup>146</sup> *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh*, CXXXI, par. 3, p. 324.
- <sup>147</sup> From a message dated 28 December 2010 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, published in *Framework for Action*, no. 16.33, pp. 112–13.
- <sup>148</sup> *Ibid.*, p. 113.
- <sup>149</sup> Shoghi Effendi, *The Advent of Divine Justice*, par. 37, p. 33.
- <sup>150</sup> Bahá'u'lláh, *Gems of Divine Mysteries: Javáhiru'l-Asrár* (Haifa: Bahá'í World Centre, 2002, 2007 printing), par. 81, p. 59.
- <sup>151</sup> *The Call of the Divine Beloved: Selected Mystical Works of Bahá'u'lláh* (Haifa: Bahá'í World Centre, 2018), no. 2.43, p. 31.
- <sup>152</sup> From a Tablet dated 17 December 1919 addressed by 'Abdu'l-Bahá to the Central Organization for a Durable Peace, The Hague, par. 11, published on Bahá'í Reference Library ([www.bahai.org](http://www.bahai.org)); also in *Selections from the Writings of 'Abdu'l-Bahá*, no. 227.11, p. 413.
- <sup>153</sup> From the Riḍván 2008 message of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá'ís of the world, published in *Framework for Action*, no. 10.8, p. 64.
- <sup>154</sup> From a message dated 24 November 2009 written by the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá'ís in Iran, par. 4, published on Bahá'í Reference Library ([www.bahai.org](http://www.bahai.org)).

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- <sup>155</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 111.1, p. 191.
- <sup>156</sup> From the Riḍván 2010 message of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá’ís of the world, published in *Framework for Action*, no. 14.29, p. 89.
- <sup>157</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 202.3, pp. 341–42.
- <sup>158</sup> From an undated talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, published in *Paris Talks*, no. 40.8, p. 160.
- <sup>159</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 29 August 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 9, pp. 409–10.
- <sup>160</sup> *The Hidden Words*, Arabic no. 68, p. 20.
- <sup>161</sup> Bahá’u’lláh, cited in a letter dated 27 March 1978 written on behalf of the Universal House of Justice to all National Spiritual Assemblies, published in *Messages from the Universal House of Justice, 1963–1986: The Third Epoch of the Formative Age* (Wilmette: Bahá’í Publishing Trust, 1996), no. 206.3a–206.3b, pp. 376–77.
- <sup>162</sup> From “Kalimát-i-Firdawsíyyih” [Words of Paradise], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 6.26, p. 76.
- <sup>163</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 8.7, p. 38.
- <sup>164</sup> *Ibid.*, no. 1.3, p. 6.
- <sup>165</sup> ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, cited in a letter dated 28 November 1931 written by Shoghi Effendi to the Bahá’ís of the West, published in *The World Order of Bahá’u’lláh: Selected Letters* (Wilmette: Bahá’í Publishing Trust, 1991, 2012 printing), p. 36; also cited by Shoghi Effendi, *The Promised Day Is Come* (Wilmette: Bahá’í Publishing Trust, 1996, 2018 printing), par. 292, p. 195.
- <sup>166</sup> From a letter dated 28 November 1931 written by Shoghi Effendi to the Bahá’ís of the West, published in *The World Order of Bahá’u’lláh*, pp. 41–42.
- <sup>167</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 77.1, p. 161.
- <sup>168</sup> *Light of the World: Selected Tablets of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá* (Haifa: Bahá’í World Centre, 2021), no. 4.4, pp. 9–10.
- <sup>169</sup> From “Lawḥ-i-Maqṣúd” [Tablet of Maqṣúd], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 11.5, p. 200; also in *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá’u’lláh*, CXII, par. 1, pp. 247–48.
- <sup>170</sup> *‘Abdu’l-Bahá in London: Addresses and Notes of Conversations* (London: Bahá’í Publishing Trust, 1987), p. 91.
- <sup>171</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 13 May 1912, published in *The Promulgation of Universal Peace*, par. 4, p. 172.
- <sup>172</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 30 April 1912, *ibid.*, par. 4, p. 94.
- <sup>173</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 6 November 1912, *ibid.*, par. 6, p. 553.
- <sup>174</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 1 September 1912, *ibid.*, par. 6, p. 416.
- <sup>175</sup> From the Riḍván 2008 message of the Universal House of Justice to the Bahá’ís of the world, published in *Framework for Action*, no. 10.8, p. 64.
- <sup>176</sup> From a talk given by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá on 14 November 1911, published in *Paris Talks*, no. 50.10, pp. 202–3.
- <sup>177</sup> From a Tablet revealed by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá to the Bahá’ís of the Central States, published in *Tablets of the Divine Plan*, no. 11.11, p. 79.
- <sup>178</sup> From a message dated 8 January 2000 written by the Universal House of Justice to the friends gathered at the youth congress in Paraguay, published in *Turning Point*, no. 20.5, p. 124.
- <sup>179</sup> From “Aṣḥ-i-Kullu’l-Khayr” [Words of Wisdom], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 10.10, p. 192.

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- <sup>180</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 179.1, p. 285.
- <sup>181</sup> From “Lawḥ-i-Dunyá” [Tablet of the World], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 7.10, p. 100; also in *Gleanings from the Writings of Bahá’u’lláh*, XLIII, par. 4, p. 105.
- <sup>182</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 208.1, pp. 365–66.
- <sup>183</sup> *Epistle to the Son of the Wolf*, p. 32.
- <sup>184</sup> *The Call of the Divine Beloved*, no. 7.30, p. 95.
- <sup>185</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 213.1, p. 371.
- <sup>186</sup> *Ibid.*, no. 214.2, p. 372.
- <sup>187</sup> From “Súriy-i-Mulúk” [Súrih of the Kings], published in *The Summons of the Lord of Hosts: Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh* (Wilmette: Bahá’í Publishing, 2006), par. 113, p. 342–43.
- <sup>188</sup> From “Lawḥ-i-Ḥikmat” [Tablet of Wisdom], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 9.42, p. 188.
- <sup>189</sup> ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in *Some Answered Questions*, no. 45.5, p. 198.
- <sup>190</sup> *The Hidden Words*, Persian no. 36, p. 35.
- <sup>191</sup> From “Lawḥ-i-Maqṣúd” [Tablet of Maqṣúd], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 11.15, p. 207.
- <sup>192</sup> *The Hidden Words*, Arabic no. 42, p. 13.
- <sup>193</sup> From “Kalimát-i-Firdawsíyyih” [Words of Paradise], published in *Tablets of Bahá’u’lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas*, no. 6.19, p. 72; also in *Epistle to the Son of the Wolf*, p. 30.
- <sup>194</sup> *Muntakhabátí az Makátib-i-Ḥaḍrat-i-‘Abdu’l-Bahá* [Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá] (Haifa: Bahá’í World Centre, 1984), vol. 2, no. 156, p. 118 (authorized translation); also in the “Compilation for the 2018 Counsellors’ Conference”, no. 8, published on Bahá’í Reference Library ([www.bahai.org](http://www.bahai.org)).
- <sup>195</sup> *Light of the World: Selected Tablets of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 76.4, p. 205.
- <sup>196</sup> *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 174.5, p. 282.
- <sup>197</sup> ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in *Bahá’í Prayers*, p. 328; also in *Selections from the Writings of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá*, no. 237.5, p. 442.
- <sup>198</sup> From a letter dated 11 March 1936 written by Shoghi Effendi to the Bahá’ís of the West, published in *The World Order of Bahá’u’lláh*, pp. 187–88.
- <sup>199</sup> From a letter dated 28 April 1939 written on behalf of Shoghi Effendi to an individual, in *Bahá’í Education*, no. 138, p. 55; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 1, no. 671, p. 302.
- <sup>200</sup> From a letter dated 29 March 1982 written on behalf of the Universal House of Justice to an individual, in *Family Life*, no. 69, p. 47.
- <sup>201</sup> From a Tablet revealed by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in *Bahá’í Education*, no. 54, p. 21; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 1, no. 602, p. 268.
- <sup>202</sup> From a Tablet revealed by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in “Bahá’í Education”, published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 1, no. 604, pp. 268–69.
- <sup>203</sup> From a Tablet revealed by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in *Bahá’í Education*, no. 64, pp. 24–25; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 1, no. 612, p. 273.
- <sup>204</sup> From a Tablet revealed by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, in *Bahá’í Education*, no. 67, pp. 25–26; also published in *The Compilation of Compilations*, vol. 1, no. 615, p. 274.